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Zechariah

Zechariah - Introduction

Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of the Book of Zechariah

1. Zechariah calls the returning nation of Israel to repent and return to Yahweh (1:1–6)
2. The eight night visions (1:7–6:8)
3. Yahweh sends his messengers throughout the whole earth (1:7–17)
4. Four horns and four craftsmen (1:18–21)
5. The measuring line (2:1–13)
6. The priest in filthy clothes (3:1–10)
7. The golden lampstand olive trees (4:1–14)
8. The flying scroll (5:1–4)
9. The woman in a basket (5:5–11)
10. Four chariots (6:1–8)
11. A crown for the high priest (6:9–15)
12. Questions about fasting (7:1–8:23)
13. Yahweh judge the nations and saves his people (9:1–11:17)
14. Final message (12:1–14:21)
15. Yahweh will finally defeat Israel's enemies (12:1–9)
16. Israel mourns for the one they pierced (12:10–14)
17. Yahweh purifies Israel and removes false prophets (13:1–6)
18. Yahweh comes as king (14:1–21)

Literary Structure
Many interpreters see Zechariah organized using chiasms—mirrored patterns where the beginning and end match, then the second and second-to-last parts match, and so on. Three larger sections show this design: the eight night visions (1:7–6:15), the two fasting messages (7:1–8:23), and the closing oracles (chapters 9–14). Smaller chiasms also appear within individual passages, such as 1:14–17 and 8:9–13.

What is the Book of Zechariah about?
Zechariah wrote to the people of Judah who returned from being exiled in Babylon. The people of Judah continued to sin, as their ancestors did before they went into exile. Zechariah called the people to repent and to obey Yahweh. And he called them to renew the covenant with Yahweh. Zechariah also prophesied about the Messiah and about Israel finally being victorious over her enemies.

How should the title of this book be translated?
This book traditionally has been titled "Zechariah" or "The Book of Zechariah." Translators may decide to call it the "The Book About Zechariah" or "The Sayings of Zechariah."

Who wrote the Book of Zechariah?
The prophet Zechariah wrote this book between 520 and 518 B.C.

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

Did Zechariah prophesy before Ezra, Nehemiah, and Haggai?
Zechariah prophesied before the time of Ezra and Nehemiah. He prophesied at the same time as Haggai and continued after Haggai.

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

What is the meaning of the term "Israel"?
The name "Israel" is used in many different ways in the Bible. Jacob was a son of Isaac. God changed Jacob's name to Israel. The descendants of Jacob became a nation also called Israel. Eventually, the nation of Israel split into two kingdoms. The northern kingdom was named Israel. The southern kingdom was named Judah. Zechariah uses the term "Israel" to refer to both the nation of Israel and the northern kingdom of Israel.

What imagery does Zechariah use in reference to the Messiah?
Zechariah presented the Messiah as both a king and a shepherd. Zechariah said that the Messiah would come and deliver his people. However, the Messiah would also be pierced (12:10) and struck with the sword (13:7).

What does the phrase "that day" mean?
Zechariah often spoke of the last days by using the phrase "that day" or "in that day." When referring to a future "day," the translator should be aware that the author may be speaking about the last days. If your language wouldn't use the repetition of "on that day" for stylistic emphasis, find a natural way to do it in your language.

Zechariah - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is written in prose with imagery used throughout to portray Zechariah's vision given by the Lord.

Some translations prefer to set apart quotations. The ULT and many other English translations set lines 1:3–6, 14–17, which are extended quotations, farther to the right on the page than the rest of the text.

The Eight Night-Visions as a Chiasm
Chapters 1:7–6:8 present eight visions arranged in a mirrored (chiastic) pattern: patrolling horses (1:7–17) match the closing chariot vision (6:1–8); the horns that scattered Judah (1:18–21) match the removal of wickedness in the basket vision (5:5–11); Jerusalem without walls (2:1–5) matches the scroll of judgment (5:1–4); and Joshua reclothed (3:1–10) matches the two anointed leaders, Joshua and Zerubbabel (4:1–14). This chapter contains the first two panels of that pattern.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Visions
This book contains a number of visions given to Zechariah. The images are not ones Zechariah actually saw; rather, they were given to him in a vision or dream. It is important for each of these visions to keep their given meanings and not be interpreted to mean any specific thing.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Date
Zechariah uses two separate dates in this first chapter. When compared to the book of Haggai, Zechariah's prophecy was proclaimed just a few weeks after the prophecy of Haggai. However, the two men prophesied in two different places: Haggai was in Jerusalem, and Zechariah was somewhere outside of Jerusalem.

Zechariah 1:1 (#1)

בַּחֹדֶשׁ הַשְּׁמִינִי בִּשְׁנַת שְׁתַּיִם לְדָרְיָוֶשׁ

"In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius"

If your language would not represent numbers in a form such as **eighth** and **second**, you could represent these numbers in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [In month eight in year two of Darius]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 1:1 (#2)

הָיָה דְבַר־יְהוָה אֶל־זְכַרְיָהוּ

"the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah"

Zechariah is using **the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah** as a common expression of the culture to mean "Yahweh communicated a message to Zechariah." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh spoke his message to Zechariah] or [Yahweh gave his message to Zechariah]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 1:1 (#3)

בַּחֹדֶשׁ הַשְּׁמִינִי בִּשְׁנַת שְׁתַּיִם לְדָרְיָוֶשׁ

"In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius"

Zechariah is using the phrase **In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius** to introduce a new event in the story (in this case, the very beginning). Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 1:2 (#1)

קָצַף & קֶצֶף

"was angry {with} anger"

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [was extremely angry]

See: Poetry

Zechariah 1:3 (#1)

וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

"And you shall say to them, 'Thus says Yahweh of Armies"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And you shall tell them that Yahweh of Armies says this]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Zechariah 1:3 (#2)

שׁוּבוּ אֵלָי

"Return to me"

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the people's relationship with him were a place that they had physically left and could physically come back to. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [Be faithful to me again] or [Renew your commitment to me]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 1:3 (#3)

נְאֻם יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

The term **the declaration of Yahweh of Armies** introduces a parenthetical affirmation of the source of this direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating the authoritative source of direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 1:3 (#4)

שׁוּבוּ אֵלַי & וְאָשׁוּבָה אֲלֵיכֶם

“Return to me & and I will return to you”

Here, **Return to me** introduces the first part of a possible condition. Yahweh will only do the thing in the second part, **and I will return to you**, if this condition happens. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [If you return to me, then I will return to you]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Zechariah 1:3 (#5)

וְאָשׁוּבָה אֲלֵיכֶם

“and I will return to you”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if his renewed favor toward the people were a physical movement back to them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will be favorable to you again] or [and I will bless you again]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 1:4 (#1)

מִדַּרְכֵיכֶם הָרָעִים ומעלליכם הָרָעִים

“from your evil ways and your evil deeds”

The terms **evil ways** and **evil deeds** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [from all of your evil conduct]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 1:4 (#2)

מִדַּרְכֵיכֶם הָרָעִים

“from your evil ways”

Yahweh is speaking of how the ancestors lived as if that were a **way** or path that they were walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from your evil behavior]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 1:4 (#3)

וְלֹא שָׁמְעוּ וְלֹא־הִקְשִׁיבוּ

“But they did not hear, and they did not pay attention”

Yahweh uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between what the former prophets told the ancestors to do and what the ancestors actually did. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, they did not hear, and they did not pay attention]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 1:4 (#4)

לֵאמֹר כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“saying, ‘Thus says Yahweh of Armies”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and told them that Yahweh of Armies had said to]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Zechariah 1:4 (#5)

וְלֹא שָׁמְעוּ וְלֹא־הִקְשִׁיבוּ אֵלָי

“But they did not hear, and they did not pay attention to me”

The terms **did not hear** and **did not pay attention** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [But they completely refused to obey me]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 1:5 (#1)

אֲבוֹתֵיכֶם אַיֵּה־הֵם

“Your fathers, where {are} they”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that the ancestors are dead. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your fathers are no longer alive.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 1:5 (#2)

וְהַנְּבִאִים הַלְעוֹלָם יִחְיוּ

“And the prophets, do they live forever”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that the prophets also died. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [And the prophets did not live forever either.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 1:6 (#1)

אַאַךְ ׀ דְּבָרַי וְחֻקַּי

“But my words and my statutes”

Yahweh uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the mortality of the fathers and prophets and the enduring effect of God’s words and statutes. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, my words and my statutes]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 1:6 (#2)

הֲלֹוא הִשִּׂיגוּ אֲבֹתֵיכֶם

“did they not overtake your fathers”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that his words certainly did overtake the ancestors. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [they certainly overtook your fathers.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 1:6 (#3)

דְּבָרַי וְחֻקַּי & הֲלֹוא הִשִּׂיגוּ אֲבֹתֵיכֶם

“my words and my statutes & did they not overtake your fathers”

Yahweh is speaking of **my words and my statutes** as if they were living things that could pursue and catch people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my words and my statutes, … did they not come true for your fathers]

See: Personification

Zechariah 1:6 (#4)

וַיָּשׁוּבוּ וַיֹּאמְרוּ

“And they returned and said”

The pronoun **they** refers to the ancestors, not to the words and statutes mentioned earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And your ancestors repented and said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 1:6 (#5)

כִּדְרָכֵינוּ וּכְמַעַלְלֵינוּ

“according to our ways and according to our deeds”

The ancestors are speaking of how they lived as if that were a **way** or path that they were walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to how we behaved and according to what we did]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 1:7 (#1)

בְּיוֹם ׀ עֶשְׂרִים וְאַרְבָּעָה

“On the twenty-fourth day”

Zechariah is using the phrase **On the twenty-fourth day** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 1:7 (#2)

בְּיוֹם ׀ עֶשְׂרִים וְאַרְבָּעָה לְעַשְׁתֵּי־עָשָׂר הוּא־חֹדֶשׁ שְׁ

“On the twenty-fourth day of the eleventh month”

Both **twenty-fourth** and **eleventh** are ordinal numbers. If your language would not represent a number in a ordinal form, you could represent this number in

a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [On day twenty-four of month eleven]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 1:7 (#3)

בִּשְׁנַ֣ת שְׁתַּ֔יִם לְדָרְיָ֖וֶשׁ

“in the second year of Darius”

The phrase **in the second year** uses an ordinal number. If your language would not represent a number in a form such as **second**, you could represent this number in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [in year two of the reign of Darius]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 1:7 (#4)

הָיָ֥ה דְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה אֶל־זְכַרְיָ֣הוּ

“the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah”

Zechariah is using **the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Yahweh communicated a message to Zechariah.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh spoke his message to Zechariah] or [Yahweh gave his message to Zechariah]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 1:7 (#5)

הַנָּבִ֛יא לֵאמֹ֖ר

“the prophet, saying”

The word **saying** normally introduces something Yahweh said. Here it introduces what Zechariah saw in a vision, which he describes in his own words starting in the next verse. If it would be unnatural in your language to use a speech word to introduce a vision, you could use a phrase that introduces a report or account instead, and you should not mark the vision as a quotation. Alternate translation: [the prophet. This is what Yahweh showed him:] or [the prophet, and this is what happened:]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 1:8 (#1)

רָאִ֣יתִי ׀ הַלַּ֗יְלָה וְהִנֵּ֞ה

“I saw in the night, and behold”

Zechariah is using the phrase **I saw in the night, and behold** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 1:8 (#2)

וְהִנֵּ֞ה

“and behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and I saw]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 1:10 (#1)

וַיַּ֣עַן & וַיֹּאמַ֔ר

“answered and said”

The terms **answered and said** together introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 1:10 (#2)

אֵ֖לֶּה

“These”

The pronoun **These** refers to the horses and their riders that Yahweh sent to patrol the earth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [These horses and riders]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 1:11 (#1)

וַיַּעֲנ֗וּ

“And they answered”

The pronoun **they** refers to the horse riders who had been patrolling the earth, described in verse 8. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the riders answered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 1:11 (#2)

וַיַּעֲנ֗וּ & וַיֹּאמְר֛וּ

“And they answered & and they said”

The terms **answered** and **said** together introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 1:11 (#3)

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ יֹשֶׁבֶת וְשֹׁקָטֶת

“all of the earth is sitting and is at rest”

The riders are speaking of **all of the earth** as if it were a living thing that could sit down and be quiet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the peoples of the earth are peaceful and calm]

See: Personification

Zechariah 1:12 (#1)

עַד־מָתַי אַתָּה֙ יְהוָ֔ה לֹ֥א תְרַחֵ֖ם אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַ֑͏ִם וְאֵ֛ת עָרֵ֥י יְהוּדָ֖ה אֲשֶׁ֥ר זָעַ֣מְתָּ זֶּ֔ה שִׁבְעִ֖ים שָׁנָֽה

“until when & not have compassion on Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah & these”

The angel of Yahweh is using the question form to urgently plead with God to show mercy. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please have compassion on Jerusalem and the cities of Judah with which you have been indignant these 70 years now!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 1:12 (#2)

אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַ֑͏ִם וְאֵ֛ת עָרֵ֥י יְהוּדָ֖ה

“on Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah”

Here, **Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah** represents the people who live in those places. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [on the people of Jerusalem and the people of the cities of Judah]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:13 (#1)

דְּבָרִ֖ים נִחֻמִֽים

“words of comfort”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **comfort**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [words that comforted him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 1:14 (#1)

קְרָ֣א לֵאמֹ֔ר כֹּ֥ה אָמַ֖ר יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֹ֑ות

“Call out, saying, ‘Thus says Yahweh of Armies”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Proclaim that Yahweh of Armies says this]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Zechariah 1:14 (#2)

קִנֵּ֥אתִי לִירוּשָׁלַ֖͏ִם וּלְצִיּ֑וֹן קִנְאָ֖ה גְּדוֹלָֽה

“I have been jealous for Jerusalem and for Zion {with} a great jealousy”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [I have been very zealous for Jerusalem and for Zion]

See: Poetry

Zechariah 1:14 (#3)

קִנְאָ֖ה גְּדוֹלָֽה

“with} a great jealousy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **jealousy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [indeed very jealous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 1:15 (#1)

וְקֶ֥צֶף גָּדוֹל֙ אֲנִ֣י קֹצֵ֔ף

“And {with} a great anger I, I am angry”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [And I am very, very angry]

See: Poetry

Zechariah 1:15 (#2)

אֲנִי֙ קָצַ֣פְתִּי & אֲנִ֔י קָצַ֖פְתִּי

“I, I am angry & I, I was angry”

The pronoun **I** is repeated for emphasis in both clauses. You could translate Yahweh’s emphasis with a phrase that conveys strong personal involvement in your language. Alternate translation: [I myself am angry…I myself was angry]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 1:15 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר אֲנִי֮ קָצַ֣פְתִּי מְעָ֣ט וְהֵ֔מָּה עָזְר֖וּ לְרָעָֽה

“for I, I was angry {only} a little, but they helped toward the evil”

Yahweh uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between the limited extent of his anger and the excessive harm the nations inflicted. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [for I was angry only a little, yet they made the harm far worse]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 1:15 (#4)

לְרָעָֽה

“toward the evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to do what was harmful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 1:16 (#1)

לָכֵ֗ן

“Therefore”

The term translated as **Therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Because of this]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 1:16 (#2)

שַׁ֣בְתִּי לִירוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם בְּרַחֲמִ֑ים

“I have returned to Jerusalem with compassions”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if his renewed favor toward Jerusalem were a physical journey back to the city. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have again shown favor to Jerusalem with mercy] or [I have once again been gracious to Jerusalem]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 1:16 (#3)

בְּרַחֲמִ֑ים

“with compassions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [while acting mercifully to her people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 1:16 (#4)

בֵּיתִ֤י יִבָּנֶה־בָּהּ֙

“My house will be built in her”

The expression **My house will be built in her** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the people of Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [the people will build my house in her]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 1:16 (#5)

וקוה יִנָּטֶ֥ה עַל־יְרוּשָׁלָֽ͏ִם

“and a measuring line will be stretched out over Jerusalem”

The expression **a measuring line will be stretched out over Jerusalem** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the builders. Alternate translation: [and the builders will stretch out a measuring line over Jerusalem]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 1:16 (#6)

וקוה

“and a measuring line”

A **measuring line** is a kind of rope or cord that builders stretch out to measure distances when constructing or planning a building or city. If your readers would not be familiar with what a measuring line is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and a measuring rope]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 1:17 (#1)

עָרַ֖י

“My cities”

Here, **My cities** represents the people who live in those cities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people living in my cities]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:17 (#2)

קְרָ֣א לֵאמֹ֔ר

“call out, saying”

There are three levels of quotation here. The angel of Yahweh is speaking to Zechariah (level 1) and telling him to proclaim a message (level 2), which itself quotes what Yahweh of Armies says (level 3). Use the appropriate punctuation in your language to mark these levels of quotation. Alternatively, you could translate this so that there is not a third-level quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Zechariah 1:17 (#3)

מִטּ֑וֹב

“from goodness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from good things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 1:18 (#1)

וָאֶשָּׂ֤א אֶת־עֵינַי֙ וָאֵ֔רֶא

“my eyes and I saw”

Zechariah is using the phrase **And I lifted up my eyes and I saw** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 1:18 (#2)

וָאֶשָּׂ֤א אֶת־עֵינַי֙

“my eyes”

Zechariah is using **And I lifted up my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I looked” or “I directed my attention.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I looked up] or [And I directed my gaze upward]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 1:18 (#3)

וְהִנֵּ֖ה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהִנֵּ֖ה”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and there I saw]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 1:19 (#1)

הַקְּרָנ֔וֹת אֲשֶׁ֥ר זֵֽרוּ֙ אֶת־יְהוּדָ֔ה

“the horns that scattered Judah”

Here, **the horns** represents the military power of the nations that attacked God’s people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the powerful nations that scattered the people of Judah]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:19 (#2)

אֶת־יְהוּדָ֛ה אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל וִירוּשָׁלָֽם

“Judah, Israel, and Jerusalem”

Here, **Judah, Israel, and Jerusalem** represents the people who lived in those nations and that city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Judah, the people of Israel, and the people of Jerusalem]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:21 (#1)

אֵאֵלֶּה & אֵאֵלֶּה הַקְּרָנוֹת & וַיָּבֹאוּ אֵאֱלֹהִה

“are} these & These {are} the horns & And these have come”

The word **These** is used three times in this verse with two different referents. The first and third **these** refers to the craftsmen. The second **these** refers to the horns, that is, the powerful nations. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [are these craftsmen ... These horns are the nations ... And these craftsmen have come]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 1:21 (#2)

כְּפִי

“according to the mouth of”

The angel is using **according to the mouth of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “so that.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to the extent that]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 1:21 (#3)

אִישׁ֙ לֹא־נָשָׂא רֹאשׁוֹ

“a man {who} has not lifted up his head”

The angel is using **has not lifted up his head** as a common expression of the culture to mean “no one was able to resist or act with confidence.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [no one was able to resist them] or [no one dared to oppose them]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 1:21 (#4)

וַיָּבֹאוּ אֵאֱלֹהִה לְהַחֲרִיד אוֹתָם

“And these have come to terrify them”

The term translated as **And** here indicates that what follows is the result or purpose of what came before. The craftsmen have come in order to terrify the nations that scattered Judah. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [So these have come to terrify them]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 1:21 (#5)

אֶת־קַרְנוֹת הַגּוֹיִם

“the horns of the nations”

Here, **the horns of the nations** represents the military power of those nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the armies of the nations]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:21 (#6)

הַנֹּשְׂאִים קֶרֶן אֶל־אֶרֶץ יְהוּדָה

“the ones lifting up a horn against the land of Judah”

Here, **lifting up a horn** represents exercising aggressive military power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the ones using their military power against the land of Judah]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 1:21 (#7)

אֶל־אֶרֶץ יְהוּדָה

“against the land of Judah”

Here, **the land of Judah** represents the people who live there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [against the people of Judah]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is introduced in prose with imagery used in the rest of the chapter to portray Zechariah’s third vision about measuring lines given by the Lord.

Some translations prefer to set apart quotations. The ULT and many other English translations set the lines of 2:4–13, which are extended quotations, farther to the right on the page than the rest of the text.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Visions

This book contains a number of visions given to Zechariah, so the images are not ones Zechariah actually saw, but were ones given to him in a vision or dream. It is important for each of these visions to keep their meanings and not be interpreted to mean any specific thing. Please be careful to translate each of the terms in your language.

Zechariah 2:1 (#1)

וָאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי וָאֵרֶא וְהִנֵּה

“And I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold”

The phrase **And I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold** is a way that Zechariah introduces each new vision in his book. Your language may have its own way of introducing a new vision or important event in a narrative.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 2:1 (#2)

וָאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי

“And I lifted up my eyes”

The expression **I lifted up my eyes** was a common expression meaning “I looked up” or “I looked intently.” If this expression does not communicate well in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I looked up]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 2:1 (#3)

וְהִנֵּה

“and behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and I was surprised to see]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 2:1 (#4)

חֶבֶל מְדָּה

“a rope of measuring”

Zechariah is using the possessive form to describe a **rope** that is used for **measuring**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the possessive form with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a string for measuring]

See: Possession

Zechariah 2:3 (#1)

וְהִנֵּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהִנֵּה”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [And look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 2:3 (#2)

לִקְרָאתוֹ

“to meet him”

The pronoun **him** refers to the angel who had been speaking with Zechariah, not to the man with the measuring line. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that more clearly. Alternate translation: [to meet the interpreting angel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:4 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר אֵלָיו

“And he said to him”

Here, **he** refers to the second angel, and **him** refers to the angel who had been speaking with Zechariah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that more clearly. Alternate translation: [And the second angel said to the first angel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:4 (#2)

רֻץ דַּבֵּר אֶל־הַנַּעַר הַלָּזֶה לֵאמֹר

“Run, speak to that young man, saying”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. For example, you could express the inner quotation as an indirect quotation.

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 2:4 (#3)

הַנַּעַר הַלָּזֶה

“that young man”

The phrase **that young man** likely refers to the man with the measuring line from verse 1. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that more clearly. Alternate translation: [the young man who was going to measure Jerusalem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:4 (#4)

לֵאמֹ֑ר

“saying”

The word **saying** introduces a quotation. Use a natural form for introducing a quotation in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 2:4 (#5)

פְּרָז֣וֹת תֵּשֵׁ֣ב יְרוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם

“Jerusalem will be inhabited {as} open areas”

The second angel is speaking of **Jerusalem** as if it would be like **open areas** without walls, meaning the city will have so many inhabitants that people will overflow beyond its walls. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Jerusalem will be like an unwalled city]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 2:4 (#6)

מֵרֹ֣ב אָדָ֔ם וּבְהֵמָֽה

“because of the multitude of man and beast”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the abstract noun **multitude** in another way. Alternate translation: [the many people and animals]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:4 (#7)

אָדָ֔ם וּבְהֵמָֽה

“man and beast”

The second angel is referring to all living creatures by naming two broad categories, **man** and **beast**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [people and animals of every kind]

See: Merism

Zechariah 2:5 (#1)

וַאֲנִ֣י אֶֽהְיֶה־לָּ֗הּ

“And I, I will be for her”

Here, the pronoun **I** is repeated for emphasis. Yahweh is emphasizing his personal commitment to protect Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [And I, even I, will be for her]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:5 (#2)

נְאֻם־יְהוָ֔ה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the abstract noun **declaration** in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh declares]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:5 (#3)

חוֹמַת־אֵ֣שׁ סָבִ֔יב

“a wall of fire all around”

Yahweh is speaking of his protection of Jerusalem as if he were **a wall of fire all around** it, meaning he will powerfully protect the city on every side. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a powerful defense all around]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 2:5 (#4)

וּלְכָב֖וֹד אֶֽהְיֶ֥ה בְּתוֹכָֽהּ

“and for glory I will be in her midst”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the abstract noun **glory** in another way. Alternate translation: [to show how glorious I am, I will be in her midst]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:5 (#5)

בְּתוֹכָֽהּ

“in her midst”

Here, **her** refers to Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that more clearly. Alternate translation: [in the midst of Jerusalem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:6 (#1)

הוֹי הוֹי

“Woe! Woe”

The exclamation **Woe!** is repeated for emphasis to express urgency and warning. If your language has its own way of expressing an urgent warning, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [Listen! Listen!]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 2:6 (#2)

מֵאֶרֶץ צָפוֹן

“from the land of the north”

Yahweh is using **the land of the north** to refer to Babylon, since the Babylonians came from the north to invade Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the land of Babylon, in the north]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:6 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the abstract noun **declaration** in another way. Alternate translation: [this is what Yahweh says]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:6 (#4)

כְּאַרְבַּע רוּחוֹת הַשָּׁמַיִם פֵּרַשְׂתִּי אֶתְכֶם

“as the four winds of the heavens, I have spread you out”

Yahweh compares the way he scattered his people to the way **the four winds of the heavens** blow in every direction. If this comparison does not communicate well in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have scattered you to every part of the earth]

See: Simile

Zechariah 2:7 (#1)

הוֹי צִיּוֹן

“Woe, Zion”

The exclamation **Woe** expresses an urgent call. If your language has its own way of expressing an urgent call, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [Listen, Zion!]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 2:7 (#2)

צִיּוֹן

“Zion”

Here, **Zion** represents the people who live in Jerusalem. Yahweh is calling the exiled people of Jerusalem to escape from Babylon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that plainly. Alternate translation: [you people of Zion]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:7 (#3)

בַּת־בָּבֶל

“the daughter of Babylon”

Yahweh is using **the daughter of Babylon** as a common expression to refer to the people of Babylon. If this expression does not communicate well in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Babylon]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 2:8 (#1)

כִּי כֹה אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“For thus says Yahweh of Armies”

The phrase **For thus says Yahweh of Armies** introduces an indirect quotation of what Yahweh says. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing indirect quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 2:8 (#2)

אַחַר כָּבוֹד שְׁלָחַנִי

“after glory he has sent me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in order to glorify himself, he has sent me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:8 (#3)

שְׁלָחַנִי

“he has sent me”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, while the pronoun **me** refers to the prophetic speaker. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has sent me, his prophet]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:8 (#4)

הַנֹּגֵעַ בָּכֶם נֹגֵעַ בְּבָבַת עֵינוֹ

“the one touching you is touching the apple of his eye”

Yahweh is using **the one touching you is touching the apple of his eye** as a common expression of the culture to mean “harming you is harming what is most precious to him.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who harms you harms what Yahweh treasures most]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 2:9 (#1)

הִנְנִי

“behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look, I am waving my hand over them]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 2:9 (#2)

מֵנִיף אֶת־יָדִי עֲלֵיהֶם

“I am waving my hand over them”

Here, **my hand** represents Yahweh’s power to punish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am about to strike them with my power]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:9 (#3)

יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת שְׁלָחָנִי

“Yahweh of Armies has sent me”

The pronoun **me** refers to the prophetic speaker. This statement is outside Yahweh’s direct speech. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh of Armies has sent me, his prophet]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:10 (#1)

רָנִּי וְשִׂמְחִי

“Sing and rejoice”

The terms **Sing** and **rejoice** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Celebrate with great joy]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 2:10 (#2)

בַּת־צִיּוֹן

“daughter of Zion”

Yahweh is using **daughter of Zion** as a common expression of the culture to refer to the people of Jerusalem. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people of Zion]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 2:10 (#3)

הִנְנִי

“behold, I am”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [watch]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 2:10 (#4)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **declaration**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [this is what Yahweh has declared]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:11 (#1)

וְנִלְווּ֨וּ גוֹיִ֤ם רַבִּים֙ אֶל־יְהוָ֔ה

“And many nations will join themselves to Yahweh”

By **join themselves to Yahweh**, Zechariah means become worshipers of Yahweh. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And people from many nations will worship Yahweh like the Israelites]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 2:11 (#2)

בַּיּ֣וֹם הַה֔וּא

“in that day”

Yahweh is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See the Introduction to Zechariah for a discussion of the phrase “in that day.”

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:11 (#3)

וְיָדַעְתְּ֗ כִּֽי־יְהוָ֤ה צְבָאוֹת֙ שְׁלָחַ֣נִי אֵלָ֔יִךְ

“And you will know that Yahweh of Armies has sent me to you”

Here the pronoun **you** is singular and refers to the people of Zion, and the pronoun **me** refers to the prophetic speaker. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And you, people of Zion, will know that Yahweh of Armies has sent me, his prophet, to you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 2:12 (#1)

וְנָחַ֤ל & אֶת־יְהוּדָה֙ חֶלְקֹ֔ו

“will inherit Judah {as} his portion”

The word translated as **will inherit** means to take formal, permanent possession of something as one’s rightful property. It does not imply that a previous owner has died. If the word you use for **will inherit** would give your readers that wrong impression, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [will claim Judah as his possession]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 2:12 (#2)

אַדְמַ֥ת הַקֹּ֖דֶשׁ

“the land of holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the holy land]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 2:13 (#1)

הַ֣ס

“Hush”

Zechariah is using the exclamation **Hush** to express a strong feeling of reverence and awe before Yahweh. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what Zechariah was feeling. Alternate translation: [Be silent]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 2:13 (#2)

כָּל־בָּשָׂ֔ר

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כָּל־בָּשָׂר”

Here, **all flesh** represents all living people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all people]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:13 (#3)

מִפְּנֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה

“Yahweh”

Here, **the face of Yahweh** represents the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 2:13 (#4)

נֵעוֹר֙ מִמְּעוֹן֙ קָדְשֹׁ֔ו

“he has been roused”

Here Zechariah is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who had been sleeping and has now **been roused** to take action. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [he has risen to act from his holy dwelling place]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 2:13 (#5)

נֵעוֹר

“he has been roused”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could state **he has been roused** with an active form. The context indicates that Yahweh himself is the agent of this action. Alternate translation: [he has roused himself]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 2:13 (#6)

מִמְּעוֹן קָדְשׁוֹ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִמְּעוֹן קָדְשׁוֹ”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from his holy dwelling place]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter presents Zechariah’s fourth night vision: a heavenly courtroom scene in which Joshua the priest stands before the angel of Yahweh while the adversary accuses him (vv.1–5), followed by a prophetic oracle about “the Branch” and the removal of iniquity (vv.6–10).

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Clothing as a Symbol of Moral State

Filthy garments represent sin and defilement, while clean garments and a clean turban represent purification and restored priestly authority.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Nested Quotation Structure

Verses 7–10 contain three levels of quotation: the angel of Yahweh quotes Yahweh of Armies, whose speech includes both a conditional promise and a messianic oracle.

Zechariah 3:1 (#1)

וַיַּרְאֵנִי

“And he made me see”

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 3:1 (#2)

אֶת־יְהוֹשֻׁעַ הַכֹּהֵן הַגָּדוֹל

“Joshua the high priest”

Zechariah is introducing **Joshua the high priest** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a man named Joshua who served as the high priest]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Zechariah 3:1 (#3)

וְהַשָּׂטָן

“and the adversary”

Zechariah is introducing **the adversary** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and a being who was an adversary]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Zechariah 3:1 (#4)

וַיַּרְאֵנִי

“And he made me see”

The pronoun **he** could refer to (1) Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh made me see], or (2) the angel that was speaking to Zechariah. Alternate translation: [The angel made me see]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 3:1 (#5)

עֹמֵד לִפְנֵי מַלְאַךְ יְהוָה

“standing to the face of the angel of Yahweh”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in the presence of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [standing in the presence of the angel of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:2 (#1)

יִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַשָּׂטָן וְיִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַבּחֵר בִּירוּשָׁלָם

“May Yahweh rebuke you, the adversary, and may Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem rebuke you”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [May I, Yahweh, rebuke you, the adversary, and may I, Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem, rebuke you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 3:2 (#2)

יִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַשָּׂטָן וְיִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַבּחֵר בִּירוּשָׁלָם

“May Yahweh rebuke you, the adversary, and may Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem rebuke you”

Yahweh is expressing what he desires to happen to the adversary. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about this form of speech and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I rebuke you, the adversary, and I, Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem, rebuke you]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Zechariah 3:2 (#3)

יִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַשָּׂטָן וְיִגְעַר יְהוָה בְּךָ הַבּחֵר בִּירוּשָׁלָם

“May Yahweh rebuke you, the adversary, and may Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem rebuke you”

These two phrases **May Yahweh rebuke you, the adversary** and **may Yahweh who is choosing Jerusalem rebuke you** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Certainly, may Yahweh rebuke you, the adversary]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 3:2 (#4)

הֲלֹוא זֶה אאוּד מֻצָּל מֵאֵשׁ

“Is} this not a firebrand rescued from the fire”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that Joshua has indeed been rescued from destruction. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Surely this is a firebrand rescued from the fire!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 3:2 (#5)

אאוּד מֻצָּל מֵאֵשׁ

“a firebrand rescued from the fire”

Yahweh is speaking as if Joshua were **a firebrand rescued from the fire**. He means that Joshua has been barely saved from destruction. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one who has been barely saved from destruction]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:2 (#6)

אאוּד מֻצָּל מֵאֵשׁ

“a firebrand rescued from the fire”

The expression **rescued** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a firebrand that God rescued from the fire]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 3:3 (#1)

וִיהוֹשֻׁעַ הָיָה לָבֻשׁ בְּגָדִים צוֹאִים וְעֹמֵד לִפְנֵי הַמַּלְאָךְ

“was clothed {in} filthy & and standing to the face of”

Zechariah is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 3:3 (#2)

הָיָה לָבֻשׁ בְּגָדִים צוֹאִים

“was clothed {in} filthy”

Zechariah is speaking as if Joshua’s sinfulness were **filthy garments** that he was wearing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [was wearing filthy clothes signifying sin and guilt] or [was deeply sinful]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:3 (#3)

וְעֹמֵד לִפְנֵי הַמַּלְאָךְ

“and standing to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in the presence of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [standing in the presence of the angel]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:4 (#1)

וַיַּ֣עַן וַיֹּ֔אמֶר

“And he answered and said”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel of Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the angel of Yahweh answered and said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 3:4 (#2)

הָעֹמְדִ֖ים לְפָנָ֑יו

“the ones standing to the face of him”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in the presence of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [those who stood before him]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:4 (#3)

לֵאמֹ֔ר

“saying”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 3:4 (#4)

הָסִ֥ירוּ הַבְּגָדִ֖ים הַצֹּאִאִ֣ים מֵעָלָ֑יו

“Remove the filthy garments from upon him”

The angel of Yahweh is speaking as if Joshua’s sin were **filthy garments** that could be removed. He means that God is taking away Joshua’s sin. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take away Joshua’s sin from him]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:4 (#5)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר אֵלָ֔יו

“And he said to him”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel of Yahweh, and **him** refers to Joshua. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the angel of Yahweh said to Joshua]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 3:4 (#6)

רְאֵ֣ה

“See”

The angel of Yahweh is using the term **See** as an expression to focus Joshua’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pay attention!]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:4 (#7)

עֲוֹנֶ֖ךָ

“your iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong things you have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 3:4 (#8)

הֶעֱבַ֥רְתִּי מֵעָלֶ֖יךָ עֲוֹנֶ֑ךָ

“I have caused your iniquity to pass away from you”

The angel of Yahweh is speaking as if Joshua’s iniquity were a physical object that could be **caused to pass away from** him. He means that God has forgiven Joshua’s sin. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have forgiven your sin] Alternate translation: [I have forgiven your sin]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:4 (#9)

וְהַלְבֵּשׁ אֹתְךָ מַחֲלָצוֹת

“and I will clothe you {with} fine clothing”

The angel of Yahweh is speaking as if Joshua’s restored condition were **fine clothing** that he could put on. He means that God is restoring Joshua to a state of purity and honor. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will restore you to a state of purity and honor]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:5 (#1)

וַיָּשִׂימוּ֩ הַצָּנִ֨יף הַטָּהֹ֜ור עַל־רֹאשֹׁ֗ו וַיַּלְבִּשֵׁ֙הוּ֙ בְּגָדִ֔ים

“And they set the clean turban on his head and clothed him {with} garments”

Setting a clean turban on Joshua’s head and clothing him with garments was a symbolic action by which the angels showed that Joshua was being restored to his priestly office. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [they set the clean turban on his head and clothed him with garments, showing that Joshua was being restored to his priestly office]

See: Symbolic Action

Zechariah 3:5 (#2)

וָאֹמַ֔ר

“And I said”

The pronoun **I** refers to Zechariah, who is interjecting into the vision. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Then I, Zechariah, said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 3:5 (#3)

וּמַלְאַ֖ךְ יְהוָ֑ה עֹמֵֽד

“and the angel of Yahweh was standing {by”

Zechariah is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 3:6 (#1)

לֵאמֹֽר

“saying”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 3:7 (#1)

כֹּה־אָמַ֤ר יְהוָה֙ צְבָאֹ֔ות אִם־בִּדְרָכַ֖י תֵּלֵ֑ךְ

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies, ‘If you will walk in my ways”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Here the angel is quoting Yahweh of Armies, whose words form a second level of quotation within the angel’s speech. Alternate translation: [Yahweh of Armies has said: “If you will walk in my ways] or [Yahweh of Armies says that if you will walk in his ways]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 3:7 (#2)

כֹּה־אָמַ֤ר יְהוָה֙ צְבָאֹ֔ות

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies”

The phrase **Thus says Yahweh of Armies** introduces a direct quotation from Yahweh. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase in exactly this way.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 3:7 (#3)

בִּדְרָכַ֖י תֵּלֵ֑ךְ

“you will walk in my ways”

Yahweh is speaking as if obeying him were **walking** along a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you obey my commands]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:7 (#4)

אֶת־מִשְׁמַרְתִּ֣י תִשְׁמֹ֔ר

“you will keep my charge”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this.

See: Poetry

Zechariah 3:7 (#5)

תָּדִ֣ין אֶת־בֵּיתִ֔י

“will judge my house”

Yahweh is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will oversee my temple]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:7 (#6)

וְנָתַתִּ֥י לְךָ֖ מַהְלְכִ֑ים בֵּ֣ין הָעֹמְדִ֔ים הָאֵ֖לֶּה

“and I will give to you access among these who are standing {here”

Yahweh is speaking as if the privilege of coming into his presence were physical **access** to walk among the angels. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will allow you to be near me like these angels who are standing here]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:7 (#7)

וְנָתַתִּ֥י לְךָ֖ מַהְלְכִ֑ים

“and I will give to you access”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **access**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and I will allow you to be]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 3:8 (#1)

הַיֹּשְׁבִ֣ים לְפָנֶ֔יךָ

“to the face of you”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in the presence of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who are sitting in the presence of you]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:8 (#2)

אַנְשֵׁ֣י מוֹפֵ֑ת

“a sign”

Yahweh is using **men of a sign** as a common expression of the culture to mean “men whose lives serve as signs pointing to future events.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [men who are living signs pointing to what is to come]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 3:8 (#3)

כִּ֣י־אַנְשֵׁ֣י מוֹפֵ֔ת הִנֵּ֖ה כִּי־הִנְנִ֥י

“a sign & behold”

Here, **for** marks Yahweh’s bringing of his servant the Branch as the goal or purpose of Joshua and his companions being men of a sign. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Zechariah 3:8 (#4)

הִנְנִ֥י

“behold”

Yahweh is using the term **behold** to focus Joshua’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 3:8 (#5)

צֶֽמַח

“the Branch”

Yahweh is speaking as if the future messianic king were a **Branch** growing from a family line. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the king who will come from the family line of David]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:9 (#1)

הִנֵּ֨ה

“behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [notice]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 3:9 (#2)

לִפְנֵי יְהוֹשֻׁעַ

“to the face of Joshua”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in front of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before Joshua]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:9 (#3)

שִׁבְעָ֥ה עֵינָֽיִם

“are} seven eyes”

Here, **seven eyes** represents God’s complete and watchful awareness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [are seven facets that represent God’s complete awareness of everything]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 3:9 (#4)

מְפַתֵּחַ֙ פִּתֻּחָ֔הּ

“I am engraving its engraving”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this.

See: Poetry

Zechariah 3:9 (#5)

נְאֻ֖ם יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֽוֹת

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

The expression **the declaration of Yahweh of Armies** is a prophetic attestation formula that affirms the authority of what is being said. In your translation, use a natural way of representing this kind of affirmation in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression in exactly this way.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 3:9 (#6)

וּמַשְׁתִּ֥י אֶת־עֲוֹ֛ן הָאָ֥רֶץ־הַהִ֖יא בְּי֣וֹם אֶחָֽד

“and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day”

Yahweh is speaking as if the iniquity of the land were a physical object that he could **remove**. He means that he will forgive the sin of the people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will forgive the sin of that land]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:9 (#7)

אֶת־עֲוֹ֛ן

“the iniquity of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:4. Alternate translation: [the wrong things that the people have done in]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 3:10 (#1)

אֶל־תַּ֥חַת גֶּ֖פֶן וְאֶל־תַּ֥חַת תְּאֵנָֽה

“to under {his} vine and to under {his} fig tree”

Yahweh is speaking as if the peace and prosperity of the future age were sitting **under** a **vine** and **fig tree**. This was a common image representing security and contentment. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to enjoy calm prosperity together]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 3:10 (#2)

אִ֣ישׁ לְרֵעֵ֔הוּ

“each man to his neighbor”

The masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [each person to their neighbor]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Zechariah 4 is the fifth of eight night visions. The chapter moves from a prophetic vision (a golden lampstand with seven lamps and two olive trees) to an explanation, then to an oracle declaring that Zerubbabel will complete the temple "not by might and not by power, but by my Spirit," and concludes with the identification of the two olive trees as those set apart to serve the Lord of all the earth.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Temple Furniture as Symbol

The lampstand echoes the tabernacle menorah (Exodus 25:31–40). Seven lamps and continuous olive oil flowing through golden pipes symbolized God's provision for continuous worship and the Spirit's empowering presence.

Anointing and Divine Empowering

"Sons of the fresh oil" is an idiom for those set apart for special service. Olive oil consecrated kings and priests; here it represents the Spirit enabling Zerubbabel and his community to complete the rebuilding work.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Quotations

Verses 6–10 contain a series of quotes in which it is difficult to discern who is speaking. The ULT suggests:

- the angel speaks from 6–10
- the angel quotes Yahweh in the middle of verse 6 and beginning of verse 9
- the angel prophetically quotes the people's reaction at the end of verse 7
- the angel, not Zechariah, is the speaker who received the word of Yahweh in verse 8
- the "me" at the end of verse 9 refers to the angel, this is probably the most contested point, scholars are divided as to if this is Zechariah, the angel speaking to him, or the Angel of Yahweh (read as Jesus)

If there is a translation in your area, you may wish to follow its decisions regarding speakers in this section. If not, you may wish to follow the ULT.

Mountains as Obstacles

Verse 7 calls a great mountain to become a plain, representing political and practical obstacles dissolving so that Zerubbabel can set the capstone in place.

Zechariah 4:1 (#1)

וַיָּ֣שָׁב הַמַּלְאָ֔ךְ הַדֹּבֵ֖ר בִּ֑י וַיְעִירֵ֕נִי

"And the angel who was speaking with me returned and roused me"

Zechariah is using the word translated as **returned** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 4:1 (#2)

כְּאִ֣ישׁ אֲשֶׁר־יֵעָ֔וֹר מִשְּׁנָתֽוֹ

"like a man who is roused from his sleep"

The point of this comparison is that just as a man who is roused from his sleep is awakened suddenly, so the angel is rousing Zechariah to pay attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as when a man is suddenly awakened from sleep]

See: Simile

Zechariah 4:1 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר־יֵעָ֔וֹר מִשְּׁנָתֽוֹ

"who is roused from his sleep"

The expression **is roused from his sleep** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [who someone wakes from sleep]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 4:2 (#1)

וְגֻלָּ֥ה עַל־רֹאשָׁ֖הּ

"and its bowl on its top"

The angel is using the possessive form to describe a **bowl** that belongs to the lampstand. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the bowl on top of it]

See: Possession

Zechariah 4:2 (#2)

וְשִׁבְעָ֣ה נֵרֹתֶ֔יהָ עָלָ֖יהָ שִׁבְעָ֑ה וְשִׁבְעָ֥ה וְשִׁבְעָ֖ה מוּצָקֹ֥ות

"and seven lamps on it, seven and seven tubes"

Translate this number according to the conventions of your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [and seven lamps on it, fourteen tubes]

See: Numbers

Zechariah 4:2 (#3)

וְהִנֵּה

“and behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 4:3 (#1)

עָלֶ֖יהָ

“are} beside it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the bowl. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [are beside the bowl]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:4 (#1)

לֵאמֹ֔ר

“saying”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 4:5 (#1)

הֲלֹ֣וא יָדַ֔עְתָּ מָה־הֵ֥מָּה אֵ֖לֶּה

“Do you not know what these are”

The angel is using the question form to express that Zechariah should already know what the items mean. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should know what these are.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 4:5 (#2)

הֵ֥מָּה אֵ֖לֶּה

“these are”

The pronoun **these** refers to the lampstand and the two olive trees. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the lampstand and olive trees are]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:5 (#3)

וַיַּ֣עַן הַמַּלְאָ֗ךְ הַדֹּבֵ֥ר בִּי֙ וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And the angel who was speaking with me answered and said”

The terms **answered and said** together introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 4:6 (#1)

דְּבַר־יְהוָ֔ה

“is} the word of Yahweh”

The angel is using the possessive form to describe a **word** that comes from Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the word from Yahweh]

See: Possession

Zechariah 4:6 (#2)

לֹ֣א בְחַ֔יִל וְלֹ֥א בְכֹ֖חַ כִּ֣י אִם־בְּרוּחִ֑י

“Not by might and not by power, but by my Spirit”

The angel is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [You will not accomplish this by your own might or power, but my Spirit will accomplish it]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 4:6 (#3)

אֵלַ֛י לֵאמֹ֖ר זֶ֣ה דְּבַר־יְהוָ֑ה אֶל־זְרֻבָּבֶ֣ל לֵאמֹ֔ר לֹ֥א

“to me, saying, “This {is} the word of Yahweh to Zerubbabel, saying, ‘Not”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within

a quotation. Alternate translation: [to me that this is the message from Yahweh to Zerubbabel: “Not]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 4:6 (#4)

לֹ֣א בְחַ֔יִל וְלֹ֖א בְּכֹ֑חַ

“Not by might and not by power”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **might** and **power,** you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Not by strength and not by force]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 4:6 (#5)

לֹ֣א בְחַ֔יִל וְלֹ֖א בְּכֹ֑חַ

“Not by might and not by power”

The terms **might** and **power** mean similar things. The angel is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Not by your own strength]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 4:7 (#1)

מִֽי־אַתָּ֣ה הַר־הַגָּדֹ֗ול לִפְנֵי֙ זְרֻבָּבֶ֔ל לְמִישֹׁ֖ר

“Who {are} you, great mountain, to the face of Zerubbabel? {You} will become a plain”

The angel is speaking to the great mountain that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about how the obstacles before Zerubbabel will be removed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if the angel were speaking directly to the people about the mountain. Alternate translation: [Now about this great mountain in front of Zerubbabel, it will become a plain.]

See: Apostrophe

Zechariah 4:7 (#2)

מִֽי־אַתָּ֣ה הַר־הַגָּדֹ֗ול לִפְנֵי֙ זְרֻבָּבֶ֔ל לְמִישֹׁ֖ר

“Who {are} you, great mountain, to the face of Zerubbabel? {You} will become a plain”

Here the angel is speaking as if the great mountain were a person standing in the way. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What are you, great obstacle, before Zerubbabel? You will no longer block him!]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 4:7 (#3)

מִֽי־אַתָּ֣ה הַר־הַגָּדֹ֗ול לִפְנֵי֙ זְרֻבָּבֶ֔ל

“Who {are} you, great mountain, to the face of Zerubbabel”

The angel is using the question form to emphasize that the mountain obstacle will be removed. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You are nothing, great mountain, before Zerubbabel]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 4:7 (#4)

וְהֹוצִ֥יא

“And he will bring out”

The pronoun **he** refers to Zerubbabel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Zerubbabel will bring out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:7 (#5)

תְּשֻׁאֹ֛ות חֵ֥ן חֵ֖ן לָֽהּ

“with} shouts of ‘Grace, grace to it”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [while people call out blessings on it]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 4:7 (#6)

חֵ֥ן חֵ֖ן לָֽהּ

“Grace, grace to it”

The angel is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what the angel was feeling, or you could say what caused him to feel joyful. Alternate translation: [What joy! Let joy be upon it!]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 4:7 (#7)

חֵ֥ן חֵ֖ן

“Grace, grace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grace,** you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Blessed! Blessed!]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 4:7 (#8)

חֵ֥ן

“Grace”

Zechariah is repeating the word **Grace** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [May God greatly bless it]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 4:7 (#9)

לָ֔הּ

“to it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the top stone or the temple. The angel is using the top stone to represent the completed temple. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to the top stone] or [to the temple]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 4:8 (#1)

דְּבַר־יְהוָ֖ה

“the word of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:6. Alternate translation: [the word from Yahweh]

See: Possession

Zechariah 4:8 (#2)

לֵאמֹֽר

“saying”

The term “saying” introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 4:9 (#1)

יְדֵ֤י זְרֻבָּבֶל֙ יְסָדֻ֣הוּ הַבַּ֔יִת הַזֶּ֖ה וְיָדָ֣יו תְּבַצַּ֑עְנָה

“The hands of Zerubbabel have founded this house, and his hands will complete it”

Here, **hands** represents the work and effort of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Zerubbabel’s work has founded this house, and his work will complete it.]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 4:9 (#2)

וְיָדַעְתָּ֕

“And you will know”

The pronoun **you** refers to Zerubbabel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And you, Zerubbabel, will know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:9 (#3)

שְׁלָחַ֥נִי אֲלֵיכֶֽם

“has sent me to you”

The pronoun **me** could refer to: (1) the angel speaking to Zechariah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [has sent his angelic messenger to you] or (2) to Zechariah. Alternate translation: [has sent me, Zechariah, to you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:9 (#4)

אֲלֵיכֶֽם

“to you”

The word **you** is plural here because Yahweh is addressing the people, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Zechariah 4:10 (#1)

וְשָׂמְח֔וּ וְרָא֕וּ

“And they will rejoice and will see”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the people will be glad and will see]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:10 (#2)

הֵ֣מָּה מְשׁוֹטְטִ֔ים בְּכָל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“they are roaming through all of the earth”

Yahweh is speaking of the eyes as if they were living things that could roam. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they look throughout all the earth]

See: Personification

Zechariah 4:10 (#3)

כִּֽי־מִ֤י בַזַּ֙ח֙ לְי֣וֹם קְטַנּ֔וֹת וְשָׂמְח֕וּ

“For who has despised the day of small things? And they will rejoice”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Indeed, who would despise the day of small beginnings? It is certain that people will rejoice]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 4:10 (#4)

לְי֣וֹם קְטַנּ֔וֹת

“the day of small things”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **day** that is characterized by small things. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the day when small things happen]

See: Possession

Zechariah 4:10 (#5)

מִ֤י בַזַּ֙ח֙ לְי֣וֹם קְטַנּ֔וֹת

“who has despised the day of small things”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that no one should despise small beginnings. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one should despise the day of small things!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 4:10 (#6)

אֶת־הָאֶ֣בֶן הַבְּדִ֔יל

“the stone of tin”

A **stone of tin** refers to a metal or stone weight tied to a line and hung down from the top of a wall to make sure it is perfectly straight up and down. The common term for this is “plumb line,” as in the UST. If your readers would not be familiar with what a plumb line is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a measuring string] or [a device that proves that the building was constructed properly]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 4:10 (#7)

שִׁבְעָ֥ה־אֵ֖לֶּה

“These seven are”

The pronoun **These** refers to the seven lamps. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [These seven lamps are]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:10 (#8)

עֵינֵ֥י יְהוָ֖ה

“the eyes of Yahweh”

Here, **eyes** represents the awareness and watchfulness of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s watchfulness]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 4:11 (#1)

וָאַ֣עַן וָאֹמַ֔ר אֵלָ֖יו

“And I answered and said to him”

The terms **answered and said** together introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 4:12 (#1)

שֵׁנִ֖ית

“a second time”

If your language would not represent a number in a form such as “second,” you could represent this number in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [again]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 4:12 (#2)

הַמְרִיקִ֥ים מֵעֲלֵיהֶ֖ם הַזָּהָֽב

“that are emptying the gold from upon them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the two olive branches. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [that are emptying the gold from upon the two branches]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:12 (#3)

הַמְרִיקִ֥ים מֵעֲלֵיהֶ֖ם הַזָּהָֽב

“that are emptying the gold from upon them”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if the olive oil were gold because of its preciousness and golden color. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [emptying the olive oil from upon them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 4:13 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר אֵלַ֔י

“And he said to me”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the angel said to me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 4:13 (#2)

הֲלֹ֥וא יָדַ֖עְתָּ מָה־אֵ֑לֶּה

“Do you not know what these are”

The angel is using the question form to express that Zechariah should already know what the items mean. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. See how you translated the similar expression in 4:5. Alternate translation: [You should know what these are.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 4:14 (#1)

אֲדֹנִ֖ו כָּל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“the Lord of all of the earth”

The angel is using the possessive form to describe a **Lord** who rules all the earth. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the Lord who rules all the earth]

See: Possession

Zechariah 4:14 (#2)

שְׁנֵ֥י בְנֵי־הַיִּצְהָ֖ר

“are the two sons of the fresh oil”

The angel is using **sons of the fresh oil** as a common expression of the culture to mean the people who have been anointed to serve. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are the two servants who were anointed]

See: Idiom

Zechariah - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter presents two visions in which an angel interprets what Zechariah sees. The first vision (verses 1–4) shows a flying scroll carrying a divine curse against thieves and false swearers. The second vision (verses 5–11) shows evil personified as a woman sealed inside an ephah and carried away to Shinar.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Personification of Wickedness

The angel identifies the woman inside the ephah as “the wickedness,” using a human figure to represent the community’s sin. Translators should preserve this identification without reducing it to a mere symbol.

Ancient Measurements

The chapter refers to cubits (verse 2) and the ephah (verses 6–10). These measurement units may need explanatory notes for readers unfamiliar with ancient systems.

Zechariah 5:1 (#1)

וְהִנֵּ֖ה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהִנֵּ֖ה”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you

can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and I saw]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 5:1 (#2)

וְאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי

“my eyes”

Zechariah is using **I lifted up my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I looked up.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I looked]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 5:1 (#3)

וָאֶשָּׂא

“And I turned”

Zechariah is using the phrase translated as **And I turned** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 5:2 (#1)

עֶשְׂרִים בָּאַמָּה & עֶשֶׂר בָּאַמָּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עֶשְׂרִים בָּאַמָּה & עֶשֶׂר בָּאַמָּה”

A **cubit** was a unit of measurement corresponding to the distance between an average person’s elbow and middle fingertip, or about 45 centimeters or 18 inches. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express the dimensions of the scroll in modern measurements, either in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [10 meters ... 5 meters]

See: Biblical Distance

Zechariah 5:3 (#1)

הָאָלָה

“the curse”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **curse**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the words Yahweh spoke against them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 5:3 (#2)

פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ

“all of the earth”

The angel is using **the face of all of the earth** as a common expression of the culture to mean “everywhere.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the surface of the whole land]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 5:3 (#3)

כִּי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּי”

The implication is that the word **for** introduces the specific content of the curse, explaining what it says about those who steal. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for, as the curse says,]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 5:3 (#4)

כָּל־הַגֹּנֵב

“everyone”

The angel is not referring to a specific person **who is stealing**. He means anyone who steals in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone who steals]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 5:3 (#5)

מִזֶּה & מִזֶּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִזֶּה & מִזֶּה”

The implication is that **from this** and **from this** refer to the two sides of the scroll, one side addressing those who steal and the other side addressing those who swear falsely. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [on this side of the scroll ... on the other side of the scroll]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 5:3 (#6)

נִקָּה וְכָל־הַנִּשְׁבָּע מִזֶּה כָּמוֹהָ נִקֶּה

“and everyone”

The expression **has been cleared** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has cleared him, and everyone who is swearing from this side, according to it, Yahweh has also cleared]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 5:4 (#1)

נְאֻם־ יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

The phrase **declaration of Yahweh of Armies** identifies the speaker of the direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating the speaker of a direct quotation in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase as an interruption within the quotation.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 5:4 (#2)

וּבָאָה & וְלָנָה & וְכִלַּתּוּ

“and it will come & And it will spend the night & and will consume it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the curse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the curse will come ... And the curse will spend the night ... and the curse will consume the house]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 5:4 (#3)

בִּשְׁמִי

“by my name”

Here, **my name** represents Yahweh’s person and authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by my name and authority]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 5:4 (#4)

הַגַּנָּב & הַנִּשְׁבָּע בִּשְׁמִי לַשָּׁקֶר

“the thief & the one swearing by my name to falsehood”

Yahweh is not referring to a specific **thief** or a specific person **swearing by** his **name to falsehood**. He means any such person in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people who steal ... people who swear falsely by my name]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 5:4 (#5)

הַנִּשְׁבָּע בִּשְׁמִי

“the one swearing by my name”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one falsely swearing by my name]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 5:4 (#6)

וְלָנָה בְּתוֹךְ בֵּיתוֹ וְכִלָּתוּ וְאֶת־עֵצָיו וְאֶת־אֲבָנָיו

“And it will spend the night in the midst of his house and will consume it, and its timbers, and its stones”

Yahweh is speaking of the curse as if it were a living thing that could **spend the night in the midst of** someone’s **house** and **consume** a house and **its timbers and its stones**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And it will remain in his house and will destroy it, and its timbers and its stones]

See: Personification

Zechariah 5:4 (#7)

בֵּיתוֹ

“his house”

The pronoun **his** refers to each person who steals or swears falsely, as mentioned earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the house of the one who sinned]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 5:5 (#1)

וַיֵּצֵא הַמַּלְאָךְ הַדֹּבֵר בִּבְיִ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וַיֵּצֵא הַמַּלְאָךְ הַדֹּבֵר בִּבְיִ”

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase,

or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 5:5 (#2)

שָׂא נָא עֵינֶיךָ וּרְאֵה

“now your eyes and see”

The angel is using **Lift up now your eyes and see** as a common expression of the culture to mean “look up and pay attention.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Look up now and pay attention to]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 5:6 (#1)

עֵינָם

“their eye”

The pronoun **their** refers to the people of the land. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people’s eye]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 5:6 (#2)

עֵינָם

“their eye”

The phrase **their eye** is a translation of the written text in the original language. Some ancient translations, however, read “their iniquity” instead. You may want to follow this alternative reading in your translation. Alternate translation: [their iniquity]

See: Alternative Readings

Zechariah 5:6 (#3)

הָאֵיפָה

“the ephah”

An **ephah** was a unit of dry volume equivalent to about 22 liters or nearly two thirds of a bushel. Here it refers to a large measuring container. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express this in terms of modern measurements, either in the text or in a footnote.

See: Biblical Volume

Zechariah 5:6 (#4)

עֵינָם בְּכָל־הָאָרֶץ

“their eye & the earth”

Here, **their eye** could mean: (1) their appearance, meaning the ephah represents what the people are doing throughout the land. Alternate translation: [what they are doing throughout all the earth] (2) their iniquity, since the words for “eye” and “iniquity” are similar in the original language. Alternate translation: [how they are sinning throughout all the earth]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 5:7 (#1)

וְהִנֵּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהִנֵּה”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Then, look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 5:7 (#2)

כִּכַּר עֹפֶרֶת

“lead”

Zechariah is using the possessive form to describe a **disk** that is made of **lead**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a lead disk]

See: Possession

Zechariah 5:7 (#3)

כִּכַּר עֹפֶרֶת נִשֵּׂאת

“lead”

The expression **was being lifted up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [someone lifted up a disk of lead]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 5:8 (#1)

זֹאת הָרִשְׁעָה

“This {is”

The angel is referring to the woman in the previous verse as **wickedness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This woman embodies wickedness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 5:8 (#2)

הָרִשְׁעָה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הָרִשְׁעָה"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how wicked they are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 5:8 (#3)

פִּיהָ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: פִּיהָ"

Zechariah is using **its mouth** as a common expression of the culture to mean "its opening." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [its opening]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 5:9 (#1)

וָאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי וָאֵרֶא

"my eyes and I saw"

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 5:9 (#2)

וָאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי

"my eyes"

See how you translated the similar expression in 5:1.

See: Idiom

Zechariah 5:9 (#3)

וְהִנֵּה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהִנֵּה"

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners' attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 5:9 (#4)

הַחֲסִידָה

"the stork"

A **stork** is a kind of large water bird with long legs, a long beak, and large, powerful wings. If your readers would not be familiar with what a stork is, you could use the name of a similar large bird that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a large water bird]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 5:9 (#5)

כְּנָפַיִם כִּכַנְפֵי הַחֲסִידָה

"wings & the stork"

The point of this comparison is that just as **the wings of the stork** are large and powerful, so the wings of these two women were large and powerful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [wings as large and powerful as those of a stork]

See: Simile

Zechariah 5:11 (#1)

לִבְנוֹת

"To build"

Here, **To build** marks building a house for the woman in the land of Shinar as the goal or purpose of taking the ephah there. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Zechariah 5:11 (#2)

לָהּ

"for her"

The pronoun **her** refers to the woman who represents wickedness. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for the woman who represents wickedness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 5:11 (#3)

וְהוּכַן

“And it will be established”

The expression **it will be established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And they will establish it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 5:11 (#4)

וְהֻנִּיחָה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְהֻנִּיחָה”

The expression **she will be set down** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the two women. Alternate translation: [and they will set her down]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 5:11 (#5)

עַל־מְכֻנָתָהּ

“on her base”

A **base** is a kind of platform or pedestal on which something is placed for support or display. If your readers would not be familiar with what a base is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [on her stand]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter concludes the eight night visions (vv. 1–8) with four chariots dispatched as divine agents, then shifts to a sign-act in which Zechariah crowns Joshua the high priest and delivers the “Branch” oracle (vv. 9–15).

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The Branch

The title “Branch” is a messianic designation for a coming king who will build the temple and unite kingship and priesthood on one throne, with “counsel of peace” between the two offices (vv. 12–13).

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Nested Quotations

Verses 10–15 contain three levels of quotation as Yahweh instructs Zechariah to speak to Joshua a message from Yahweh of Armies.

Zechariah - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is written mainly in prose and tells the last vision of the four chariots in the first part of the chapter.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the poetic song in 6:12–13.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Meaning of the visions

The visions are stated and even when the prophet asked for an explanation, their true meaning is often obscure. This uncertainty should remain in your translation. (See: prophet, prophecy, prophesy, seer, prophetess)

Zechariah 6:1 (#1)

וְאָשׁוּב

“And I turned”

Zechariah is using the phrase translated as **And I turned** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 6:1 (#2)

וָאֶשָּׂא עֵינַי

“and I lifted my eyes”

Zechariah is using **I lifted my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I looked up.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I looked up]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 6:1 (#3)

וְהִנֵּה

“and behold”

Zechariah is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners' attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [and look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 6:1 (#4)

אַרְבַּ֖ע מַרְכָּב֣וֹת יֹצְאֹ֑ות מִבֵּ֣ין שְׁנֵ֣י הֶהָרִ֔ים

"four chariots coming out from between two mountains"

Here, **four chariots coming out from between two mountains** represents the divine agents that Yahweh sends out to execute his purposes in the earth. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information in a footnote. Alternate translation: [four chariots, which represent the divine agents Yahweh sends out to carry out his purposes, coming out from between two mountains]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Zechariah 6:1 (#5)

הָרֵ֥י נְחֹֽשֶׁת

"were} mountains of bronze"

Here, **mountains of bronze** represents the permanence and strength of Yahweh's heavenly dwelling place. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information in a footnote. Alternate translation: [represented the permanence and strength of Yahweh's heavenly dwelling place]

See: Symbolic Language

Zechariah 6:2 (#1)

בַּמֶּרְכָּבָ֥ה הָרִאשֹׁנָ֖ה & וּבַמֶּרְכָּבָ֣ה הַשֵּׁנִ֑ית

"In the first chariot & and in the second chariot"

If your language would not represent numbers in a form such as first and second, you could represent these numbers in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [In the chariot that went at the front ... and in the chariot that went after it]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 6:3 (#1)

וּבַמֶּרְכָּבָ֣ה הַשְּׁלִשִׁ֔ית & וּבַמֶּרְכָּבָה֙ הָרְבִיעִ֔ית

"and in the third chariot & and in the fourth chariot"

If your language would not represent numbers in a form such as third and fourth, you could represent these numbers in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [and in chariot three ... and in the last chariot]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 6:4 (#1)

וָאַעַ֥ן וָאֹמַ֖ר

"And I answered and said"

The phrase **And I answered and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 6:5 (#1)

וַיַּ֣עַן הַמַּלְאָ֔ךְ וַיֹּ֥אמֶר אֵלָ֖י

"And the angel answered and said to me"

The phrase **answered and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent both terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 6:5 (#2)

אַרְבַּ֣ע ׀ רוּחֹ֣ות הַשָּׁמַ֗יִם

"the four winds of the heavens"

Here the angel is speaking as if these chariots were **the four winds of the heavens** meaning that they go in every direction, covering the entire earth. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [four messengers from heaven who will cover the entire earth]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 6:5 (#3)

אַרְבַּ֣ע ׀ רוּחֹ֣ות

"the four winds of"

The word translated as **winds** could mean: (1) wind, denoting directions, Alternate translation: [four directions from] (2) spirits. Alternate translation: [four of God's servants in]

Zechariah 6:5 (#4)

מֵהִתְיַצֵּב עַל

“from standing before”

Here, **standing before** represents being ready to serve. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from readiness to serve]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 6:7 (#1)

וְהָאֲמֻצִּים

“And the strong ones”

Zechariah is using the adjective **strong** as a noun to mean a certain kind of horse. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [And the strong horses]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 6:7 (#2)

וְהָאֲמֻצִּים יָצְאוּ וַיְבַקְּשׁוּ לָלֶכֶת לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ בָּאָרֶץ וַיֹּאמֶר לְכוּ הִתְהַלְּכוּ בָאָרֶץ וַיִּתְהַלְּכוּ בָּאָרֶץ

“And the strong ones went out and sought to go to walk about in the earth. And he said, “Go, walk about in the earth.” And they walked about in the earth”

Here, **sought to go** marks **to walk about in the earth** as the goal or purpose of **went out**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Zechariah 6:7 (#3)

לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ בָּאָרֶץ & לְכוּ הִתְהַלְּכוּ בָאָרֶץ וַיִּתְהַלְּכוּ בָּאָרֶץ

“to walk about in the earth & Go, walk about in the earth.” And they walked about in the earth”

Zechariah is using **to walk about in the earth** as a common expression of the culture to mean “to patrol the earth.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to patrol the earth ... Go, walk about in the earth ... and they walked about in the earth]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 6:7 (#4)

וַיֹּאמֶר

“And he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the angel said to them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:7 (#5)

לְכוּ הִתְהַלְּכוּ בָאָרֶץ

“Go, walk about in the earth”

The words translated as **Go, walk about in the earth** are imperatives, but they communicate permission rather than a command. If the imperatives do not communicate permission for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates permission. Alternate translation: [Go ahead and walk about in the earth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Zechariah 6:7 (#6)

וַיִּתְהַלְּכוּ בָּאָרֶץ

“And they walked about in the earth”

The pronoun they refers to the strong horses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the strong ones walked about in the earth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:8 (#1)

וַיַּזְעֵק אֹתִי וַיְדַבֵּר אֵלַי לֵאמֹר

“And he called out to me and spoke to me, saying”

The phrase **And he called out to me and spoke to me, saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent all three terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 6:8 (#2)

וַיַּזְעֵק אֹתִי

“And he called out to me”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the angel called out to me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:8 (#3)

רְאֵ֔ה

“See”

The angel is using the term **See** to focus Zechariah’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 6:8 (#4)

הַיּוֹצְאִ֣ים אֶל־אֶ֣רֶץ צָפ֔וֹן

“the ones going out to the land of the north”

The phrase **the ones** refers to the chariots with their horses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the chariots going out to the land of the north]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:8 (#5)

הֵנִ֖יחוּ אֶת־רוּחִ֥י

“have caused my spirit to rest”

The angel is using **have caused my spirit to rest** as a common expression of the culture to mean “have satisfied my anger.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have calmed me down]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 6:8 (#6)

אֶת־רוּחִ֥י

“my spirit”

Here, my spirit represents “my anger” or “my wrath.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my wrath]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 6:8 (#7)

אֶת־רוּחִ֥י

“my spirit”

The pronoun **my** refers to Yahweh, who is speaking through the angel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s spirit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:9 (#1)

וַיְהִ֥י דְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה אֵלַ֥י

“And the word of Yahweh came to me”

Zechariah is using **the word of Yahweh came to me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Yahweh communicated a message to me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh communicated a message to me]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 6:9 (#2)

וַיְהִ֥י דְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה אֵלַ֣י לֵאמֹֽר

“And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying”

Zechariah is using the phrase **And the word of Yahweh came to me** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 6:10 (#1)

לְקַ֣ח מֵאֵ֣ת הַגּוֹלָ֔ה

“Take from the exiles”

The next verse clarifies that Zechariah is to take silver and gold from the exiles. You could include this information here if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Take silver and gold from the exiles]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 6:10 (#2)

הַגּוֹלָ֔ה

“the exiles”

The implication is that **the exiles** refers to people who had returned from exile in Babylon. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the recently returned exiles]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 6:10 (#3)

מֵחֶלְדַּי & טוֹבִיָּה & יְדַעְיָה & יאשִׁיָּה & צְפַנְיָה

“from Heldai & Tobijah & Jedaiah & Josiah & Zephaniah”

These are the names of men. This **Josiah** is not the same person as King Josiah.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 6:10 (#4)

וּבָאתָ אַתָּה֙ בַּיּ֣וֹם הַה֔וּא וּבָ֖אתָ בֵּ֥ית

“and you, you shall come on that day, and you shall come to the house of”

If the connection between the phrase **and you, you shall come on that day** and **and you shall come to the house of** is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [and make sure that you yourself certainly go that very day to the house of]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 6:10 (#5)

וּבָאתָ אַתָּה֙

“and you, you shall come”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you shall come** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Zechariah himself is the one who will go to Josiah’s house. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself shall come]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:10 (#6)

אֲשֶׁר־בָּ֣אוּ מִבָּבֶ֑ל

“who have come from Babylon”

The pronoun **who** refers to Heldai, Tobijah, and Jedaiah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers or restructure the verse to clarify. Alternate translation: [for Heldai, Tobijah, and Jedaiah have come from Babylon]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:11 (#1)

וְלָקַחְתָּ֣ כֶ֔סֶף־וְזָהָ֖ב וְעָשִׂ֣יתָ עֲטָרוֹת֙ וְשַׂמְתָּ֣ בְּרֹ֔אשׁ יְהוֹשֻׁ֥עַ בֶּן־יְהוֹצָדָ֖ק הַכֹּהֵ֥ן הַגָּדֽוֹל

“And you shall take silver and gold, and you shall make crowns, and you shall set {them} on the head of Joshua, the son of Jehozadak, the high priest”

These instructions are to be carried out in sequence: first take the silver and gold, then make crowns, and then place them on Joshua’s head. Your language may have a connecting phrase that you can use to show this. Alternate translation: [And you shall take silver and gold, and then you shall make crowns, and then you shall set {them} on the head of Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest.]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Zechariah 6:11 (#2)

וְעָשִׂ֣יתָ עֲטָרוֹת֙ וְשַׂמְתָּ֣ בְּרֹ֔אשׁ יְהוֹשֻׁ֥עַ

“and you shall make crowns, and you shall set {them} on the head of Joshua”

Placing crowns on the head of Joshua the high priest was a symbolic action by which Yahweh showed that a future king-priest figure would come. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote.

See: Symbolic Action

Zechariah 6:11 (#3)

יְהוֹצָדָ֖ק

“Jehozadak”

Jehozadak is the name of a man, the high priest.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 6:12 (#1)

וְאָמַרְתָּ֣ אֵלָ֔יו לֵאמֹ֖ר

“And you shall speak to him, saying”

The phrase **And you shall speak to him, saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 6:12 (#2)

לֵאמֹ֣ר כֹּ֔ה אָמַ֖ר יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֹ֑ות לֵאמֹ֣ר

“saying, ‘Thus says Yahweh of Armies, saying”

The phrase **Yahweh of Armies, saying** introduces a direct quotation within a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent these terms explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 6:12 (#3)

כֹּ֚ה אָמַ֣ר יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹת֮ לֵאמֹר֒ הִנֵּה־אִ֣ישׁ

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies, saying, Behold, a man”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh of Armies says that there is a man]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 6:12 (#4)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

Yahweh is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 6:12 (#5)

צֶ֣מַח שְׁמ֔וֹ

“Branch is his name”

Here Yahweh is speaking of this future king as if he were a **Branch** growing from a plant. He means that this person will arise from the line of David. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Descendant is his name]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 6:12 (#6)

הִנֵּה־אִ֣ישׁ צֶ֣מַח שְׁמ֔וֹ

“Behold, a man—Branch is his name”

Here Yahweh is introducing Branch as a new participant in the prophecy. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Zechariah 6:12 (#7)

צֶ֣מַח & יִצְמָ֑ח

“Branch & he will sprout”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its subject come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [Branch ... he will branch off]

See: Poetry

Zechariah 6:12 (#8)

וּמִתַּחְתָּ֖יו יִצְמָ֑ח

“and from his place he will sprout”

Here Yahweh is speaking of this future king as if he were a plant that would **sprout** from the ground. He means that this person will arise and emerge. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and from his place he will arise]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 6:12 (#9)

וּבָנָ֖ה אֶת־הֵיכַ֥ל יְהוָֽה

“and he will build the temple of Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [and he will build my temple]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 6:13 (#1)

וְ֭הוּא יִבְנֶ֣ה

“And he, he will build”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will build** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is the Branch who will build the temple of Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the

meaning here. Alternate translation: [And he himself will build the temple of Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:13 (#2)

אֶת־הֵיכַל יְהוָה

“the temple of Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [my temple]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 6:13 (#3)

וְהוּא־יִשָּׂא הוֹד

“and he, he will bear glory”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will bear glory** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is this man, the Branch, who will bear glory. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [he himself will bear glory]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 6:13 (#4)

יִשָּׂא הוֹד

“he will bear glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will be known as great and powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 6:13 (#5)

וְהָיָה כֹהֵן עַל־כִּסְאוֹ

“And he will be a priest on his throne”

This could mean: (1) Branch will be both priest and king or (2) Branch will be king, and another person will be a priest who will share the royal power. Alternate translation: [There will be a priest upon his throne]

Zechariah 6:13 (#6)

וְיָשַׁב וּמָשַׁל עַל־כִּסְאוֹ

“and he will sit and rule on his throne”

Here, **his throne** represents “his royal authority.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and will sit and rule with his royal authority]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 6:13 (#7)

וַעֲצַת שָׁלוֹם

“and a counsel of peace”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **counsel** and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and they will advise each other peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 6:13 (#8)

וַעֲצַת שָׁלוֹם

“and a counsel of peace”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **counsel** that is characterized by **peace**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and a peaceful counsel]

See: Possession

Zechariah 6:13 (#9)

בֵּין שְׁנֵיהֶם

“between the two of them”

The implication is that **the two of them** refers to the offices of king and priest. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [between the two offices of king and priest.’]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 6:14 (#1)

לְחֶלֶם

“for Helem”

The word Helem is the name of a man. This is an alternate form of the name Heldai from verse 10.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 6:14 (#2)

וּלְחֵ֣ן בֶּן־צְפַנְיָ֔ה

“and for Hen, the son of Zephaniah”

The word Hen is the name of a man. This is an alternate form of the name Josiah from verse 10.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 6:14 (#3)

לְזִכָּרָ֑וֹן

“as a memorial”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of memorial, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [so that people would remember]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 6:14 (#4)

לְזִכָּרוֹן֙ בְּהֵיכַ֣ל יְהוָ֔ה

“as a memorial in the temple of Yahweh”

Storing the crowns in the temple of Yahweh was a symbolic action by which the people showed that Yahweh had promised a future king-priest. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [as a memorial in the temple of Yahweh to show that Yahweh has promised a future king-priest]

See: Symbolic Action

Zechariah 6:14 (#5)

בְּהֵיכַ֣ל יְהוָ֔ה

“in the temple of Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [in my temple]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 6:15 (#1)

וּרְחוֹקִ֖ים

“And those far off”

Yahweh is using the adjective **far off** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [People who live far away]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 6:15 (#2)

יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹת֮ שְׁלָחַ֣נִי אֲלֵיכֶם֒

“Yahweh of Armies has sent me to you”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as Yahweh of Armies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [I, Yahweh of Armies, sent this messenger to you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 6:15 (#3)

וְהָיָה֙ אִם־שָׁמֹ֣עַ תִּשְׁמְעוּן֮ בְּקוֹל֒ יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיכֶ֔ם

“And {this} will happen if listening, you will listen to the voice of Yahweh your God”

Yahweh is presenting a possible condition, that these things will only happen if the people obey Yahweh. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. It may be helpful to reorder this sentence so that the conditional statement is first. Alternate translation: [And if you will listen carefully to the voice of Yahweh your God, this will happen]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Zechariah 6:15 (#4)

שָׁמֹ֣עַ תִּשְׁמְעוּן֮

“listening, you will listen”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **listen** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [you will certainly listen]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 6:15 (#5)

תִּשְׁמְעוּן֮ בְּקוֹל֒ יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיכֶ֔ם

“you will listen to the voice of Yahweh your God”

Yahweh is using **listen to the voice of Yahweh your God** as a common expression of the culture to mean “obey what Yahweh your God commands.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers,

you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will obey Yahweh your God]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 6:15 (#6)

בְּקֹ֖ול יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיכֶֽם

“to the voice of Yahweh your God”

Here, **the voice of Yahweh your God** represents “the commands of Yahweh your God.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the instructions of Yahweh your God]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah - Chapter 7 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Zechariah 7 shifts from prophetic visions to prose narrative. A delegation from Bethel asks whether to continue fast in the fifth month, and Yahweh responds with two oracles (vv. 4–7, 8–14) that redirect the question from ritual observance to justice, covenant faithfulness, and mercy.

Chapters 7–8 as a Mirrored Unit

Chapters 7–8 are shaped as a mirrored (chiastic) unit: the opening question about fasting (7:1–3) is answered at the very end (8:18–19); the first sermon on fasting (7:4–14) is balanced by a second sermon (8:9–17), with the covenant sayings (8:1–8) forming the center.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Fasting as Ritual Mourning

The fifth-month fast commemorated the destruction of Solomon’s temple. Yahweh challenges the people as to whether this practice honored him or merely served the people themselves.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Nested Quotation Levels

Verses 5–7 and 9–10 contain three levels of quotation (narrator, Yahweh, inner message), requiring careful management of quotation marking conventions.

Zechariah 7:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי֙ בִּשְׁנַ֣ת אַרְבַּ֔ע לְדָרְיָ֖וֶשׁ הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“And it happened in the fourth year of Darius the king”

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 7:1 (#2)

בִּשְׁנַ֣ת אַרְבַּ֔ע לְדָרְיָ֖וֶשׁ הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ & בְּאַרְבָּעָ֥ה לַחֹ֛דֶשׁ הַתְּשִׁעִ֖י בְּכִסְלֵֽו

“in the fourth year of Darius the king & on the fourth {day} of the ninth month, in Kislev”

Here Zechariah is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 7:1 (#3)

הָיָ֥ה דְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה אֶל־זְכַרְיָֽה

“the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah”

The name **Zechariah** refers to the prophet himself, who also narrates this book in the first person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the word of Yahweh came to me, Zechariah]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:1 (#4)

בְּאַרְבָּעָ֥ה לַחֹ֛דֶשׁ הַתְּשִׁעִ֖י

“on the fourth {day} of the ninth month”

If your language would not represent numbers in a form such as **fourth** and **ninth**, you could represent these numbers in a form that your language would use. Alternate translation: [on day four of month nine]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Zechariah 7:1 (#5)

לַחֹ֛דֶשׁ הַתְּשִׁעִ֖י בְּכִסְלֵֽו

“of the ninth month, in Kislev”

The **Kislev** month of the Hebrew calendar includes parts of November and December on Western calendars. You could convert the Hebrew day and month into an approximate date on the calendar that your culture uses. However, the Jews used a lunar calendar, so if you use a solar calendar, the date will be different every year, and the translation will not be entirely accurate. So you may just want to give the number of

the day and the name of the month on the Hebrew calendar and say in a footnote approximately what time of year that is on your calendar.

See: Hebrew Months

Zechariah 7:2 (#1)

בֵּית־אֵ֔ל

“Bethel”

Here, **Bethel** represents the people who lived in that city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people who lived in Bethel]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 7:2 (#2)

שַׂר־אֶ֥צֶר וְרֶגֶם מֶ֖לֶךְ

“Sharezer and Regem-Melech”

The words **Sharezer and Regem-Melech** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 7:2 (#3)

וְאַנְשָׁ֥יו

“and his men”

The pronoun **their** refers to Sharezer and Regem-Melech. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the men who were with them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:2 (#4)

אֶת־פְּנֵ֖י יְהוָֽה

“before the face of Yahweh”

Here, **the face of Yahweh** represents his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 7:3 (#1)

הַאֶבְכֶּ֤ה & בַּמֶּ֔ה

“Should I mourn & many”

The pronoun **I** refers to the people of Bethel collectively, speaking through their envoys. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Should we mourn in the fifth month by means of a fast, as we have done these many years]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:3 (#2)

לְבֵ֣ית־יְהוָ֔ה צְבָאֹֽות

“at the house of Yahweh of Armies”

Here Zechariah is speaking of the temple as if it were a **house** in which Yahweh lived. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the temple where Yahweh of hosts lives]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:3 (#3)

לֵאמֹ֔ר אֶל־הַכֹּהֲנִים֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר׀ לְבֵ֣ית־יְהוָ֔ה צְבָאֹ֑ות וְאֶל־הַנְּבִיאִ֖ים לֵאמֹ֑ר הֶאֶבְכֶּ֤ה בַּחֹ֙דֶשׁ֙ הַחֲמִשִּׁ֔י הִנָּזֵ֖ר כַּאֲשֶׁ֣ר עָשִׂ֑יתִי זֶ֛ה כַּמֶּ֥ה שָׁנִֽים

“saying to the priests who {were} at the house of Yahweh of Armies, {and} to the prophets saying, “Should I mourn in the fifth month by means of a fast, as I have done these many years”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [They asked the priests who were at the house of Yahweh of hosts and the prophets whether they should mourn in the fifth month by means of a fast, as they had done for many years]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 7:5 (#1)

לֵאמֹ֣ר כִּֽי־צַמְתֶּ֗ם

“and say, ‘When you fasted”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and ask them if when you fasted]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 7:5 (#2)

כִּֽי־צַמְתֶּ֤ם וְסָפֹד֙

“When you fasted and mourned”

The word **you** is plural here because Yahweh is addressing all the people of the land and the priests, so

use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Zechariah 7:5 (#3)

הֲצֹום צַמְתֶּתֻנִי אֲנִי

"were you fasting, fasting for me"

Yahweh is using the question form to rebuke the people for fasting for their own benefit rather than truly honoring him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [you were not truly fasting for me.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 7:5 (#4)

הֲצֹום צַמְתֶּתֻנִי אֲנִי

"were you fasting, fasting for me"

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **fasting** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [were you truly fasting for me]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 7:6 (#1)

וְכִי תֹאכְלוּ וְכִי תִשְׁתּוּ

"When you ate and when you drank"

The word **you** is plural here because Yahweh is continuing to address all the people of the land and the priests, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Zechariah 7:6 (#2)

הֲלוֹא אַתֶּם הָאֹכְלִים וְאַתֶּם הַשֹּׁתִים

"did you not eat and drink for yourselves"

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that the people were eating and drinking for their own benefit. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [you ate and drank only for yourselves.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 7:7 (#1)

הֲלֹוא אֶת־הַדְּבָרִים אֲשֶׁר קָרָא יְהוָה

"Were these not the words that Yahweh proclaimed"

Yahweh is using the question form to remind the people that these are the same messages he gave through the earlier prophets. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [These were the same words that Yahweh proclaimed]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 7:7 (#2)

הֲלֹוא אֶת־הַדְּבָרִים

"Were these not the words"

The next verse clarifies that the pronoun **these** refers to the messages about justice and mercy that Yahweh had proclaimed through the earlier prophets. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Were these messages about justice and mercy not the same words that]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:7 (#3)

בְּיַד הַנְּבִיאִים הָרִאשֹׁנִים

"by the hand of the former prophets"

Here, **by the hand of the former prophets** represents the words that the prophets spoke. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by what the former prophets said]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 7:7 (#4)

בִּהְיוֹת יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם יֹשֶׁבֶת וּשְׁלֵוָה וְעָרֶיהָ סְבִיבֹתֶיהָ

"when you still inhabited Jerusalem and the surrounding cities in prosperity"

Zechariah is using the clause **when you still inhabited Jerusalem and the surrounding cities in prosperity** to describe something that was ongoing. This provides the background for the prophetic messages that Yahweh proclaimed during this time. Connect this clause to the story in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is describing something that

was ongoing in the background. Alternate translation: [while you were still living in Jerusalem and the surrounding cities in prosperity and were settled in the Negev, and the foothills to the west]

See: Connect — Background Information

Zechariah 7:7 (#5)

וְהַנֶּגֶב & יֹשֵׁב

“and were settled in the Negev”

The expression **were settled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and had settled in the Negev]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 7:8 (#1)

וַיְהִי֙ דְּבַר־יְהוָ֔ה אֶל־זְכַרְיָ֖ה

“The word of Yahweh came to Zechariah”

Zechariah is using the phrase **The word of Yahweh came** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 7:9 (#1)

כֹּ֤ה אָמַר֙ יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹת֔ לֵאמֹ֖ר

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies saying”

The word from Yahweh in verses 9–14 are providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 7:9 (#2)

כֹּ֤ה אָמַר֙ יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹת֔ לֵאמֹ֖ר מִשְׁפַּ֣ט אֱמֶ֑ת שְׁפֹ֣טוּ

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies saying, ‘Judge with true justice”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh of Armies commands you to judge with true justice]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 7:9 (#3)

לֵאמֹ֖ר

“saying”

The phrase **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 7:9 (#4)

אֱמֶ֑ת שְׁפֹ֣טוּ

“with true justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [rightly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 7:9 (#5)

וְחֶ֥סֶד וְרַחֲמִ֖ים

“and covenant faithfulness, and mercy”

The terms **covenant faithfulness** and **mercy** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [and steadfast love]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 7:9 (#6)

וְחֶ֥סֶד

“and covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [be faithful to what you agreed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 7:9 (#7)

וְרַחֲמִ֖ים

“and mercy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mercy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and be merciful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 7:9 (#8)

עֲשׂוּ אִישׁ אֶת־אָחִיו

“Let each man do this for his brother”

Here the masculine terms **man** and **his brother** have a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [Let each person do this for one another]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 7:9 (#9)

אֶת־אָחִיו

“for his brother”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if each fellow Israelite were **his brother**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for his fellow Israelite]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:10 (#1)

וְרָעַתתְּ

“and & evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and ... anything harmful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 7:10 (#2)

בִּלְבַבְכֶם

“in your heart”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if people’s thoughts and intentions were located in their **heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:11 (#1)

וַיְמָאֲנוּ

“But they refused”

The pronoun **they** refers to the ancestors of the people Yahweh is currently addressing, not to the current audience. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [But their ancestors refused]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:11 (#2)

וַיִּתְּנוּ כָתֵף סֹרֶרֶת

“and gave a stubborn shoulder”

Here Zechariah is speaking of the people as if they were stubborn animals that **gave a stubborn shoulder** and refused to be led. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and refused to be led or directed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:11 (#3)

וְאָזְנֵיהֶם הִכְבִּידוּ מִשְּׁמֹועַ

“Their ears were heavy from hearing”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if their **ears were heavy** so that they could not hear. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Their ears were closed to hearing] or [They would not listen]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:12 (#1)

וְלִבָּם שָׂשָׂמוּ שָׁמִיר

“They made their heart as rock”

The point of this comparison is that just as **rock** is hard and unyielding, so were the people’s hearts resistant to Yahweh’s commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They hardened their hearts and made them unwilling to obey]

See: Simile

Zechariah 7:12 (#2)

אֶת־הַתּוֹרָה

“the law”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the law**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what God commanded]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 7:12 (#3)

בְּיַד֙ הַנְּבִיאִ֣ים הָרִאשֹׁנִ֔ים

“by the hand of the former prophets”

See how you translated this same phrase in Zechariah 7:7. Alternate translation: [through the words of the prophets]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 7:13 (#1)

קָרָ֣א

“he called”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh called]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:13 (#2)

וְלֹ֣א שָׁמְע֔וּ כֵּ֚ן יִקְרְא֣וּ וְלֹ֔א אֶשְׁמָ֖ע

“and they did not listen, so when they call, I will not listen”

The first pronoun **they** refer to the ancestors who refused to listen in the past, the second refers to any future hearers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the ancestors did not listen, so when their descendants call I will not listen]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:13 (#3)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֣ר & כֵּ֔ן

“as when & so”

The phrases translated as **as when ... so** indicates that what follows is a result that mirrors what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a consequence of what came before. Alternate translation: [So because when he called, they did not listen, they will call out to me, but I will not answer]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 7:14 (#1)

וְאֲסָעֲרֵ֖ם

“And I scattered them with a whirlwind”

Here Yahweh is speaking of his judgment as if it were **a whirlwind** that scatters people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For I violently scattered them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 7:14 (#2)

אַחֲרֵיהֶ֑ם

“after them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the Israelites whom Yahweh has scattered. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [after the Israelites are gone]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 7:14 (#3)

מֵעֹבֵ֥ר וּמְשָׁ֖ב

“from anyone passing through or returning”

Yahweh is referring to all human activity in the land by naming two major components, **pass through** and **returning**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [For no one will ever be in the land again]

See: Merism

Zechariah 7:14 (#4)

אֶ֣רֶץ־חֶמְדָּ֔ה

“the land of desire”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **land of desire** that is characterized by being desirable. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the desirable land]

See: Possession

Zechariah - Chapter 8 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter presents a series of prophetic oracles introduced by the messenger formula “Thus says Yahweh of Armies” moving from Yahweh’s commitment to Zion (vv. 1–8) through encouragement to rebuild the temple (vv. 9–15), ethical demands (vv. 16–17), and a vision of the nations seeking Yahweh (vv. 18–23).

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Fasts Becoming Festivals
The four fast days commemorating Jerusalem's fall will become joyful celebrations when Yahweh restores his people.

Zechariah 8:1 (#1)

לֵאמֹֽר

"saying"

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:1 (#2)

וַיְהִ֥י דְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה צְבָאֹֽות

"And the word of Yahweh of Armies came"

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 8:2 (#1)

כֹּ֤ה אָמַר֙ יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֹ֔ות

"Thus says Yahweh of Armies"

The phrase **Thus says Yahweh of Armies** introduces a direct quotation from Yahweh. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:2 (#2)

כֹּ֤ה אָמַר֙ יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֹ֔ות קִנֵּ֥אתִי לְצִיּ֖וֹן

"Thus says Yahweh of Armies, 'I have been jealous for Zion"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. In this verse, Zechariah is quoting what Yahweh says directly. Alternate translation: [I, Yahweh of hosts, am passionate for Zion]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 8:2 (#3)

קִנֵּ֥אתִי לְצִיּ֖וֹן קִנְאָ֣ה גְדוֹלָ֑ה וְחֵמָ֥ה גְדוֹלָ֖ה קִנֵּ֥אתִי לָֽהּ

"I have been jealous for Zion {with} a great jealousy, and I have been jealous for her {with} great heat"

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I have been extremely jealous for Zion with great heat]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 8:2 (#4)

קִנְאָ֣ה גְדוֹלָ֑ה

"with} a great jealousy"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **jealousy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and desire to keep her as my own]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:2 (#5)

לָֽהּ

"for her {with"

The pronoun **her** refers to Zion. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for Zion with]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 8:2 (#6)

וְחֵמָ֥ה גְדוֹלָ֖ה קִנֵּ֥אתִי לָֽהּ

"and I have been jealous for her {with} great heat"

Yahweh is speaking of his strong jealousy as if it were **heat**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I have been jealous for her with much anger toward her enemies]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:3 (#1)

כֹּ֤ה אָמַר֙ יְהוָ֔ה

"Thus says Yahweh"

The phrase **Thus says Yahweh** introduces a direct quotation from Yahweh. In your translation, use a

natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:3 (#2)

כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה שַׁבְתִּי אֶל־צִיּוֹן

“Thus says Yahweh, ‘I will return to Zion”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. In this verse, Zechariah is quoting what Yahweh says directly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will return to Zion]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 8:3 (#3)

יְרוּשָׁלִַם וְנִקְרְאָה

“and Jerusalem will be called”

The expression **Jerusalem will be called** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people will call Jerusalem]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 8:3 (#4)

וְהַר־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“and the mountain of Yahweh of Armies”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh of Armies**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [and my mountain]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 8:3 (#5)

יְרוּשָׁלִַם וְנִקְרְאָה & עִיר־הָאֱמֶת

“and Jerusalem will be called “the city of faithfulness”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **city of faithfulness** that is characterized by being faithful. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the faithful city]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:3 (#6)

הָאֱמֶת

“faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [where people are faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:3 (#7)

וְהַר־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“and the mountain of Yahweh of Armies”

Yahweh assumes that readers will know that **the mountain of Yahweh of hosts** refers to Mount Zion. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and Mount Zion]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 8:3 (#8)

צְבָאוֹת הַהָר

“Armies, “the mountain of”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Armies will be called “the mountain of]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 8:3 (#9)

הַהָר הַקֹּדֶשׁ

“the mountain of holiness”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe **the mountain of holiness** as a mountain that is characterized by holiness. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the holy mountain]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:4 (#1)

כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:2.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:4 (#2)

זְקֵנִים וּזְקֵנוֹת

“Old men and old women”

Yahweh is referring to all elderly people by naming two major components, **Old men** and **old women**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The elderly]

See: Merism

Zechariah 8:4 (#3)

וְאִישׁ מִשְׁעַנְתּוֹ בְּיָדוֹ

“and a man {with} his staff in his hand”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [and each person with a staff in hand]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 8:4 (#4)

מֵרֹב יָמִים

“from a multitude of days”

Yahweh is using **from a multitude of days** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of old age.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of old age]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 8:5 (#1)

וּרְחֹבוֹת הָעִירׇ יִמָּלְאוּ יְלָדִים וִילָדוֹת

“And the open areas of the city will be filled {with} boys and girls”

The expression **will be filled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Boys and girls will fill the open areas of the city,]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 8:5 (#2)

יְלָדִים וִילָדוֹת

“boys and girls”

Yahweh is referring to all children by naming both major components, **boys** and **girls**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the children]

See: Merism

Zechariah 8:6 (#1)

כֹּה אָמַרׇ יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“Thus says Yahweh of Armies”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:2.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:6 (#2)

כִּי יִפָּלֵא

“If it is wonderful”

Yahweh is speaking as if this were a hypothetical possibility, but he means that it is actually true. If your language does not state something as a condition if it is certain or true, or if your readers might think that what Yahweh is saying is uncertain, then you could translate this as a confident statement. Alternate translation: [Since it is wonderful]

See: Connect — Factual Conditions

Zechariah 8:6 (#3)

בְּעֵינֵיׇ שְׁאֵרִיתׇ הָעָם הַזֶּה

“in the eyes of the remnant of this people”

Yahweh is using **in the eyes of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the opinion of the remnant of this people]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 8:6 (#4)

גַּם & יִפָּלֵא

“will it also be wonderful”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that nothing is too difficult for him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [it will not be wonderful in my eyes]

See: Rhetorical Question

Zechariah 8:6 (#5)

נְאֻם יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

The phrase **declaration of Yahweh of Armies** affirms that the preceding words are from Yahweh. In your translation, use a natural way of representing this kind of affirmation in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:7 (#1)

הִנְנִי

“Behold”

Yahweh is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look!]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 8:7 (#2)

מֵאֶרֶץ מִזְרָח וּמֵאֶרֶץ מְבוֹא הַשָּׁמֶשׁ

“from the land of the sunrise and from the land of the setting of the sun”

Yahweh is referring to all of the places where his people are scattered by naming two extremes, **the land of the sunrise** and **the land of the setting of the sun**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from every country, whether east or west]

See: Merism

Zechariah 8:8 (#1)

אֶהְיֶה לָהֶם֙ לֵאלֹהִ֔ים

“I will be to them as God”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a covenant relationship in which he is the God whom the people worship and serve. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will be the God whom they worship and serve]

See: Possession

Zechariah 8:8 (#2)

וַאֲנִי֙ אֶהְיֶ֔ה

“and I, I will be”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will be** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his own commitment to be the God of his people, matching the reciprocal relationship he describes: they will be his people, and he himself will be their God. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and I myself will be]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 8:8 (#3)

בֶּאֱמֶת֙ וּבְצֶדֶ֔קָה

“in faithfulness and in righteousness”

The phrase **in faithfulness and in righteousness** expresses a single idea. The word **faithfulness** tells more about **righteousness**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [with faithful righteousness]

See: Hendiadys

Zechariah 8:9 (#1)

תֶּחֱזַקְנָה יְדֵיכֶם

“May your hands be strong”

Yahweh is using **hands** to represent the whole person and their courage to work. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Be strong and courageous]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 8:9 (#2)

הַשֹּׁמְעִים֙ בַּיָּמִ֣ים הָאֵ֔לֶּה אֵ֚ת הַדְּבָרִ֣ים הָאֵ֔לֶּה מִפִּי֙ הַנְּבִיאִ֔ים אֲשֶׁ֖ר בְּי֣וֹם יֻסַּ֗ד בֵּית־יְהוָ֥ה צְבָאוֹת

“you who are hearing in these days these words from the mouth of the prophets who {were} there on the day {when} the house of Yahweh of Armies was founded”

This could mean: (1) the message Zechariah is giving today is almost the same as the message that Haggai (probably) gave when the temple construction

started. Alternate translation: [you who are hearing today these same words as were from the mouth of the prophets who stood there on the day the house of Yahweh of Armies was founded] (2) prophets had repeatedly given a similar message ever since temple construction had started, these people had been hearing that. Alternate translation: [you who have kept hearing in these days these words from the mouth of the prophets ever since the day the house of Yahweh of Armies was founded]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 8:9 (#3)

יֻסַּד בֵּית־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“the house of Yahweh of Armies was founded”

The expression **was founded** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they founded the house of Yahweh of Armies]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 8:9 (#4)

הַהֵיכָל לְהִבָּנוֹת

“the temple to be built”

The expression **to be built** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so that they would build the temple]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 8:9 (#5)

מִפִּי הַנְּבִיאִים

“from the mouth of the prophets”

Yahweh is using **the mouth of the prophets** to represent what the prophets said. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the prophets]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 8:10 (#1)

כִּי לִפְנֵי הַיָּמִים הָהֵם שְׂכַר הָאָדָם לֹא נִהְיָה וּשְׂכַר הַבְּהֵמָה אֵינֶנָּה וְלַיּוֹצֵא וְלַבָּבָא אֵין־שָׁלוֹם מִן־הַצָּר וַאֲשַׁלַּח אֶת־כָּל־הָאָדָם אִישׁ בְּרֵעֵהוּ

“For to the face of those days, the wages of man were not, and the wages of the beast, there were none. And for the one going out and for the one coming in there was no peace from the enemy, and I sent every man, each against his neighbor”

Here Yahweh is providing background information to help his listeners understand the contrast he is making. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 8:10 (#2)

לִפְנֵי הַיָּמִים הָהֵם

“to the face of those days”

Yahweh is using the expression **to the face of** to mean “before” or “previous to.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [before those days]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 8:10 (#3)

שְׂכַר הָאָדָם

“the wages of man”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [the wages of people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 8:10 (#4)

שְׂכַר הָאָדָם לֹא נִהְיָה וּשְׂכַר הַבְּהֵמָה אֵינֶנָּה

“the wages of man were not, and the wages of the beast, there were none”

Yahweh is referring to all sources of income by naming two major components, **the wages of man** and **the wages of the beast**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [no money could be made in any way]

See: Merism

Zechariah 8:10 (#5)

וְלַיּוֹצֵא וְלַבָּבָא

“And for the one going out and for the one coming in”

Yahweh is referring to all of a person's daily activities by naming two opposites, **the one going out** and **the one coming in**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And for everyone in all their activities]

See: Merism

Zechariah 8:10 (#6)

שָׁלוֹם

"peace"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [safety]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:10 (#7)

אֶת־כָּל־הָאָדָם אִישׁ בְּרֵעֵהוּ

"every man, each against his neighbor"

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [every person against their neighbor]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 8:11 (#1)

נְאֻם יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

"the declaration of Yahweh of Armies"

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:6.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:11 (#2)

וְעַתָּה לֹא כַיָּמִים הָרִאשֹׁנִים אֲנִי לִשְׁאֵרִית הָעָם הַזֶּה נְאֻם יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

"But now, I will not be to the remnant of this people like the former days'—the declaration of Yahweh of Armies"

Yahweh uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the former days and the present time. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, now I will not treat the remnant of this people as I did in the former days'—the declaration of Yahweh of Armies.]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 8:12 (#1)

זֶרַע הַשָּׁלוֹם

"there} will be the seed of peace"

Yahweh is speaking of future prosperity as if it were a **seed** planted in peace that would produce an abundant harvest. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [there will be peace and prosperity]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:12 (#2)

כִּי

"For"

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Instead]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 8:12 (#3)

הַשָּׁלוֹם

"peace"

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:10.

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:12 (#4)

הַגֶּפֶן תִּתֵּן פִּרְיָהּ וְהָאָרֶץ תִּתֵּן אֶת־יְבוּלָהּ וְהַשָּׁמַיִם יִתְּנוּ טַלָּם

"the vine will give its fruit, and the land will give its produce, and the heavens will give their dew"

Yahweh speaks of **the vine**, **the land**, and **the heavens** as if they were persons who could **give** things to people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fruit will come from the vine, produce will come from the land, and dew will fall from the heavens]

See: Personification

Zechariah 8:13 (#1)

וְהָיָה כַּאֲשֶׁר הֱיִיתֶם קְלָלָה בַּגּוֹיִם בֵּית יְהוּדָה וּבֵית יִשְׂרָאֵל כֵּן אוֹשִׁיעַ אֶתְכֶם וְהְיִיתֶם בְּרָכָה אַל־תִּירָאוּ תֶּחֱזַקְנָה יְדֵיכֶם

"And it will be just as you were a curse in the nations, house of Judah and house of Israel, so I will

save you and you will be a blessing. Do not fear; let your hands be strong"

The point of this comparison is that just as **you were a curse in the nations** was certainly true, so it will certainly be true that Yahweh will save them and they will be a blessing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Just as it was certainly true that you were a curse among the nations, house of Judah and house of Israel, so it will certainly also be true that I save you and you will be a blessing. Do not fear; let your hands be strong!]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 8:13 (#2)

וֶֽהְיִיתֶ֣ם קְלָלָ֔ה בַּגּוֹיִ֑ם

"you were a curse in the nations"

Yahweh is speaking of his people as if they were a **curse**, meaning that other nations would refer to them as an example of what it means to be cursed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the other nations used you as an example of what it means to be cursed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:13 (#3)

קְלָלָ֔ה

"a curse"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **curse**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of people who were cursed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:13 (#4)

בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה וּבֵ֖ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

"house of Judah and house of Israel"

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **house of Judah** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Judah, and **house of Israel** means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [people of Judah and people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:13 (#5)

וְהָיִיתֶ֥ם בְּרָכָ֖ה

"and you will be a blessing"

Yahweh is speaking of his people as if they would actually become a **blessing**, meaning that other nations would refer to them as an example of what it means to be blessed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you will be an example of what it means to be blessed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:13 (#6)

בְּרָכָ֑ה

"a blessing"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **blessing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you will be blessed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:13 (#7)

אַל־תִּירָ֖אוּ תֶּחֱזַ֥קְנָה יְדֵיכֶֽם

"Do not fear; let your hands be strong"

Yahweh is using **hands** to represent the whole person and their courage to work. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Be strong and courageous]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 8:14 (#1)

לְהָרַ֥ע לָכֶ֛ם

"to cause harm to you"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **harm**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to harm you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:14 (#2)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֨ר

"Just as"

Yahweh uses the words **Just as** and "thus" (next verse) here to indicate a contrast between what he did in the past and what he will do in the future. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 8:14 (#3)

אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

"says Yahweh of Armies"

The phrase **says Yahweh of Armies** is a parenthetical remark that reminds the listener that these are Yahweh's words. In your translation, use a natural way of representing this kind of attribution in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:15 (#1)

שַׁבְתִּי זָמַמְתִּי

"I have turned; I plan"

The words **I have turned** and **I plan** express a single idea. The word **turned** indicates that Yahweh is planning again, reversing his earlier purpose to bring harm. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [I again plan] or [I have decided once more]

See: Hendiadys

Zechariah 8:16 (#1)

אֱמֶת

"truth"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:16 (#2)

אִישׁ אֶת־רֵעֵהוּ

"each with his neighbor"

Here the masculine term **his** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [every person with their neighbor]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 8:16 (#3)

שָׁלוֹם

"peace"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and peaceful resolutions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:16 (#4)

בְּשַׁעֲרֵיכֶם

"in your gates"

Yahweh is using **gates** to represent the places where legal judgments are made. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your courts]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 8:16 (#5)

אֱמֶת וּמִשְׁפַּט שָׁלוֹם שִׁפְטוּ בְּשַׁעֲרֵיכֶם

"judge in your gates {with} faithfulness and a judgement of peace"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [judge in your gates faithfully and peacefully]

Zechariah 8:16 (#6)

וּמִשְׁפַּט שָׁלוֹם

"and a judgement of peace"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgement**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and make decisions that bring peace]

Zechariah 8:17 (#1)

אֶת־רָעַת

"evil"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [do harmful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:17 (#2)

בִּלְבַבְכֶם

“within his heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 8:17 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

The phrase **the declaration of Yahweh** affirms that the preceding words are from Yahweh. This quotation began at verse 2. In your translation, use a natural way of representing this kind of affirmation in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:18 (#1)

וַיְהִי דְּבַר־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת אֵלַי

“And the word of Yahweh of Armies came to me”

Zechariah is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 8:18 (#2)

לֵאמֹר

“saying”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:1.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 8:19 (#1)

לְשָׂשׂוֹן

“into joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [joyful times]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:19 (#2)

לְשָׂשׂוֹן וּלְשִׂמְחָה

“into joy, and into gladness”

The terms **joy** and **gladness** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [times of great joy]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 8:19 (#3)

וּלְשִׂמְחָה

“and into gladness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **gladness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when you gladly celebrate]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:19 (#4)

וְהָאֱמֶת

“And & faithfulness”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:16.

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:19 (#5)

וְהַשָּׁלוֹם

“and peace”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:16.

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:21 (#1)

אֶת־פְּנֵי יְהוָה

“the face of Yahweh”

Here, **the face of Yahweh** represents the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 8:21 (#2)

לֵאמֹר נֵלְכָה הָלוֹךְ & אֵלְכָה גַּם־אֲנִי

“saying, “Let us quickly go & I, I also will go”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. For example, you could translate the direct quotation as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that they should quickly go ... And that they themselves would also go]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 8:21 (#3)

אֵלְכָה גַם־אֲנִי

“I, I also will go”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I also will go** already includes this meaning. The speaker is doing that to emphasize his own eagerness to join in seeking Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I myself will also go]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 8:22 (#1)

לְבַקֵּשׁ אֶת־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת & וּלְחַלּוֹת אֶת־פְּנֵי יְהוָה

“to seek Yahweh of Armies & and beg the face of Yahweh”

See how you translated these same phrases in the previous verse.

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 8:23 (#1)

עֲשָׂרָה אֲנָשִׁים מִכֹּל לְשֹׁנְוֹת הַגּוֹיִם

“ten men from every language of the nations”

Yahweh is making an extreme statement, saying **ten men from every language of the nations**, to emphasize the great number of foreigners who will seek to worship him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [countless people from every language and nation]

See: Hyperbole

Zechariah 8:23 (#2)

יַחֲזִיקוּ & וְהֶחֱזִיקוּ בִּכְנַף

“will grab, and they will grab the hem of”

To **grab the hem** of someone’s robe was a symbolic action that expressed a strong desire to accompany that person. If this would not be understood in your culture, you could use a comparable symbolic action from your culture or describe what this action meant. Alternate translation: [will beg, they will beg to come along with]

See: Symbolic Action

Zechariah 8:23 (#3)

יַחֲזִיקוּ & וְהֶחֱזִיקוּ בִּכְנַף

“will grab, and they will grab the hem of”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **will grab** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [will grab tightly the hem of]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 8:23 (#4)

לֵאמֹר נֵלְכָה עִמָּכֶם כִּי שָׁמַעְנוּ אֱלֹהִים עִמָּכֶם

“saying, “Let us go with you, for we have heard God is with you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. For example, you could translate the direct quotation as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that they want to go with him because they have heard that God is with him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah - Chapter 9 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a prophetic oracle (the “burden of the word of Yahweh”) that moves from judgment on the surrounding nations (verses 1–8) to the coming of a righteous, humble king who brings peace (verses 9–10), then to Yahweh’s deliverance and restoration of his people (verses 11–17).

Chapters 9–14 as a Larger Chiasm

Chapters 9–14 are often read as one long, mirrored (chiastic) structure. This chapter’s judgment on the surrounding nations (9:1–8) is balanced at the very end by Yahweh’s kingship over all the earth (14:16–21), while themes of celebration, the rejection of false

shepherds, and mourning for the pierced one recur in matching pairs in between.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The blood of the covenant
In verse 11, "the blood of your covenant" refers to the sacrifices that ratified Yahweh's agreement with Israel, the basis for his freeing his people.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Verse 1
The first verse has several difficulties. The first set centers on Yahweh's relationship with Hadrach and Damascus. Many English Bibles translate the preposition here (Yahweh "in" the land) as "against'," but that preposition does not usually have that meaning. It is also not clear what is resting in Damascus. Is it Yahweh or his word or the burden? What does it mean to be his resting place? For the first set, the text and notes will lean toward an interpretation such as "this prophecy is about some place near Hadrach and Damascus; Yahweh is especially present there right now because he is about to do something." The second set of difficulties centers on the question of whose eyes are looking at whom? Is Yahweh watching the world and Israelites closely? Are the world and the Israelites watching Yahweh closely (as verse 5 may suggest)? Why (beyond translation)? The text and notes will lean toward the interpretation that Yahweh is watching the world closely. This seems to fit with other parts of the book (4:10, 12:4) and verse 8. If a local translation makes a clear decision, you may wish to follow that. Otherwise you may wish to follow the decisions made here.

Shifting speakers and personified cities
The speaker shifts between the prophet and Yahweh (first person), and cities such as Tyre and Ekron are personified as women; track these shifts throughout the chapter.

The Lord
In verse 4 and 14, Yahweh is referred to as "Lord." While we do not recommend following the custom of translating Yahweh as LORD, if that is the decision your translation has made, you will need to take special care in verse 14 where the text reads "the Lord Yahweh" and follow how you have translated that combination in other places (Ezekiel).

Zechariah 9:1 (#1)

מַשָּׂא דְבַר־יְהוָה

"The burden of the word of Yahweh"

Zechariah is using the words translated as **The burden of the word of Yahweh** to introduce a new section of his prophecy. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 9:1 (#2)

בְּאֶרֶץ

"in the land of"

The word translated as **in** could mean: (1) concerning. Alternate translation: [about the land of] (2) against. Alternate translation: [against the land of]

Zechariah 9:1 (#3)

מְנֻחָתֹו

"his resting place"

The pronoun **his** could refer to: (1) Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh's resting place] or (2) the word of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [the resting place of Yahweh's word]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:1 (#4)

כִּי לַיהוָה עֵין אָדָם וְכֹל שִׁבְטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

"for toward Yahweh are the eye of mankind and all of the tribes of Israel"

This could mean: (1) Yahweh is attentive to all the world and especially Israel. Alternate translation: [Yahweh's eyes watch all of mankind and all of the tribes of Israel] or (2) everyone in the world, including Israel, are attentive to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [all of mankind and all of the tribes of Israel watch Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:2 (#1)

תִּגְבָל־בָּהּ

"borders on it"

The pronoun **it** refers to the land of Hadrach and Damascus. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [borders on the land of Hadrach and Damascus]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:2 (#2)

צֹר וְצִידוֹן

“Tyre and Sidon”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [as do Tyre and Sidon]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 9:2 (#3)

צֹר וְצִידוֹן כִּֽי חָכְמָה מְאֹד

“Tyre and Sidon, for they are very wise”

Here, **they** represents the people who live in **Tyre and Sidon**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Tyre and Sidon, for their inhabitants are very wise]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:2 (#4)

כִּֽי חָכְמָה מְאֹד

“for they are very wise”

Yahweh actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for they consider themselves very wise]

See: Irony

Zechariah 9:3 (#1)

וַתִּתְבֶּן צֹר מָצוֹר לָֽהּ

“And Tyre has built herself a stronghold”

Zechariah is speaking of the city **Tyre** as if it were a living woman who **built herself a stronghold**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the people of Tyre have built themselves a stronghold]

See: Personification

Zechariah 9:3 (#2)

וַתִּתְבֶּן צֹר מָצוֹר לָֽהּ

“And Tyre has built herself a stronghold”

The word **herself** indicates that the object of the verb is the same as the subject of the verb. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that the same person fills two roles in the sentence. Alternate translation: [And Tyre has built a stronghold for her own benefit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:3 (#3)

וַתִּצְבָּר־כֶּֽסֶף כָּעָפָר וְחָרוּץ כְּטִיט חוּצוֹת

“and heaped up silver like dust, and refined gold like the mud of the streets”

The point of this comparison is that just as **dust** and **the mud of the streets** are extremely common and plentiful, so the **silver** and **refined gold** that Tyre accumulated were extremely abundant. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [heaped up silver and refined gold in very great abundance]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:4 (#1)

הִנֵּֽה

“Behold”

Behold! The Lord is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 9:4 (#2)

אֲדֹנָי יוֹרִישֶׁנָּה

“The Lord will dispossess her”

The pronoun **her** refers to the city of Tyre. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The Lord will dispossess Tyre]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:4 (#3)

וְהִכָּֽה בַיָּ֖ם חֵילָ֑הּ וְהִ֖יא בָּאֵ֥שׁ תֵּאָכֵֽל

“and strike down her wealth on the sea, and she, she will be devoured by fire”

Zechariah is speaking of the city of Tyre as if it were a living woman whose wealth could be struck **down** and who would be **devoured by fire**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will destroy the wealth

of that city on the sea, and the city will be destroyed by fire]

See: Personification

Zechariah 9:4 (#4)

וְהִכָּהּ & חֵילָהּ

“and strike down her wealth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wealth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [strike down all she owns]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:4 (#5)

וְהִוא בָּאֵשׁ תֵּאָכֵל

“and she, she will be devoured by fire”

Here, fire represents “destruction in war.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and she will be destroyed in war]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:4 (#6)

וְהִוא בָּאֵשׁ תֵּאָכֵל

“and she, she will be devoured by fire”

Zechariah is stating the pronoun **she** separately, even though the verb translated as **will be devoured** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Tyre itself will be destroyed. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Tyre itself will be devoured by fire]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:4 (#7)

וְהִוא בָּאֵשׁ תֵּאָכֵל

“and she, she will be devoured by fire”

The expression she will be devoured by fire is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and fire will devour her]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 9:5 (#1)

אַשְׁקְלוֹן & וְעַזָּה & וְעֶקְרוֹן

“Ashkelon & and Gaza & and Ekron”

Here, **Ashkelon**, **Gaza**, and **Ekron** represent the people who live in those cities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Ashkelon ... and the people of Gaza ... And the people of Ekron]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:5 (#2)

וְעַזָּה וְתָחֵיל מְאֹד

“and Gaza, and it will writhe greatly”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if Gaza’s terror were a physical pain that would make the city **writhe greatly**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Gaza also will be greatly distressed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:5 (#3)

כִּי־הֹבִישׁ מִבְטָהּ

“for her hope has dried up”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for she no longer expects good things to happen]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:5 (#4)

וְעֶקְרוֹן כִּי־הֹבִישׁ מִבְטָהּ

“and Ekron, for her hope has dried up”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And Ekron will also see and tremble, for her hope has dried up]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 9:5 (#5)

הֹבִישׁ מִבְטָהּ

“her hope has dried up”

Here Zechariah is speaking of Ekron's **hope** as if it were a stream or spring that has **dried up**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [she has no more hope]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:5 (#6)

וְאַשְׁקְלוֹן לֹא תֵשֵׁב

"and Ashkelon will not be inhabited"

The expression **Ashkelon will not be inhabited** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people will no longer inhabit Ashkelon]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 9:6 (#1)

וְהִכְרַתִּי גְּאוֹן

"and I will cut off the pride of"

The pronoun **I** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh will cut off the pride]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:6 (#2)

וְהִכְרַתִּי גְּאוֹן פְּלִשְׁתִּים

"and I will cut off the pride of the Philistines"

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the **pride of the Philistines** were something that he could **cut off** with a blade. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will put an end to the arrogance of the Philistines]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:6 (#3)

גְּאוֹן פְּלִשְׁתִּים

"the pride of the Philistines"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what the Philistines are proud of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:6 (#4)

וְהִכְרַתִּי גְּאוֹן פְּלִשְׁתִּים

"and I will cut off the pride of the Philistines"

Here, **the pride of the Philistines** represents their mightiness as seen in the glory of their king and their controlling who lives in their own cities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and I will make the Philistines an insignificant people group]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:7 (#1)

וַהֲסִרֹתִי דָמָיו מִפִּיפִיו וְשִׁקֻּצָיו֙ מִבֵּ֣ין שִׁנָּ֔יו

"And I will remove his blood from his mouth and his abominations from between his teeth"

Here, **his blood** and **his abominations** represent the meat with blood in it and the food sacrificed to idols that the Philistines ate. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And I will remove the meat with blood in it from his mouth and the food sacrificed to idols from between his teeth]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:7 (#2)

וַהֲסִרֹתִי דָמָיו מִפִּיפִיו וְשִׁקֻּצָיו֙ מִבֵּ֣ין שִׁנָּ֔יו וְנִשְׁאַ֥ר גַּם־הַה֖וּא לֵאלֹהֵ֑ינוּ וְהָיָה֙ כְּאַלֶּ֣ף בִּיהוּדָ֔ה

"And I will remove his blood from his mouth and his abominations from between his teeth, and he also will be left behind for our God, and he will be like a clan in Judah"

The pronouns **his** and **he** both refer to the Philistines. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I will remove the Philistines' blood from their mouth and their abominations from between their teeth, and they also will be left behind for our God, and they will be like a clan in Judah]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:7 (#3)

וְהָיָה֙ כְּאַלֶּ֣ף בִּיהוּדָ֔ה וְעֶקְרוֹן֙ כִּיבוּסִֽי

"and he will be like a clan in Judah, and Ekron, like a Jebusite"

The point of these comparisons is that just as a clan in Judah belongs fully to Yahweh's people, so the surviving Philistines will belong to Yahweh's people, and

just as a Jebusite was absorbed into Israel, so Ekron will be absorbed among them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and the surviving Philistines will belong to Yahweh's people just as a clan in Judah does, and the people of Ekron will be absorbed among them just as the Jebusites were]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:8 (#1)

וְחָנִיתִי לְבֵיתִי מִצָּבָא מֵעֹבֵר וּמִשָּׁב וְלֹא־יַעֲבֹר עֲלֵיהֶם עוֹד נֹגֵשׂ כִּי עַתָּה רָאִיתִי בְעֵינִי

"And I will camp around my house as a guard against the one passing through and against the one returning, and no oppressor will pass over them again, for now I have seen with my eyes"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the last phrase gives the reason for the result that the rest of the verse describes. Alternate translation: [I am paying close attention to what happens to my people like one camping around my house as a guard against the one passing through and against the one returning, and no oppressor will pass over them again.]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 9:8 (#2)

וְחָנִיתִי לְבֵיתִי

"And I will camp around my house"

Here Yahweh is speaking as if he were an army that would **camp around** his **house** to protect it. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will stand guard around my house]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:8 (#3)

לְבֵיתִי

"around my house"

Here, **my house** represents his temple and the people connected with it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my temple and those who belong to it]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:8 (#4)

מֵעֹבֵר וּמִשָּׁב

"against the one passing through and against the one returning"

Yahweh is using the expressions **the one passing through** and **the one returning** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use such expressions in the same way. If not, you can translate them with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [against enemies who pass through and the enemies who return]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 9:8 (#5)

עֲלֵיהֶם

"them"

The pronoun **them** refers to the people connected with Yahweh's house. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [my people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:8 (#6)

עַתָּה רָאִיתִי בְעֵינִי

"now I have seen with my eyes"

Here, **now I have seen with my eyes** represents "I have begun to pay close attention to and care for my people." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [now I have begun to care for my people]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:9 (#1)

גִּילִי מְאֹד בַּת־צִיּוֹן הָרִיעִי בַּת יְרוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

"Rejoice greatly, daughter of Zion! Shout, daughter of Jerusalem"

The two clauses **Rejoice greatly, daughter of Zion** and **Shout, daughter of Jerusalem** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Rejoice with great joy, people of Zion and Jerusalem!]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 9:9 (#2)

וְנוֹשָׁ֥ע הֽוּא

“and being saved is he”

The expression **being saved** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and God saves him]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 9:9 (#3)

בַּת־צִיּ֖וֹן & בַּבַּ֣ת יְרוּשָׁלָ֑͏ִם

“daughter of Zion & daughter of Jerusalem”

Here Zechariah is speaking of the people of Jerusalem as if they were a **daughter of Zion** or **daughter of Jerusalem**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people of Zion … people of Jerusalem]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:9 (#4)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“Behold”

Zechariah is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 9:9 (#5)

וְרֹכֵ֣ב עַל־חֲמ֔וֹר וְעַל־עַ֖יִר בֶּן־אֲתֹנֽוֹת

“and riding on a donkey, and on a colt, the son of female donkeys”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. There are not two donkeys. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [and riding on a donkey, even on a young donkey] or [and riding on a donkey’s colt]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 9:9 (#6)

עַ֖יִר בֶּן־אֲתֹנֽוֹת

“a colt, the son of female donkeys”

It might seem that the expression **a colt, the son of female donkeys** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [a young donkey]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Zechariah 9:10 (#1)

וְהִכְרַתִּי־רֶ֥כֶב מֵאֶפְרַ֖יִם

“And I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim”

The pronoun **I** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh will cut off the chariot from Ephraim]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:10 (#2)

וְהִכְרַתִּי־רֶ֥כֶב מֵאֶפְרַ֖יִם וְסוּס֙ מִירֽוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם וְנִכְרְתָ֖ה קֶ֥שֶׁת מִלְחָמָ֑ה

“And I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim, and the horse from Jerusalem, and the bow of war will be cut off”

Here, **the chariot from Ephraim, and the horse from Jerusalem, and the bow of war** represents the military power of those regions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will remove all the military power from Ephraim and from Jerusalem]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:10 (#3)

וְנִכְרְתָ֖ה קֶ֥שֶׁת מִלְחָמָ֑ה

“and the bow of war will be cut off”

The expression **the bow of war will be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and I will cut off the bow of war]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 9:10 (#4)

קֶ֥שֶׁת מִלְחָמָ֑ה

“the bow of war”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **bow** that is characterized by its use in **war**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form

for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the bow used in war]

See: Possession

Zechariah 9:10 (#5)

וְדִבֶּ֥ר שָׁלֹ֖ום לַגֹּויִֽם

“And he will speak peace to the nations”

Zechariah is using **speak peace** as a common expression of the culture to mean “proclaim peace.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he will make peace with the nations] or [And he will make the nations behave peacefully]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 9:10 (#6)

וְדִבֶּ֥ר שָׁלֹ֖ום לַגֹּויִֽם

“And he will speak peace to the nations”

The pronoun **he** refers to the king mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the king will speak peace to the nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:10 (#7)

וּמָשְׁלֹ֖ו מִיָּ֣ם עַד־יָ֑ם

“and his dominion will be from sea to sea”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dominion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he will rule from sea to sea]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:10 (#8)

מִיָּ֣ם עַד־יָ֑ם וּמִנָּהָ֖ר עַד־אַפְסֵי־אָֽרֶץ

“will be from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth”

Yahweh is referring to all of the earth by naming two major regions, **from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [across the entire earth]

See: Merism

Zechariah 9:11 (#1)

גַּם־אַתְּ

“As for} you also”

Here Zechariah is using the phrase **As for you also** to introduce the people of Jerusalem as the ones Yahweh now addresses directly. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [As for you also, O Jerusalem]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Zechariah 9:11 (#2)

בְּדַם־בְּרִיתֵ֔ךְ

“by the blood of your covenant”

Here, **the blood of your covenant** represents the sacrificial blood by which Yahweh confirmed his covenant with the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by the sacrificial blood that sealed my covenant with you]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:11 (#3)

שִׁלַּ֥חְתִּי אֲסִירַ֖יִךְ

“I have set free your prisoners”

The pronoun **I** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has set free your prisoners]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:11 (#4)

אֲסִירַ֣יִךְ מִבְּבֹ֔ור אֵ֥ין מַ֖יִם בֹּֽו

“your prisoners from the pit in which there is no water”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the exile and suffering of the people as if they were **prisoners** held in a **pit in which there is no water**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your captives who are dying in desperate misery]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:12 (#1)

אֲסִירֵ֥י הַתִּקְוָ֖ה

“prisoners of hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [prisoners who are hopeful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:12 (#2)

שׁ֚וּבוּ לְבִצָ֣רוֹן אֲסִירֵ֔י הַתִּקְוָ֖ה

“Return to the stronghold, prisoners of hope”

Here Yahweh is speaking of a place of safety and security as if it were a **stronghold** to which the people could return. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Return to the place where you will be safe, prisoners of hope]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:12 (#3)

מְשֻׁנֶּ֖ה אָשִׁ֥יב לָֽךְ

“that I will return double to you”

Yahweh is using **return double to you** as a common expression of the culture to mean “restore to you twice as much as you have lost.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that I will restore to you twice as much as you have lost]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 9:13 (#1)

כִּ֣י

“for”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [in that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 9:13 (#2)

בָּנַ֙יִךְ֙ צִיּ֔וֹן עַל־בָּנַ֖יִךְ יָוָֽן

“your sons, Zion, against your sons, Greece”

Yahweh is using **your sons, Zion** and **your sons, Greece** as common expressions of the culture to mean the people of Zion and the people of Greece. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Zion against the people of Greece]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 9:13 (#3)

דָּרַ֤כְתִּי לִ֙י֙ יְהוּדָ֔ה קֶ֖שֶׁת מִלֵּ֣אתִי אֶפְרַ֑יִם

“I have bent for myself Judah, a bow; I have filled Ephraim”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the people of **Judah** as if they were a **bow** that he bends and of **Ephraim** as the arrow that he uses. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have made the people of Judah like a bow for myself, and I have made the people of Ephraim like arrows]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:13 (#4)

מִלֵּ֣אתִי אֶפְרַ֑יִם

“I have filled Ephraim”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I have filled Ephraim as a quiver of arrows]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 9:13 (#5)

וְשַׂמְתִּ֥יךָ כְּחֶ֖רֶב גִּבּֽוֹר

“and I will make you like the sword of a mighty man”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the sword of a mighty man** is powerful and effective in battle, so Yahweh will make his people powerful against their enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I will make you very powerful in battle]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:14 (#1)

וַיהוָה֙ עֲלֵיהֶ֣ם יֵרָאֶ֔ה

“And Yahweh will appear over them”

The pronoun **them** refers to Yahweh's people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh will appear over his people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:14 (#2)

וְיָצָא כַבָּרָק חִצּוֹ

"and his arrow will go out like the lightning"

The point of this comparison is that just as **the lightning** flashes suddenly and strikes powerfully, so Yahweh's **arrow** will strike his enemies swiftly and powerfully. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and his arrow will go out suddenly and strike powerfully]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:14 (#3)

וַאדֹנָי יְהוִה בַּשּׁוֹפָר יִתְקָע וְהָלַךְ בְּסַעֲרוֹת תֵּימָן

"and the Lord Yahweh will blow on the shofar and will go with the storms of the south"

Zechariah is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a warrior. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the Lord Yahweh will blow on the trumpet and advance furiously, like a mighty warrior]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:15 (#1)

יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת יָגֵן עֲלֵיהֶם

"Yahweh of Armies will defend them"

The pronoun **them** refers to Yahweh's people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh of Armies will defend his people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:15 (#2)

וְאָכְלוּ וְכָבְשׁוּ אַבְנֵי־קָלַע

"and they will devour and will subdue the stones of the sling"

Here Zechariah is speaking of the people utterly defeating their enemies as if they would **devour** them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will completely defeat and will subdue those who attack them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:15 (#3)

וְשָׁתוּ הָמוּ כְּמוֹ־יָיִן

"and they will drink and roar as with wine"

The point of this comparison is that just as men who have drunk **wine** become loud and boisterous, so the people will **drink and roar** in their triumph. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they will drink and roar in triumph just as drunk men roar]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:15 (#4)

וּמָלְאוּ כַּמִּזְרָק כְּזָוִיּוֹת מִזְבֵּחַ

"and they will be full like the bowl, like the corners of the altar"

The point of this comparison is that just as the bowl and the corners of the altar were filled with sacrificial blood, so the people will be full. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and they will be as full as the bowl and the corners of the altar are filled with sacrificial blood]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:16 (#1)

וְהוֹשִׁיעָם יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

"And Yahweh their God will save them"

The pronouns **their** and **them** refer to Yahweh's people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh the God of his people will save his people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:16 (#2)

בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא

"on that day"

Zechariah is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See the Introduction to Zechariah for a discussion of the phrase "in that day."

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 9:16 (#3)

כִּֽי־אַבְנֵי־נֵזֶר

“for they are the stones of a crown”

The pronoun **they** refers to Yahweh’s people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for his people are the stones of a crown]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:16 (#4)

כְּצֹ֣אן עַמּ֔וֹ

“like the flock of his people”

The point of this comparison is that just as a shepherd rescues and protects the flock of his people, so Yahweh will save and care for his people on that day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as a shepherd saves his sheep]

See: Simile

Zechariah 9:16 (#5)

כִּֽי

“for”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an expansion. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [indeed to him]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 9:16 (#6)

כִּֽי אַבְנֵי־נֵ֖זֶר מִתְנוֹסְסֹ֥ות עַל־אַדְמָתֹֽו

“for they are the stones of a crown gleaming over his land”

Here Zechariah is speaking of Yahweh’s people as if they were **the stones of a crown** that sparkle beautifully. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they are precious to him and glorious over his land]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 9:17 (#1)

כִּֽי מַה־טּ֥וּבֹו וּמַה־יָּפְיֹ֖ו

“For how {is} his goodness, and how {is} his beauty”

Zechariah is using phrases that express a strong feeling of admiration and praise. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Everything is amazing and wonderful]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 9:17 (#2)

מַה־טּ֥וּבֹו וּמַה־יָּפְיֹ֖ו

“how {is} his goodness, and how {is} his beauty”

The pronoun **his** could refer to: (1) the people. Alternate translation: [how good and beautiful every one is] or (2) Yahweh. Alternate translation: [how great is Yahweh’s goodness, and how great is Yahweh’s beauty] It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 9:17 (#3)

מַה־טּ֥וּבֹו וּמַה־יָּפְיֹ֖ו

“how {is} his goodness, and how {is} his beauty”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **goodness** and **beauty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how good he is, and how beautiful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 9:17 (#4)

דָּגָ֣ן בָּחוּרִ֔ים וְתִירֹ֖ושׁ יְנוֹבֵ֥ב בְּתֻלֹֽות

“Grain the young men, and new wine will make the virgins flourish”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Grain will make the young men flourish, and new wine will make the virgins flourish]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah - Chapter 10 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This prophetic poem first contrasts Yahweh, who gives rain and guidance, with worthless idols and diviners (verses 1–2), then becomes a first-person divine promise to strengthen and regather his scattered people (verses 3–12).

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Shepherds and leaders
The shepherds and male goats represent the people's leaders, while Yahweh is the true shepherd who cares for his flock.

Regathering the exiles
Yahweh promises to bring the house of Judah and the house of Joseph (Ephraim, the northern kingdom) back from Egypt, Assyria, and distant lands.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Shifts in speaker
The chapter alternates between describing Yahweh and Yahweh speaking as "I," and in verse 11 the referent of "he" is ambiguous. Keep these referents clear.

Zechariah 10:1 (#1)

לְאִישׁ עֵשֶׂב בַּשָּׂדֶה

"to a man, vegetation in the field"

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [to a man he gives vegetation in the field]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 10:1 (#2)

לְאִישׁ

"to a man"

Zechariah is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to each person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 10:2 (#1)

כִּֽי

"For"

The word **For** introduces the reason Zechariah gives for the command to ask Yahweh for rain rather than trusting in idols and diviners. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 10:2 (#2)

הַתְּרָפִ֔ים דִּבְּר֖וּ־אָ֑וֶן

"household idols speak iniquity"

Since **household idols** cannot speak, this represents the false messengers that claim to speak for the household idols. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the false prophets who profess to speak for your silent household idols speak iniquity]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:2 (#3)

דִּבְּר֖וּ־אָ֑וֶן

"speak iniquity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [speak wicked things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 10:2 (#4)

וְחֲלֹמוֹת֙ הַשָּׁ֣וְא יְדַבֵּ֔רוּ

"and they speak dreams of emptiness"

Zechariah is using the possessive form to describe **dreams** that are characterized by **the emptiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and they claim to have visions from their gods but they are just making things up]

See: Possession

Zechariah 10:2 (#5)

הֶ֥בֶל

"with vanity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vanity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [worthlessly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 10:2 (#6)

נָסָ֖עוּ כְּמוֹ־צֹ֑אן יַעֲנ֖וּ כִּי־אֵ֥ין רֹֽעֶה

"they journey like a flock; they are afflicted because there is no shepherd"

The point of this comparison is that just as **a flock** with no shepherd wanders and suffers, so do the people who rely on idols and diviners. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they wander and suffer just as a flock wanders and suffers when there is no shepherd to guide them]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:2 (#7)

נָסָ֥עוּ כְמוֹ־צֹ֖אן

“they journey like a flock”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people, not to the idols or the diviners just mentioned. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people journey like a flock]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 10:2 (#8)

אֵ֥ין רֹ֛עֶה

“there is no shepherd”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if a leader who guides and protects people were a **shepherd**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [there is no leader to guide and protect them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#1)

עַל־הָרֹ֣עִ֔ים חָרָ֖ה אַפִּ֑י

“Against the shepherds my nose burns”

Here Yahweh begins to speak, but there is no verb introducing his words as a quotation. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as a direct quotation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh says, “Against the shepherds my nose burns]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Zechariah 10:3 (#2)

עַל־הָרֹ֣עִ֔ים חָרָ֖ה אַפִּ֑י וְעַל־הָעַתּוּדִ֖ים אֶפְקֹ֣ד

“Against the shepherds my nose burns, and on the male goats I will attend”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I am furious with the shepherds who lead my people, and I will certainly deal with those leaders]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 10:3 (#3)

הָרֹעִֽים׃

“the shepherds”

Yahweh is speaking of the leaders of the people as if they were **the shepherds** of a flock. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Some interpreters think these refer to the foreign leaders (see 11:3). Alternate translation: [the leaders who should be like shepherds]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#4)

חָרָ֖ה אַפִּֽי

“my nose burns”

Here, **nose ** represents Yahweh’s anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I am furious]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:3 (#5)

הָעַתּוּדִֽים׃

“the male goats”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the corrupt leaders of Judah as if they were **the male goats** who lead a flock. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the head goats of the flock] or [the leaders]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#6)

חָרָ֖ה אַפִּֽי

“my nose burns”

Here Yahweh is speaking of his anger as if it were a fire when he says that it burns. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my anger is intense]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#7)

כִּ֣י

“For”

The word **For** introduces the reason for what Yahweh has just said about punishing the leaders: he cares for his people and will restore them. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 10:3 (#8)

כִּֽי־פָקַ֤ד יְהוָה֙ צְבָאוֹת֙ אֶת־עֶדְר֔וֹ

“For Yahweh of Armies attends to his flock”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh of Armies**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [For I, Yahweh of Armies, attend to my flock, the house of Judah, and I will make them]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 10:3 (#9)

אֶת־עֶדְר֔וֹ

“his flock”

Here Yahweh is speaking of his people as if they were **his flock** of sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his people]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#10)

אֶת־בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה

“the house of Judah”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the people of the kingdom of Judah as if they were a single house, or household. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of the kingdom of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:3 (#11)

כְּסוּסֹ֥ו הוֹדֹ֖ו

“like a horse of his splendor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [like his splendid horse]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 10:3 (#12)

כְּסוּסֹ֥ו הוֹדֹ֖ו בַּמִּלְחָמָֽה

“like a horse of his splendor in the battle”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the horse of his splendor** is strong and majestic **in the battle**, so the people of Judah will be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as strong and majestic in the battle as his splendid warhorse]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:4 (#1)

מִמֶּ֥נּוּ פִנָּ֖ה

“From him a cornerstone”

The pronoun **him** refers to Judah, mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [From him, that is, Judah, a cornerstone]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 10:4 (#2)

מִמֶּ֥נּוּ פִנָּ֖ה

“From him a cornerstone”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to move **will come forth** from the end of the verse to here at the start. Alternate translation: [From him will come forth a cornerstone]

See: Information Structure

Zechariah 10:4 (#3)

פִּנָּה֙ & יָתֵ֣ד & קֶ֔שֶׁת מִלְחָמָ֑ה

“a cornerstone & a {tent} peg & a bow of war”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the rulers who will come from Judah as if they were **a cornerstone** of a building, the **tent peg**, and **a bow of war**. Your language may have comparable expressions that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will come forth the ruler who supports them ... the ruler who holds them together ... the ruler who leads them in war]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:5 (#1)

וְהָיוּ כְגִבֹּרִים

“And they will be like warriors”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Judah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the people of Judah will be like warriors]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 10:5 (#2)

כְגִבֹּרִים

“like warriors”

The point of this comparison is that just as **warriors** are strong and victorious in battle, so will the people of Judah be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [strong and victorious like warriors]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:5 (#3)

בּוֹסְסִים בְּטִטֵ֥יט חוּצ֖וֹת בַּמִּלְחָמָ֑ה

“trampling in the mud of the streets in the battle”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The meaning may be that the warriors will trample their enemies into the mud of the streets. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [trampling their enemies in the mud of the streets in the battle]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 10:5 (#4)

כִּֽי

“for”

The word **for** introduces the reason the people of Judah will prevail in battle: Yahweh is with them. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 10:5 (#5)

יְהוָ֥ה עִמָּ֖ם

“Yahweh is with them”

By **Yahweh is with them**, Zechariah means that Yahweh will help them win the battle against their enemies. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will help them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 10:5 (#6)

וְהֹבִ֖ישׁוּ רֹכְבֵ֥י סוּסִֽים

“and they will put to shame the riders of horses”

Here, the expression **put to shame** represents defeating them in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and they will defeat the riders of horses]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:6 (#1)

כִּֽי

“for”

The word **for** introduces the reason Yahweh will restore his people: he has compassion on them. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 10:6 (#2)

רִחַמְתִּ֖ים

“I have compassion on them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I feel compassionate toward them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 10:6 (#3)

אֶת־בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה & בֵּ֖ית יוֹסֵ֑ף

“the house of Judah & the house of Joseph”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Judah** and **the house of Joseph** figuratively mean all the people descended from Judah and from Joseph. Alternate translation: [the people of Judah ... the people of Joseph]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:7 (#1)

וְהָיִ֤וּ כְגִבּוֹר֙ אֶפְרַ֔יִם וְשָׂמַ֥ח לִבָּ֖ם

“And Ephraim will be like a warrior, and their heart will be glad”

The word their is plural, but it refers back to Ephraim, which is grammatically singular. Here the singular name Ephraim stands for all the people of that tribe. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the people of Ephraim will be like a warrior, and their heart will be glad]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 10:7 (#2)

וְהָיִ֤וּ כְגִבּוֹר֙ אֶפְרַ֔יִם

“And Ephraim will be like a warrior”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a warrior** is strong and courageous, so the people of Ephraim will be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And Ephraim will be as strong and courageous as a warrior]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:7 (#3)

לִבָּ֖ם

“their heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s feelings exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their feelings]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:7 (#4)

כְּמוֹ־יָ֑יִן

“as {with} wine”

The point of this comparison is that just as **wine** makes a person feel glad and cheerful, so their hearts will be glad. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as people become cheerful from drinking wine]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:7 (#5)

וְשָׂמַ֥ח לִבָּ֖ם כְּמוֹ־יָ֑יִן

“and their heart will be glad as {with} wine”

The point of this comparison is that just as a person who drinks **wine** becomes cheerful, so the people of Ephraim will be glad. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their heart will be glad, just as a person who drinks wine becomes cheerful]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:7 (#6)

כְּגִבּוֹר֙

“like a warrior”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a warrior** is strong and mighty, so **Ephraim** will be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a strong and mighty warrior]

See: Simile

Zechariah 10:7 (#7)

וְשָׂמַ֥ח לִבָּ֖ם

“and their heart will be glad”

In this verse, the word **heart** is singular in form, but it refers to all the people of Ephraim as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “heart.” Alternate translation: [and their hearts will be glad]

See: Collective Nouns

Zechariah 10:7 (#8)

יָגֵ֣ל לִבָּ֔ם

“their heart will exult”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if a person’s **heart** were where their feelings exist. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their feelings will exult]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:8 (#1)

כִּֽי־

“for”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [after all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 10:8 (#2)

אֶשְׁרְקָה לָהֶם

“I will whistle for them”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if he were a shepherd who could **whistle** for his flock to gather them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will summon them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:9 (#1)

וְאֶזְרָעֵם בָּעַמִּים

“And I will sow them among the peoples”

Here Yahweh is speaking of scattering his people among the nations as if he were planting seed when he says that he will **sow them**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will cause them to live among different nations]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:10 (#1)

וַהֲשִׁיבוֹתִים מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם וּמֵאַשּׁוּר אֲקַבְּצֵם

“And I will bring them back from the land of Egypt, and from Assyria I will gather them”

Yahweh is referring to all the places from which he will bring his people back by naming two extremes, **the land of Egypt** and **Assyria**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will bring them back from every land, including Egypt and Assyria]

See: Merism

Zechariah 10:10 (#2)

וְלֹא יִמָּצֵא לָהֶם

“and {room} will not be found for them”

The expression **will not be found** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and they will not have enough room]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 10:11 (#1)

וְעָבַר בַּיָּם צָרָה וְהִכָּה בַיָּם גַּלֵּי֙ים וְהֹבְּשׁוּ כֹּל מְצוּלֹ֣ות יְאֹ֔ר

“And he will pass through the sea {of} distress, and he will strike the waves in the sea, and all the depths of the Nile will dry up”

By **he will pass through the sea of distress, and he will strike the waves in the sea, and all the depths of the Nile will dry up**, Zechariah means that Yahweh will remove every danger and obstacle blocking his people’s return to their land, just as he dried up the sea and the Jordan for their ancestors when he brought them out of Egypt and into the land. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will clear away every danger that threatens his people, just as he dried up the sea and the Jordan for their ancestors]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 10:11 (#2)

בַּיָּם צָרָה

“the sea {of} distress”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the troubles his people face as if they were a dangerous sea when he refers to **the sea** of **distress**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the distress that is like a dangerous sea]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:11 (#3)

וְעָבַר בַּיָּם

“And he will pass through the sea”

The pronoun **he** could refer to: (1) Yahweh. In the surrounding verses, Yahweh speaks of himself in the first person, but here he is referred to in the third person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh will pass through the sea] or (2) Ephraim, that is the people of the northern tribes of Israel. However, in the surrounding verse Ephraim is always referred to using plural pronouns and verbs. Alternate translation: [And Ephraim will pass through the sea]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 10:11 (#4)

בַּיָּם צָרָה

“the sea {of} distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the distressing sea]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 10:11 (#5)

וְהִכָּה בַיָּם֙ גַּלִּ֔ים

“and he will strike the waves in the sea”

Here Yahweh is using the phrase **strike the waves in the sea** as a common expression to mean that he will subdue the raging waters and overcome the troubles they represent. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will subdue the raging waves in the sea]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 10:11 (#6)

וְהוּרַ֖ד גְּא֣וֹן אַשּׁ֑וּר

“And the pride of Assyria will be brought down”

The expression **will be brought down** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh will bring down the pride of Assyria]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 10:11 (#7)

וְהוּרַ֖ד גְּא֣וֹן אַשּׁ֑וּר

“And the pride of Assyria will be brought down”

Here, the term **pride** represents the proud nation of Assyria and its army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the proud army of Assyria will be brought down]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:11 (#8)

וְשֵׁ֥בֶט מִצְרַ֖יִם יָסֽוּר

“and the scepter of Egypt will depart”

Here, the term **scepter** represents the royal power of Egypt, since a scepter is a symbol that a king holds. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and the royal power of Egypt will be no more]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:12 (#1)

וְגִבַּרְתִּים֙ בַּֽיהוָ֔ה

“And I will strengthen them in Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [And I will strengthen them in myself, and in my name they will walk]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 10:12 (#2)

יִתְהַלָּ֑כוּ

“they will walk”

Here Yahweh is speaking of how the people will live as if they would **walk** along a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will conduct their lives]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 10:12 (#3)

וּבִשְׁמ֖וֹ

“and in his name”

Here, **his name** represents Yahweh’s authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and by his authority]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 10:12 (#4)

נְאֻ֥ם יְהוָֽה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

Zechariah is using the phrase **the declaration of Yahweh** to indicate that what has been said is a direct quotation from Yahweh and comes with Yahweh’s authority. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah - Chapter 11 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

The chapter opens with a poetic taunt of judgment (verses 1–3), moves to a prophetic sign-act in which Zechariah acts as a shepherd (verses 4–14), and closes with a woe oracle against a worthless shepherd (verses 15–17). The ULT sets verses 1–3 and 17 as poetry.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Shepherds and the flock

Throughout the chapter, the shepherd represents a ruler, and the flock represents the people he leads.

The two staffs

Zechariah names two shepherd's staffs "Favor" and "Union;" breaking them signifies the ending of Yahweh's covenant and of the unity between Judah and Israel.

Zechariah 11:1 (#1)

פְּתַח־לְבָנוֹן דְּלָתֶיךָ

"Open your doors, Lebanon"

Zechariah is speaking to **Lebanon**, a place that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the coming destruction of the land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Lebanon. Alternate translation: [People of Lebanon, open your doors]

See: Apostrophe

Zechariah 11:1 (#2)

וְתֹאכַל אֵשׁ בַּאֲרָזֶיךָ

"that fire may devour among your cedars"

Zechariah is speaking of **fire** as if it were a living thing that could **devour** the trees. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that fire may burn up your cedars]

See: Personification

Zechariah 11:2 (#1)

הֵילֵל & הֵילִילוּ

"Wail & Wail"

The word translated as **wail** copies the sound of crying or howling. Zechariah uses this word here, and a similar word about lions in verse 3, to make the scene sound sad and urgent, like people weeping and lions roaring. If your language has a word that sounds like crying, use it here. If not, choose words that still sound emotional and urgent, not calm or formal.

See: Poetry

Zechariah 11:2 (#2)

בְּרוֹשׁ

"cypress"

The word **cypress** refers to a tall evergreen tree, but its exact identification is uncertain; other translations render it as "fir," "pine," or "juniper." If your readers would not be familiar with this kind of tree, you could use the name of a similar tall, valuable evergreen tree that they would recognize, or you could use a more general term, such as "large evergreen tree." Alternate translation: [fir tree] or [pine tree]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 11:2 (#3)

הֵילֵל בְּרוֹשׁ

"Wail, cypress"

Here Zechariah is speaking of the cypress trees as if they were a person who could **wail**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Cry out, cypress, like a mourner] or [Cypress, be greatly distressed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:2 (#4)

הֵילֵל בְּרוֹשׁ כִּי־נָפַל אֶרֶז אַשֶּׁר אַדִּרִים שֻׁדָּדוּ הֵילִילוּ אַלוֹנֵי בָשָׁן כִּי יָרַד יַעַר הַבָּצוּר

"Wail, cypress, for the cedar has fallen, because the majestic ones have been devastated! Wail, oaks of Bashan, for the fortified forest has gone down"

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because the cedar has fallen, wail, cypress, since the majestic ones have been devastated! Because the fortified forest has gone down, wail, oaks of Bashan]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 11:2 (#5)

נָפַל אֶרֶז

“the cedar has fallen”

Zechariah is speaking of powerful rulers as if they were a **cedar** tree that had fallen. A cedar was one of the tallest, strongest trees in that area, so a fallen cedar pictures a powerful ruler who has lost his power. The text does not say exactly which ruler or nation this is, so keep your translation general instead of naming a specific person or place. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the powerful rulers have been overthrown]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:2 (#6)

אַדִּרִּ֖ים שֻׁדָּֽדוּ

“the majestic ones have been devastated”

The expression **have been devastated** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [enemies have devastated the majestic ones]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 11:2 (#7)

יַ֣עַר הבצור

“the fortified forest”

The word translated as **fortified** has a similar spelling to the word for **vintage/grape harvest**. Some ancient manuscripts and versions read this as “the forest of the vintage,” apparently confusing the two similar words. The ULT and UST follow the reading “the fortified forest” (i.e., an inaccessible or lofty forest), which matches the word form actually present here. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [the forest of the vintage has come down]

See: Textual Variants

Zechariah 11:3 (#1)

קֹ֚ול יְלִלַ֣ת הָרֹעִ֔ים כִּֽי־שֻׁדְּדָ֖ה אַדַּרְתָּ֑ם קֹ֚ול שַׁאֲגַ֣ת כְּפִירִ֔ים כִּֽי־שֻׁדַּ֖ד גְּאֹ֥ון הַיַּרְדֵּֽן

“The voice of the wailing of the shepherds, for their glory is devastated! The voice of the roaring of the young lions, for the pride of the Jordan is devastated”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. The word for glory here is a lot like the word for the “majestic ones” in verse 2. Zechariah repeats this idea to show that everything great and important, both the leaders and the land, has been completely ruined. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Listen to the shepherds wailing and the young lions roaring, for everything of value to them has been utterly devastated]

See: Parallelism

Zechariah 11:3 (#2)

יְלִלַ֣ת הָרֹעִ֔ים & שַׁאֲגַ֣ת כְּפִירִ֔ים

“the wailing of the shepherds & the roaring of the young lions”

Zechariah is speaking of the rulers of the land as if they were **shepherds** and **young lions** that were wailing and roaring over what they had lost. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the crying of the rulers ... the mourning of the powerful men]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:3 (#3)

גְּאֹ֥ון הַיַּרְדֵּֽן

“the pride of the Jordan”

Zechariah is using **the pride of the Jordan** as a common expression of the culture to mean the dense thickets of trees and bushes that grow along the Jordan River. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the dense thickets along the Jordan River are devastated]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 11:4 (#1)

רְעֵ֖ה

“Shepherd”

Yahweh is speaking of leading and caring for the people as if that task were to **Shepherd** a flock of sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that

you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take care of]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:4 (#2)

אֶת־צֹאן הַהֲרֵגָה

“the flock of slaughter”

Yahweh is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were a flock of sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who are marked for slaughter]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:5 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר קֹנֵיהֶן יַהַרְגֵן וְלֹא יֶאְשָׁמוּ וּמֹכְרֵיהֶן יֹאמַר

“which the buyers kill and are not held guilty, and the ones selling them say”

Here Yahweh is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Zechariah 11:5 (#2)

וְלֹא יֶאְשָׁמוּ

“and are not held guilty”

The expression **are not held guilty** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and no one considers them guilty]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 11:5 (#3)

יֹאמַר בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה וַאֶעְשַׁר

“say, ‘Blessed be Yahweh, for I have become rich”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [say that Yahweh has blessed them, for they have become rich!]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 11:6 (#1)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

Even though Yahweh is speaking, he refers to himself in the third person, using **the declaration of Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [the declaration that I, Yahweh, am making]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Zechariah 11:6 (#2)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **declaration**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [this is what Yahweh declares]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 11:6 (#3)

אָנֹכִי מַמְצִיא אֶת־הָאָדָם אִישׁ בְּיַד־רֵעֵהוּ וּבְיַד מַלְכּוֹ

“I am causing mankind to fall, each man, in the hand of his neighbor and in the hand of his king”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if he were causing people to **fall** into the power of their neighbors and king, as though pushing them down so that others could seize them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am handing mankind over, each man, to his neighbor and to his king]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:6 (#4)

אֶת־הָאָדָם

“mankind”

Here the masculine terms **mankind** and **each man** have a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [all people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 11:6 (#5)

בְּיַד־רֵעֵהוּ וּבְיַד מַלְכּוֹ & מִיָּדָם

“in the hand of his neighbor and in the hand of his king & from their hand”

Here, **hand** represents power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [under the control of his neighbor and of his king ... from their power]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 11:7 (#1)

עֲנִיֵּי הַצֹּאן

“the poor of the flock”

Zechariah is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of sheep. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the suffering sheep of the flock]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 11:7 (#2)

לְאַחַד קָרָאתִי נֹעַם וּלְאַחַד קָרָאתִי חֹבְלִים

“For the one I called “Favor,” and for the other I called “Union”

The words **Favor** and **Union** are names that Zechariah gave to his two shepherd’s staffs. He chose names that carry meaning, since the staffs represent Yahweh’s relationship with the people.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 11:8 (#1)

אֶת־שְׁלֹשֶׁת הָרֹעִים

“the three shepherds”

The implication is that these **three shepherds** were leaders of the people whom Yahweh removed from their position. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the three leaders who were poorly shepherding the people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 11:8 (#2)

וַתִּקְצַר נַפְשִׁי בָּהֶם

“And my soul became short with them”

Zechariah is using **my soul became short with them** as a common expression of the culture to mean that he became impatient with them. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I became tired of them]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 11:9 (#1)

הַמֵּתָה תָּמוּת וְהַנִּכְחֶדֶת תִּכָּחֵד

“The one dying, let it die, and the one being destroyed, let it be destroyed”

Zechariah is repeating forms of the verbs **die** and **destroy** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that the flock is doomed and beyond saving. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Let the ones who are going to die, die, and let the ones who are going to be destroyed, be destroyed]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 11:9 (#2)

וְהַנִּכְחֶדֶת תִּכָּחֵד

“and the one being destroyed, let it be destroyed”

The expression **let it be destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and let the one perishing perish]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 11:9 (#3)

תֹּאכַלְנָה אִשָּׁה אֶת־בְּשַׂר רְעוּתָהּ

“let them eat, each one, the flesh of her companion”

Zechariah is speaking of the people as if they were sheep that would eat the flesh of one another. He means mean that they will turn against and destroy one another. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let each one destroy the other]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:10 (#1)

וְאֶקַּח אֶת־מַקְלִי אֶת־נֹעַם וְאֶגְדַּע אֹתָו לְהָפֵר אֶת־בְּרִיתִי אֲשֶׁר כָּרַתִּי אֶת־כָּל־הָעַמִּים

“And I took my staff Favor, and I chopped it up, to break my covenant that I had cut with all the peoples”

Here, **to** marks the words **break my covenant that I had cut with all the peoples** as the goal or purpose of his chopping up the **staff Favor**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Zechariah 11:10 (#2)

אֶת־בְּרִיתִ֥י אֲשֶׁר־כָּרַ֖תִּי

“my covenant that I had cut”

Zechariah is using the word **cut** as a common expression of the culture to mean “make,” since in that culture people spoke of making a covenant as cutting it. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my covenant that I had made]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 11:10 (#3)

כָּל־הָעַמִּֽים

“all the peoples”

This could mean: (1) all the nations of the world. Alternate translation: [all the world’s nations] (2) the Israelite nation. Alternate translation: [all of the Israelites]

Zechariah 11:11 (#1)

וַתֻּפַּ֑ר

“And it was broken”

The expression **it was broken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And I broke it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 11:11 (#2)

וַתֻּפַּ֑ר

“And it was broken”

The pronoun **it** refers to the covenant that Yahweh had made with all the peoples, mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the covenant was broken]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 11:12 (#1)

אִם־טֽוֹב בְּעֵינֵיכֶ֗ם הָבִ֙יאוּ֙ שְׂכָרִ֔י וְאִם־לֹ֖א ׀ חֲדָ֑לוּ

“If it is good in your eyes, give my wages; but if not, refrain”

Zechariah is presenting a possible condition, that the people may or may not think it is good to give him his wages. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [If it is good in your eyes, then give my wages; but if it is not good, then refrain]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Zechariah 11:12 (#2)

אִם־טֽוֹב בְּעֵינֵיכֶ֗ם

“If it is good in your eyes”

Zechariah is using **good in your eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean that something seems good or right to a person. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [If you consider it good]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 11:12 (#3)

שְׁלֹשִׁ֖ים כָּֽסֶף

“thirty {pieces} of silver”

In ancient times, a piece of silver was a coin or weight of silver called a shekel, which weighed about 11 grams, or about a third of an ounce. You could try to express this in terms of modern money values, but if you did, that could cause your Bible translation to become outdated and inaccurate, since those values can change over time. Instead, you might say something general like “thirty silver coins,” or give the equivalent weight, or use the term in the text and give the weight in a note.

See: Biblical Money

Zechariah 11:13 (#1)

הַיּוֹצֵ֔ר & הַיּוֹצֵ֖ר

“the potter & the potter”

A **potter** is a kind of craftsman who forms objects out of clay. If your readers would not be familiar with what a potter is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the craftsman who makes things out of clay ... the craftsman who makes things out of clay]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 11:13 (#2)

אֶאֱדֶר הַיִּקָּקֵר אֲשֶׁשֶׁר יָקַקָּרְתִּי

“the magnificence of the price at which I was valued”

Yahweh actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here, since thirty pieces of silver was in fact a contemptibly small price. It was also the amount the owner of an ox that gored a slave to death had to give to the owner of the slave (see Exo 21:32), so by paying that amount they were saying he was worth the same as a dead slave. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the contemptibly small price at which I was valued]

See: Irony

Zechariah 11:13 (#3)

אֶאֱדֶר הַיִּקָּקֵר

“the magnificence of the price”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **price**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the magnificent silver]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 11:14 (#1)

אֶת־הָאַחֻוָּה

“the brotherhood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **brotherhood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the brotherly ties]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 11:15 (#1)

כְּלֵי רֹעֶה אֱוִלִי

“the equipment of a foolish shepherd”

Yahweh is speaking of a ruler of the people as if he were a shepherd. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the equipment of a foolish ruler]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:15 (#2)

רֹעֶה אֱוִלִי

“a foolish shepherd”

Yahweh is not referring to a specific **foolish shepherd**. He means foolish shepherds in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [foolish shepherds]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 11:16 (#1)

כִּֽי־ הִנֵּה

“for behold”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [illustrating that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 11:16 (#2)

הַנִּכְחָדוֹת לֹא־יִפְקֹדֵ֔ הַנְּעַר֙ לֹא־יְבַקֵּ֔שׁ וְהַנִּשְׁבֶּ֖רֶת לֹ֣א יְרַפֵּ֑א הַנִּצָּבָה֙ לֹ֣א יְכַלְכֵּ֔ל וּבְשַׂ֥שַׂר הַבְּרִיאָה֙ יֹאכַ֔ל וּפַרְסֵיהֶ֖ן יְפָרֵֽק

“He will not attend to the ones being destroyed; he will not seek the scattered one; and he will not heal the broken one; he will not sustain the one standing; but he will eat the flesh of the fat one, and he will tear off their hooves”

Zechariah uses a repetitive series of clauses here to communicate that what he is saying should be understood as comprehensive and overwhelming. Use a form in your language that someone would use to describe a situation that is comprehensive and overwhelming.

See: Litany

Zechariah 11:16 (#3)

הַבְּרִיאָה

“the fat one”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if the strongest, healthiest members of the people were **the fat one**, a well-fed sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the best-fed sheep] or [the strongest of the people]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 11:16 (#4)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

Yahweh is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look, I am raising up a shepherd in the land]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 11:17 (#1)

הוֹי

“Woe”

Yahweh is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of distress and warning of coming judgment. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Alas]

See: Exclamations

Zechariah 11:17 (#2)

עַל־זְרוֹעֹו וְעַל־עֵין יְמִינֹו

“against his arm and against his right eye”

Here, **his arm** represents the shepherd’s strength and **his right eye** represents his ability to see. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [against his strong arm and against his seeing right eye]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 11:17 (#3)

חֶרֶב עַל־זְרוֹעֹו וְעַל־עֵין יְמִינֹו

“A sword against his arm and against his right eye”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [May a sword strike his arm and his right eye]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 11:17 (#4)

חֶרֶב

“A sword”

Here, **A sword** represents “a violent attack.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [A violent attack]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 11:17 (#5)

זְרֹעֹו יָבֵבֹוׁש תִּיבָבֵׁש וְעֵין יְמִינֹו כָּהֵהַ תִּכְהֶה

“His arm withering will wither, and his right eye dimming will dim”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [his arm will surely wither, and his right eye will surely grow dim]

See: Poetry

Zechariah - Chapter 12 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a new oracle in which Yahweh promises to defend Jerusalem and Judah against the nations that attack them (verses 1–9), then to pour out grief so that the people mourn over “the one whom they pierced” (verses 10–14). The repeated phrase “on that day” marks these as future events.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The one whom they pierced

In verse 10 the pronouns shift from “me” to “him” for the pierced one. Preserve this ambiguity rather than deciding to whom these pronouns refer.

Zechariah 12:1 (#1)

מַשָּׂא דְּבַר־יְהוָה עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“The burden of the word of Yahweh concerning Israel”

Zechariah is using the words translated as **The burden of the word of Yahweh concerning Israel** to intro-

duce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 12:1 (#2)

מַשָּׂא דְּבַר־יְהוָה

“The burden of the word of Yahweh”

Here Zechariah is speaking of the message from Yahweh as if it were a **burden**, that is, a heavy load that a person must carry. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The severe word of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:1 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

Zechariah is using **the declaration of Yahweh** to indicate that what has been said is a direct quotation from Yahweh and comes with Yahweh’s authority. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 12:1 (#4)

נֹטֶה שָׁמַיִם וְיֹסֵד אֶרֶץ

“the one stretching out the heavens and founding the earth”

Here Zechariah is speaking of how Yahweh made the world as if he were **stretching out** a tent to form the heavens and **founding** a building to form the earth. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who made the heavens and who made the earth]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:1 (#5)

רוּחַ־אָדָם

“the spirit of man”

This phrase continues the references to creation. The **spirit** of man represents “life.” The word translated **man** could also be transliterated as “Adam.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the life of a person] or [Adam’s life]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 12:2 (#1)

הִנֵּנִי אָשִׂים

“Behold, I am making”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 12:2 (#2)

הִנֵּנִי

“Behold”

Zechariah is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 12:2 (#3)

סַף־רַעַל לְכָל־הָעַמִּים סָבִיב

“a cup of staggering for all of the peoples all around”

Here Yahweh is speaking of **Jerusalem** as if it were a **cup of staggering**, that is, a cup of wine that would make the surrounding nations drunk so that they reel and cannot stand. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a source of helpless reeling for all of the peoples all around]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:2 (#4)

וְגַם עַל־יְהוּדָה יִהְיֶה בַּמָּצוֹר עַל־יְרוּשָׁלִָם

“And also against Judah it will be, in the siege against Jerusalem”

This could mean: (1) Judah and Jerusalem are besieged. Alternate translation: [And just as Jerusalem is besieged, so is all of Judah.] (2) Judah is going to besiege Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [Judah joins the nations to besiege Jerusalem.]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 12:3 (#1)

אֶ֣בֶן מַעֲמָסָ֔ה לְכָל־הָֽעַמִּ֑ים

“a stone of burden for all of the peoples”

Here Yahweh is speaking of Jerusalem as if it were a **stone of burden**, that is, a stone so heavy that anyone who tries to lift it injures himself. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a burden too heavy for all of the peoples]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:3 (#2)

שָׂרֹ֥ט יִשָּׂרֵ֖טוּ

“injuring, will be injured”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **injuring** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [will certainly be severely injured]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 12:3 (#3)

כָּל־עֹ֣מְסֶ֔יהָ

“All of the ones lifting it”

Yahweh is using the participle **the ones lifting it** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person, namely, the nations who try to take Jerusalem for themselves. Your language may use participles in the same way. If not, you can translate this participle with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [All of the nations who try to lift it]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 12:3 (#4)

שָׂרֹ֥ט יִשָּׂרֵ֖טוּ

“injuring, will be injured”

The expression **will be injured** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [will surely injure themselves severely]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 12:3 (#5)

וְנֶאֶסְפ֥וּ עָלֶ֖יהָ כֹּ֣ל גּוֹיֵ֣י הָאָ֑רֶץ

“and all of the nations of the earth will be gathered against it”

The expression **will be gathered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and all of the nations of the earth will assemble themselves against it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 12:4 (#1)

אַכֶּ֣ה כָל־סוּס֮ בַּתִּמָּהוֹן֒ וְרֹכְבֹ֣ו בַּשִּׁגָּעֽוֹן

“I will strike every horse with confusion and its rider with madness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **confusion** and **madness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [I will strike every horse so that it becomes bewildered and its rider so that he becomes crazed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 12:4 (#2)

בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה

“the house of Judah”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the people of Judah as if they were a **house**, a single household. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Judean people]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:4 (#3)

אֶפְקַ֖ח אֶת־עֵינַ֑י

“I will open my eyes”

Yahweh is using **I will open my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will watch over and protect.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will keep watch protectively]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 12:4 (#4)

כָּל־סוּס בַּתִּמָּהוֹן וְרֹכְבוֹ בַּשִּׁגָּעוֹן & וְכֹל֙ סוּס֙ הָעַמִּ֔ים

“every horse with confusion and its rider with madness & and every horse of the peoples”

Yahweh is using **every horse**, **every horse of the peoples**, and **its rider** to represent the whole army of the enemy nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the enemy forces with confusion and their soldiers with madness ... every horse of the enemy]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 12:5 (#1)

וְאָמְרוּ֙ אַלְפֵ֣י יְהוּדָ֔ה בְּלִבָּ֖ם

“And the chiefs of Judah will say in their heart”

Zechariah is using **will say in their heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “will say to themselves” or “will think.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then the chiefs of Judah will think to themselves]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 12:5 (#2)

אַמְצָ֣ה לִ֗י יֹשְׁבֵ֤י יְרוּשָׁלַ֙͏ִם֙ בַּיהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹ֔ת אֱלֹהֵיהֶֽם

“The inhabitants of Jerusalem are a strength to me by Yahweh of Armies, their God”

The words that the chiefs of Judah say are a quotation within Yahweh’s quotation. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [that the dwellers of Jerusalem are strength for them through Yahweh of Armies, their God]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 12:5 (#3)

אַמְצָ֣ה לִ֗י יֹשְׁבֵ֤י יְרוּשָׁלַ֙͏ִם֙

“The inhabitants of Jerusalem are a strength to me”

This could mean: (1) the people who live in Jerusalem are strong because Yahweh of Armies their God is with them or (2) the people who live in Jerusalem are a source of strength for the chiefs of Judah. You could make this information explicit if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The dwellers of Jerusalem are a source of strength to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 12:5 (#4)

אַמְצָ֣ה לִ֗י

“are a strength to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [strengthen me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 12:5 (#5)

לִ֗י

“to me”

The pronoun **me** is singular, referring to each chief of Judah individually, even though all the chiefs are speaking. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to each of us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 12:6 (#1)

כְּכִיּ֣וֹר אֵ֔שׁ בְּעֵצִ֖ים וּכְלַפִּ֣יד אֵ֑שׁ בָּעֲמִֽיר

“like a basin of fire among trees and like a torch of fire in a sheaf”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a basin of fire among trees** and **a torch of fire in a sheaf** quickly burn up everything around them, so the chiefs of Judah will destroy the peoples around them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [able to consume their enemies as quickly as a firepot burns up wood and as a flaming torch burns up a sheaf of grain]

See: Simile

Zechariah 12:6 (#2)

כְּכִיּ֣וֹר אֵ֔שׁ

“like a basin of fire”

A **basin** is a kind of large, open container that can hold burning coals or fire. If your readers would not be familiar with what a basin of this kind is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [like a pot full of burning coals]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 12:6 (#3)

בְּעֲמִיר

“in a sheaf”

A **sheaf** is a bundle of cut grain stalks tied together. When dried, it is highly flammable. If your readers would not be familiar with what a sheaf is, you could use a more general term or explain it in a footnote. Alternate translation: [bundle of cut grain]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 12:6 (#4)

וְאָכְלוּ

“and they will devour”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the chiefs of Judah destroying their enemies as if they would **devour** them the way fire consumes what it burns. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they will destroy]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:6 (#5)

עַל־יָמִין וְעַל־שְׂמֹאול

“on the right and on the left”

Yahweh is referring to every direction by naming two major components, **the right** and **the left**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in every direction]

See: Merism

Zechariah 12:6 (#6)

וְיָשְׁבָה יְרוּשָׁלַם עוֹד תַּחְתֶּיהָ

“And Jerusalem will dwell again in its place”

Here, **Jerusalem** represents the people who live in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the people of Jerusalem will dwell again in their place]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 12:6 (#7)

תַּחְתֶּיהָ בִּירוּשָׁלִָם

“in its place, in Jerusalem”

It might seem that the expression **in its place, in Jerusalem** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [in its own place]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Zechariah 12:7 (#1)

לְמַעַן

“so that”

Here, **so that** marks **the honor of the house of David and the honor of the dweller of Jerusalem will not be great over Judah** as the goal or purpose of Yahweh saving the tents of Judah first. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Zechariah 12:7 (#2)

אֶת־אָהֳלֵי יְהוּדָה

“the tents of Judah”

Here, **the tents of Judah** represents the homes and households of the people of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the households of Judah]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 12:7 (#3)

תִּפְאֶרֶת בֵּית־דָּוִיד וְתִפְאֶרֶת יֹשֶׁב יְרוּשָׁלִָם

“the honor of the house of David and the honor of the dweller of Jerusalem”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **honor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the honored house of David and the honored dweller of Jerusalem]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 12:7 (#4)

בֵּית־דָּוִיד

“the house of David”

Here Zechariah is speaking of the descendants of King David, the royal family, as if they were a **house**, a single household. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the royal family descended from David]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:7 (#5)

יֹשֵׁ֥ב יְרוּשָׁלִָֽם

“the dweller of Jerusalem”

Zechariah is not referring to a specific **dweller** of Jerusalem. He means the people who live in Jerusalem in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the residents of Jerusalem]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 12:7 (#6)

לְא־תַגְדִּ֣יל תִּפְאֶ֤רֶת בֵּית־דָּוִיד֙ וְתִפְאֶ֣רֶת יֹשֵׁ֔ב יְרוּשָׁלִַ֖ם עַל־יְהוּדָֽה

“the honor of the house of David and the honor of the dweller of Jerusalem will not be great over Judah”

Zechariah is using **will not be great over Judah** as a common expression of the culture to mean “will not be considered more important than the rest of Judah.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the honor of the house of David and the honor of the dweller of Jerusalem will not be regarded as more important than the honor of the rest of Judah]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 12:8 (#1)

הַנִּכְשָׁ֛ל בָּהֶ֖ם

“and the stumbler among them”

Here Zechariah is speaking of a weak or feeble person as if he were a **stumbler**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the weakest one among them]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:8 (#2)

הַנִּכְשָׁ֛ל

“and the stumbler”

Zechariah is using the adjective **stumbler** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the one who stumbles]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 12:8 (#3)

וְהָיָ֞ה כְּדָוִ֣יד ׀ וּבֵ֣ית דָּוִיד֮ כֵּאלֹהִים֒

“will be like David, and the house of David, like God”

Zechariah says **will be like David, and the house of David, like God** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [will be strong like David was, and the house of David will seem as powerful as God]

See: Hyperbole

Zechariah 12:8 (#4)

וּבֵ֣ית דָּוִיד֮ כֵּאלֹהִים֒

“and the house of David, like God”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. It may be helpful to repeat them from the earlier phrase. Alternate translation: [and the house of David will be like God]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 12:8 (#5)

וּבֵ֣ית דָּוִיד֮ כֵּאלֹהִים֒ כְּמַלְאַ֣ךְ יְהוָ֔ה

“and the house of David, like God, like the angel of Yahweh”

The point of this comparison is that just as **God** and **the angel of Yahweh** are powerful, so the house of David will be powerful as they lead the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and the house of David will be as powerful as God is, as powerful as the angel of Yahweh]

See: Simile

Zechariah 12:8 (#6)

כְּמַלְאַ֣ךְ יְהוָ֔ה לִפְנֵיהֶֽם

“like the angel of Yahweh to their face”

Here, **their face** represents their presence, so the phrase means going ahead of the people to lead them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate

translation: [like having the angel of Yahweh fighting in front of them]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 12:9 (#1)

וְהָיָה בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא אְבַקֵּשׁ לְהַשְׁמִידׇ אֶת־כָּל־הַגּוֹיִם הַבָּאִים עַל־יְרוּשָׁלָם

“And it will be on that day, I will seek to destroy all of the nations coming against Jerusalem”

Here Yahweh’s direct speech resumes after the narration of the previous verses. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 12:10 (#1)

וְשָׁפַכְתִּי׳

“And I will pour out”

Here Yahweh is speaking of generously giving his spirit to people as if he would **pour out** a liquid on them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will generously bestow]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 12:10 (#2)

רׇוּחַ חֵן וְתַחֲנוּנִים

“a spirit of favor and supplications”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **favor** and **supplications**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [a spirit that causes me to be pleased with them to plead with me and causes me to be pleased with them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 12:10 (#3)

וְהִבִּיטוּ אֵלַי אֵת אֲשֶׁר־דָּקָרוּ וְסָפְדוּ עָלָיו

“and they will look to me, whom they pierced. And they will mourn over him”

The pronoun **him** refers to the same person as **me** earlier in the verse. Yahweh shifts here from speaking of himself in the first person to speaking of the pierced one in the third person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and they will look to me, whom they pierced. And they will mourn over the one they pierced]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 12:10 (#4)

וְסָפְדוּ עָלָיו כְּמִסְפֵּדׇ עַל־הַיָּחִיד

“And they will mourn over him as the mourning over the only one”

The point of this comparison is that just as people grieve very deeply for **the only one**, that is, an only child who has died, so the people will mourn over the one whom they pierced. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And they will mourn over him as deeply as people grieve for an only child who has died]

See: Simile

Zechariah 12:10 (#5)

וְהָמַר עָלָיו כְּהָמֵר עַל־הַבְּכוֹר

“and they will be bitter over him as being bitter over the firstborn”

The point of this comparison is that just as people grieve bitterly over **the firstborn**, that is, a firstborn son who has died, so the people will grieve bitterly over the one whom they pierced. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and they will weep powerfully over him, just as people weep powerfully when a firstborn son dies]

See: Simile

Zechariah 12:11 (#1)

כְּמִסְפַּד הֲדַד־רִמּוֹן בְּבִקְעַעַת מְגִדּוֹן

“like the mourning of Hadad Rimmon in the plain of Megiddo”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the mourning of Hadad Rimmon in the plain of Megiddo** was a well-known time of very great grief, so the mourning in Jerusalem will be very great. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as great as the well-known grief at Hadad Rimmon in the plain of Megiddo]

See: Simile

Zechariah 12:11 (#2)

כְּמִסְפַּד הֲדַד־רִמּוֹן

“like the mourning of Hadad Rimmon”

This could mean: (1) the weeping for King Josiah, who was killed at Megiddo and for whom the people mourned greatly, Alternate translation: [like the mourning for King Josiah at Hadad Rimmon] or (2) the ritual mourning for a god named Hadad Rimmon, or (3) both. You could include this information in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 12:11 (#3)

הֲדַד־רִמּוֹן בְּבִקְעַ֥ת מְגִדּֽוֹן

“Hadad Rimmon in the plain of Megiddo”

The word **Hadad Rimmon** is the name of a place, and the word **Megiddo** is the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 12:12 (#1)

וְסָפְדָ֣ה הָאָ֔רֶץ

“And the land will mourn”

Here, **the land** represents the people who live in the land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And everyone living in the land will mourn]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 12:12 (#2)

מִשְׁפָּחוֹת֙ מִשְׁפָּחוֹת֙ לְבָ֔ד

“clans, clans separately”

Zechariah is repeating the term **clans** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys, that each clan mourns by itself. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [each and every clan will mourn separately]

See: Reduplication

Zechariah 12:12 (#3)

מִשְׁפַּ֣חַת בֵּית־דָּוִ֔יד לְבָד֙ וְנְשֵׁיהֶ֔ם לְבָ֖ד מִשְׁפַּ֣חַת בֵּית־נָתָ֑ן לְבָד֙ וְנְשֵׁיהֶ֔ם לְבָ֖ד

“the clan of the house of David separately, and their wives separately; the clan of the house of Nathan separately, and their wives separately”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The men of the clan of the house of David will mourn by themselves and the women of that clan will mourn by themselves. The men of the clan descended from Nathan will mourn by themselves and the women of that clan will mourn by themselves]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 12:12 (#4)

בֵּית־נָתָ֑ן

“the house of Nathan”

This could mean: (1) Nathan, the son of King David, Alternate translation: [the house of Nathan, David’s son] or (2) Nathan, the prophet who served during David’s reign. Alternate translation: [the house of prophet Nathan] You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 12:12–14 (#1)

מִשְׁפַּ֣חַת בֵּית־דָּוִ֔יד לְבָד֙ וְנְשֵׁיהֶ֔ם לְבָ֖ד

“the clan of the house of David separately, and their wives separately”

In some languages, the repeated systematic repetition of the rest of verse 12 through verse 14 may not give a similar emphasis to the deepness and powerfulness of the mourning that will happen. Translate in a way that emphasizes how strong the grief was in a natural way in your language. Alternate translation: [the clans of David, Nathan, Levi, and the Shimeite will all mourn very intensely; the men and women will mourn separately, in their own ways]

See: Information Structure

Zechariah 12:12–14 (#2)

מִשְׁפַּ֣חַת בֵּית־דָּוִ֔יד לְבָד֙ וְנְשֵׁיהֶ֔ם לְבָ֖ד

“the clan of the house of David separately, and their wives separately”

Zechariah assumes that readers will know that the separation of men and women in public mourning reflects the mourning customs of that society. Translate this so readers do not misinterpret it as marital strife or divorce. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Ac-

cording to custom, each clan will mourn by itself, and men and women will mourn separately]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 12:13 (#1)

הַשִּׁמְעִי

“the Shimeite”

The word **Shimeite** is the name of a people group, the descendants of a man named Shimei.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 12:14 (#1)

כֹּל֙ הַמִּשְׁפָּחוֹת֙ הַנִּשְׁאָרוֹת

“all of the clans, the ones remaining”

Zechariah is using the adjective **the ones remaining** as a noun to mean certain clans, namely, all the other clans that have not yet been named. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and any other clans]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah - Chapter 13 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Verses 1–6 are a prose oracle about cleansing from sin and removing false prophets. Verses 7–9 shift to poetry, announcing the striking of Yahweh’s shepherd and the purifying of a surviving remnant.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The Prophetic Cloak

The “cloak of hair” (verse 4) is the rough garment that identified prophets. False prophets abandon this clothing to conceal their identity.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Nested Quotations

Yahweh’s speech spans the entire chapter and contains embedded quotes from parents (verse 3), a false prophet (verses 5–6), and a covenant declaration (verse 9).

Zechariah 13:1 (#1)

בַּיּ֣וֹם הַה֗וּא

“On that day”

Zechariah is using the phrase **On that day** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event. See the Introduction to Zechariah for a discussion of the similar phrase “in that day.”

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 13:1 (#2)

מָקֹ֔ור נִפְתָּ֖ח

“a fountain & opened”

Here Zechariah is speaking as if the means of cleansing from sin were a **fountain** that would **be opened**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a source of cleansing will be made available]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:1 (#3)

יְהוָ֔ה מָקֹ֔ור נִפְתָּ֖ח

“a fountain will be opened”

The expression **a fountain will be opened** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God will open a fountain]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 13:1 (#4)

לְבֵ֣ית דָּוִ֔יד

“for the house of David”

Here, **the house of David** represents the descendants of David and the royal dynasty. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people descended from David]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 13:1 (#5)

לְחַטָּ֖את וּלְנִדָּֽה

“for sin and for impurity”

Zechariah is referring to all types of uncleanness by naming two major components, sin and impurity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [every kind of sin and ritual uncleanness]

See: Merism

Zechariah 13:1 (#6)

לְחַטָּאת וּלְנִדָּה

“for sin and for impurity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of sin and impurity, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [cleansing you from your sinning and from your being unclean]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 13:2 (#1)

אֶת־שְׁמוֹת הָעֲצַבִּים

“the names of the idols”

Here, **the names of the idols** represents the memory and reputation of the idols. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the memory of the idols]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 13:2 (#2)

נְאֻם ׀ יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

The phrase **the declaration of Yahweh of Armies** is a parenthetical statement within Yahweh’s speech that identifies him as the speaker. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating the speaker of a direct quotation in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 13:2 (#3)

וְלֹא יִזָּכְרוּ עֹוד

“and they will not be remembered again”

The expression **they will not be remembered again** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and no one will remember them anymore]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 13:2 (#4)

הַטֻּמְאָה

“uncleanness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of uncleanness, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is unclean]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 13:2 (#5)

וְגַם

“and also”

Here, the words **and also** add a further action to the one just described. Yahweh will not only remove the idols but will additionally remove the false prophets and the unclean spirit. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [and furthermore,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Zechariah 13:3 (#1)

וְהָיָה כִּי־יִנָּבֵא אִישׁ עֹוד

“And it will happen, when a man prophesies again”

Zechariah is presenting a possible condition, that a man will prophesy falsely again and, as a result, his own father and mother will condemn and kill him. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. It may be helpful to reorder this sentence so that the conditional statement is first. Alternate translation: [If a man prophesies falsely again]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Zechariah 13:3 (#2)

אִישׁ

“a man”

Zechariah is not referring to a specific **man**. He means men in general who prophesy. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any man] or [anyone]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 13:3 (#3)

יֹלְדָיו

“the ones bearing him”

Zechariah is not distinguishing this father and mother from another father and mother who are not **the ones bearing him**. He is reminding readers that the man’s own parents are the ones who gave birth to him. Be

sure that this is clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [who themselves gave him birth]

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

Zechariah 13:3 (#4)

לֹ֣א תִחְיֶ֔ה כִּֽי־שֶׁ֥קֶר דִּבַּ֖רְתָּ בְּשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָ֑ה

“You will not live, for you have spoken falsehood in the name of Yahweh”

The father and mother’s words are a quotation within a quotation. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [that he will not live, for he has spoken falsehood in the name of Yahweh]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 13:3 (#5)

שֶׁ֥קֶר דִּבַּ֖רְתָּ

“you have spoken falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you have spoken falsely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 13:3 (#6)

בְּשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָ֑ה

“in the name of Yahweh”

Here, **the name of Yahweh** represents the authority of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [as one who has Yahweh’s authority]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 13:4 (#1)

וְ֠הֹבִישׁוּ הַנְּבִיאִ֨ים

“the prophets will have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the prophets will be ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 13:4 (#2)

אַדֶּ֣רֶת שֵׂעָ֔ר

“a cloak of hair”

The implication is that a **cloak of hair** was the distinctive garment that prophets wore, so putting it on was a way of claiming to be a prophet. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the hairy cloak that marks a person as a prophet]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 13:5 (#1)

מִנְּעוּרָֽי

“from my youth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **youth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [since I was a boy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 13:5 (#2)

אֲדָמָה֙ כִּֽי־אָדָ֣ם הִקְנָ֔נִי מִנְּעוּרָֽי

“the ground, for a man has owned me from my youth”

This could mean: (1) that the person is tied to this land and working this land because he is a bondservant or slave to the owner. Alternate translation: [this ground that my master from my youth owns] (2) that he owns this land (requires reading the Hebrew slightly differently). That is, he’s a small landowner or a subsistence farmer and is tied to the land. Alternate translation: [the little patch of ground I have owned since I was young]

See: Alternative Readings

Zechariah 13:6 (#1)

וְאָמַ֣ר אֵלָ֗יו מָזֹּ֤ת הַמַּכּוֹת֙ הָאֵ֣לֶּה בֵּ֣ין יָדֶ֔יךָ וְאָמַ֕ר אֲשֶׁ֥ר הֻכֵּ֖יתִי בֵּ֣ית מְאַהֲבָֽי

“And {someone} will say to him, ‘What are these wounds between your hands?’ And he will say, ‘Those are the ones with which I was struck {in} the house of my lovers”

The question and its answer here are quotations within a quotation. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And someone will ask him what those wounds between his hands are. And he will say that those are the ones with which he was struck in the house of his lovers]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah 13:6 (#2)

בֵּ֣ין יָדֶ֔יךָ

“between your hands”

The speaker is using **between your hands** as a common expression of the culture to mean “on the front of the body.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the front of your body]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 13:6 (#3)

הֻכֵּ֖יתִי

“I was struck”

The expression **I was struck** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people struck me]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 13:6 (#4)

בֵּ֥בֵית מְאֹהֲבָֽי

“in} the house of my lovers”

This could mean: (1) that the speaker is saying he was injured somehow while at the home of friends, perhaps in a drunken brawl or something. Alternate translation: [when I got in a fight with some local people] (2) that the speaker is speaking of the false gods that he worshiped as if they were his **lovers**. Idol worship sometimes involves self-mutilation. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the temples of the false gods I worshiped]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:7 (#1)

חֶ֚רֶב עוּרִ֣י עַל־רֹעִ֔י

“Sword, awake against my shepherd”

Yahweh is speaking to a **Sword** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the judgment that is coming on his shepherd. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the sword. Alternate translation: [May the sword awake against my shepherd]

See: Apostrophe

Zechariah 13:7 (#2)

חֶ֚רֶב עוּרִ֣י עַל־רֹעִ֔י

“Sword, awake against my shepherd”

Sword, awake against my shepherd, and against the man, my companion—Yahweh is using the term **Sword** to represent the violent death that a sword can inflict. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Someone, kill my shepherd with a sword]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 13:7 (#3)

נְאֻ֖ם יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאֹ֑ות

“the declaration of Yahweh of Armies”

Zechariah is using **the declaration of Yahweh of Armies** to indicate that what has been said is a direct quotation from Yahweh and comes with Yahweh’s authority. In your translation, use a natural way of indicating direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Zechariah 13:7 (#4)

רֹעִ֔י & אֶת־הֶ֥רֹעֶ֖ה

“my shepherd & the shepherd”

Yahweh is speaking of the leader of his people as if he were a **shepherd**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the leader of my people ... the leader of my people]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:7 (#5)

וּתְפוּצֶ֖צְנָה הַצֹּֽאן

“and the flock will scatter”

Yahweh is speaking of his people as if they were a **flock** of sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my people will scatter]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:7 (#6)

וַהֲשִׁבֹתִ֥י יָדִ֖י עַל

“and I will turn my hand against”

Here, **hand** represents the power of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will use my power against]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 13:7 (#7)

הַצְּעִרִֽים

“the little ones”

Yahweh is using the adjective **little ones** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person, those who are lowly and insignificant. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the ones who are insignificant]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 13:8 (#1)

פִּֽי־שְׁנַ֤יִם בָּהּ֙ יִכָּרְת֣וּ יִגְוָ֔עוּ וְהַשְּׁלִשִׁ֖ית יִוָּתֵ֥ר בָּֽהּ

“two portions in it will be cut off, they will expire, and the third will be left in it”

The expression **two portions** means two parts out of three equal parts, that is, two-thirds of the people. And **the third** means one part out of three equal parts, that is, one-third of the people.

See: Fractions

Zechariah 13:8 (#2)

פִּֽי־שְׁנַ֤יִם בָּהּ֙ יִכָּרְת֣וּ

“two portions in it will be cut off”

The expression **will be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will cut off two portions in it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 13:8 (#3)

יִכָּרְת֣וּ

“will be cut off”

Yahweh is speaking of people being killed as if they were parts of something that could be **cut off**, such as cutting branches from a tree. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will be killed]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:8 (#4)

יִגְוָ֔עוּ

“they will expire”

Yahweh is speaking of the people who will die as if their lives were a breath that will **expire**, or run out. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [breathe their last breath] or [die]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:8 (#5)

וְהַשְּׁלִשִׁ֖ית יִוָּתֵ֥ר בָּֽהּ

“and the third will be left in it”

The expression **will be left** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and I will leave the third in it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 13:9 (#1)

וְהֵבֵאתִ֤י אֶת־הַשְּׁלִשִׁית֙ בָּאֵ֔שׁ

“And I will bring the third into the fire”

Yahweh is speaking of the suffering he will use to purify his people as if it were a **fire**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will bring the third through purifying suffering]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 13:9 (#2)

וּצְרַפְתִּים֙ כִּצְרֹ֣ף אֶת־הַכֶּ֔סֶף וּבְחַנְתִּ֖ים כִּבְחֹ֣ן אֶת־הַזָּהָ֑ב

“and I will refine them as {one} refines the silver, and I will test them as {one} tests the gold”

The point of this comparison is that just as one **refines the silver** and **tests the gold** to remove impurities and prove them genuine, so Yahweh will purify his

people through suffering and prove that they are genuine. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I will purify them the way that one refines silver to remove its impurities, and I will prove them genuine the way that one tests gold]

See: Simile

Zechariah 13:9 (#3)

הַהֽוּא

“He”

The pronoun **He** refers to the surviving third of the people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The surviving third, they]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 13:9 (#4)

הַהֽוּא ׀ יִקְרָ֣א בִשְׁמִ֗י וַאֲנִי֙ אֶֽעֱנֵ֔ה

“He, he will call on my name, and I, I will answer”

Yahweh is stating the pronouns **He** and **I** along with the verbs translated as **he will call** and **I will answer**, which already include their meanings. He is doing that because he is contrasting what the remnant of his people will do with what he himself will do. If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [As for them, they will call on my name, and as for me, I will answer him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 13:9 (#5)

יִקְרָ֣א בִשְׁמִ֗י

“he will call on my name”

Yahweh is using **call on my name** as a common expression of the culture to mean “to worship me and pray to me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will worship me and pray to me]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 13:9 (#6)

עַמִּ֣י הֽוּא & יְהוָ֖ה אֱלֹהָֽי

“He is my people & Yahweh is my God”

The implication is that **He is my people** and **Yahweh is my God** are the words of a covenant, expressing the restored relationship in which Yahweh claims these people as his own and they acknowledge him as their God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He is the people I claim as my own ... Yahweh is the one I acknowledge as my God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 13:9 (#7)

עַמִּ֣י הֽוּא וְהֽוּא יֹאמַ֖ר יְהוָ֥ה אֱלֹהָֽי

“He is my people,’ and he, he will say, ‘Yahweh is my God”

There are quotations within a quotation here. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [that he is my people, and he, he will say that Yahweh is his God]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Zechariah - Chapter 14 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This closing chapter is a prose oracle about the day of Yahweh: the nations attack Jerusalem (verses 1–8), Yahweh reigns as king (verses 9–11), he strikes the attackers (verses 12–15), and the survivors come to worship him (verses 16–21).

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The climax of the book

Zechariah 14:20–21 presents a picture of universal holiness, where ordinary domestic objects carry the same sacredness as the High Priest’s crown. In Exodus 28:36, this inscription belonged exclusively to the High Priest’s golden crown. Here it is stamped on common horse bells and kitchen pots, signifying that in the messianic kingdom, the boundary between the sacred and the everyday is abolished, and all of life and creation becomes completely holy to God. Compare this to Isaiah 11:9 and Habakkuk 2:14, where the holy presence and knowledge of God fill the entire earth.

The day of Yahweh

The repeated phrase “on that day” marks the time when Yahweh judges the nations and establishes his rule. See day of the Lord, day of Yahweh.

The Festival of Booths
This was a yearly Israelite festival during which people lived in temporary shelters. Here even the nations celebrate it.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Shifts in person
Yahweh speaks of himself as "I" in verse 2 but is spoken of as "he" elsewhere, so translators may need to make the speaker explicit.

Zechariah 14:1 (#1)

הִנֵּה

"Behold"

Zechariah is using the term **Behold** to focus the attention of his listeners on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully]

See: Foreground Information

Zechariah 14:1 (#2)

יוֹם־בָּ֣א לַיהוָ֔ה

"a day is coming for Yahweh"

Zechariah is using **a day is coming for Yahweh** as a common expression of the culture to mean "the time is coming when Yahweh will act to judge his enemies and rescue his people." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the time of Yahweh's judgment is near]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:1 (#3)

וְחֻלַּ֥ק שְׁלָלֵ֖ךְ בְּקִרְבֵּֽךְ

"and your spoil will be divided in your midst"

Zechariah is speaking to the city of Jerusalem, which he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about what will happen to the city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [and the spoil taken from Jerusalem will be divided within that city]

See: Apostrophe

Zechariah 14:1 (#4)

שְׁלָלֵ֖ךְ בְּקִרְבֵּֽךְ

"your spoil & in your midst"

The pronoun **your** refers to Jerusalem which (see verse 2) represents the people in Jerusalem. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 14:1 (#5)

וְחֻלַּ֥ק שְׁלָלֵ֖ךְ בְּקִרְבֵּֽךְ

"and your spoil will be divided in your midst"

The expression **will be divided** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and your enemies will divide your spoil in your midst]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 14:1 (#6)

בְּקִרְבֵּֽךְ

"in your midst"

The word **your** is singular here because Zechariah is addressing the city of Jerusalem, so use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Zechariah 14:2 (#1)

וְאָסַפְתִּ֞י אֶת־כָּל־הַגּוֹיִ֤ם ׀ אֶל־יְרוּשָׁלַ֙͏ִם֙

"And I will gather all the nations to Jerusalem"

Yahweh is speaking here. If it would be helpful in your language, you could that make clear. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh says, "I will gather all the nations to Jerusalem]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Zechariah 14:2 (#2)

וְנִלְכְּדָ֣ה הָעִ֔יר וְנָשַׁסּ֖וּ הַבָּתִּ֑ים וְהַנָּשִׁ֣ים תשגלנה

"and the city will be captured, and the houses will be plundered, and the women will be raped"

The expressions **will be captured**, **will be plundered**, and **will be raped** are passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use those forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and the nations

will capture the city, and they will plunder the houses, and they will rape the women]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 14:2 (#3)

וְהַנָּשִׁים תשגלנה

“and the women will be raped”

The oral reading tradition of the original language substitutes a less explicit word here, referring in a polite way to what the soldiers will do to **the women**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and the women will be violated]

See: Euphemism

Zechariah 14:2 (#4)

וְיָצָא חֲצִי הָעִירׇ בַּגּוֹלָה

“And half of the city will go out into the exile”

Here, **the city** represents “the people who live in the city.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And half of the city’s inhabitants will go out into the exile]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:2 (#5)

חֲצִי הָעִירׇ

“half of the city”

The fraction **half** means one part out of two equal parts of the people of the city. Alternate translation: [one of every two people]

See: Fractions

Zechariah 14:2 (#6)

בַּגּוֹלָה

“into the exile”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **exile**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be forced to live in a foreign land]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 14:2 (#7)

וְיֶתֶר הָעָם לֹא יִכָּרֵת מִן־הָעִיר

“but the rest of the people will not be cut off from the city”

Zechariah is speaking as if the rest of the people would literally ** not be cut off** from the city. He means that the enemies will not remove them from it. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but the rest of the people will remain in the city]

See: Metaphor

Zechariah 14:2 (#8)

וְיֶתֶר הָעָם לֹא יִכָּרֵת מִן־הָעִיר

“but the rest of the people will not be cut off from the city”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **cut off**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [the rest of the people will remain in the city]

See: Double Negatives

Zechariah 14:2 (#9)

וְיֶתֶר הָעָם

“but the rest of the people”

Habakkuk uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between the half of the city that will go into exile and the rest of the people who will remain. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [however, the rest of the people]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 14:3 (#1)

כְּיוֹם הִלָּחֲמוֹ בְּיוֹם קְרָב

“like the day of his fighting on a day of battle”

The point of this comparison is that just as Yahweh fought powerfully for his people **on a day of battle** in the past, so he will fight against these nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as he fought powerfully for his people in past battles]

See: Simile

Zechariah 14:4 (#1)

וְעָמְדוּ רַגְלָיו

“And his feet will stand”

Zechariah is using **his feet**, one part of Yahweh, to represent all of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he will stand]

See: Synecdoche

Zechariah 14:4 (#2)

בַּיּוֹם־הַהוּא

“on that day”

Zechariah is using **on that day** as a common expression of the culture to mean “at the time when Yahweh will act to judge the nations and rescue his people.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on that day of judgment and deliverance]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:4 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר עַל־פְּנֵי יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם מִקֶּדֶם

“which is on the face of Jerusalem from the east”

Here, **the face of Jerusalem** represents “the area in front of Jerusalem.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [which is in front of Jerusalem on the east]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:4 (#4)

וְנִבְקַע֩ הַהַ֨ר הַזֵּיתִ֜ים מֶחֱצָיו֗ מִזְרָ֙חָה וְיָ֣מָּה

“And the Mount of Olives will be split from its half toward the east and toward the west”

The expression **will be split** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the Mount of Olives will split apart down the middle, from east to west, forming]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 14:4 (#5)

גֵּ֚יא גְּדוֹלָ֔ה מְאֹ֑ד

“a very great valley”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [creating a very great valley]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 14:4 (#6)

וְחֶצְיוֹ־נֶ֖גְבָּה

“and its half toward the south”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and its other half will move away toward the south]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 14:5 (#1)

וְנַסְתֶּ֣ם גֵּ֤יא־הָרַי֙ כִּי־יַגִּ֣יעַ גֵּי־הָרִ֔ים אֶל־אָצַ֑ל

“And you will flee {by} the valley of my mountains, for the valley of the mountains will reach to Azal”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because the valley of the mountains will reach to Azal, you will flee by the valley of my mountains]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Zechariah 14:5 (#2)

אָצַל

“Azal”

The word **Azal** is the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 14:5 (#3)

מִפְּנֵי הָרַ֣עַשׁ

“from the face of the earthquake”

Zechariah is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the earthquake that terrified you]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:5 (#4)

בִּימֵי עֻזִּיָּה מֶלֶךְ־יְהוּדָה

“in the days of Uzziah the king of Judah”

The implication is that this was a well-known earthquake that the people of Judah still remembered. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the days of Uzziah the king of Judah, that earthquake everyone remembers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:6 (#1)

וְהָיָה בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא

“And it will happen on that day”

Zechariah is not using the phrase translated as **And it will happen on that day** to introduce a new event. In this and in the several following verses, he is using **on that day** to refer back to the appointed day introduced in verse 1. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for looking back to the same day. Alternate translation: [And it will happen on that same day]

See: Introduction of a New Event

Zechariah 14:6 (#2)

יְקָרוֹת

“the splendid”

Zechariah is using the adjective **splendid** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the splendid heavenly bodies]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Zechariah 14:6 (#3)

לֹא־יִהְיֶה אוֹר יְקָרוֹת יקפאון

“there will not be light; the splendid will congeal”

The implication is that the normal sources of light will fail on that day. This could mean: (1) that there will be no light and that instead there will be cold and frost, Alternate translation: [there will not be light; instead there will be cold and frost] or (2) that the bright heavenly bodies will no longer shine. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the sun, moon, and stars will stop shining]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:7 (#1)

הוּא יִוָּדַע לַיהוָה

“it, it will be known to Yahweh”

The expression **will be known** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will know about it]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 14:7 (#2)

לֹא־יוֹם וְלֹא־לָיְלָה

“not day and not night”

Zechariah is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [it will not be day and it will not be night]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 14:7 (#3)

לֹא־יוֹם וְלֹא־לָיְלָה

“not day and not night”

Zechariah is using the two parts of a full day, **day** and **night**, to mean the entire cycle of time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [unlike any ordinary period of time]

See: Merism

Zechariah 14:7 (#4)

לֹא־יוֹם וְלֹא־לָיְלָה וְהָיָה לְעֵת־עֶרֶב יִהְיֶה־אוֹר

“not day and not night. And it will happen, at the time of evening there will be light”

Zechariah states **And it will happen** here to indicate a contrast between the darkness that would normally be expected at evening and the light that will be present instead. In your translation, do not try to explain or fix this contract, instead indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [there will be neither day nor night, but at the time of evening there will be light]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Zechariah 14:8 (#1)

בַּקַּ֥יִץ וּבֶחֹ֖רֶף

“in the summer and in the winter”

Zechariah is using the two main seasons of the year, **the summer** and **the winter**, to mean the whole year. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all year long]

See: Merism

Zechariah 14:8 (#2)

מַ֣יִם־חַיִּ֔ים

“living waters”

Zechariah is using **living waters** as a common expression of the culture to mean “fresh water that flows continually” and “water that gives life.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [continually flowing fresh streams] or [life-giving water]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:9 (#1)

וְהָיָ֤ה יְהוָה֙ אֶחָ֔ד וּשְׁמ֖וֹ אֶחָֽד

“Yahweh will be one, and his name, one”

The implication is that people everywhere will worship Yahweh alone and honor him alone as God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will be the only God whom people worship, and his name, the only name that they honor]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:9 (#2)

וּשְׁמ֖וֹ אֶחָֽד

“and his name, one”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. He means that his name will be one, that is, unique. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and his name will be one, meaning unique]

See: Ellipsis

Zechariah 14:9 (#3)

וּשְׁמ֖וֹ

“and his name”

Here, **his name** represents Yahweh himself and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his reputation will be unique]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:10 (#1)

מִגֶּ֣בַע לְרִמּ֔וֹן נֶ֖גֶב יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם

“from Geba to Rimmon, south of Jerusalem”

Zechariah is using the two extremes of the land of Judah, **Geba** in the north and **Rimmon** in the south, to mean all of the land between them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from one end of the land to the other]

See: Merism

Zechariah 14:10 (#2)

יִסּ֣וֹב כָּל־הָאָ֗רֶץ כָּֽעֲרָבָה֙

“All the land will turn like the Arabah”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the Arabah** is a flat plain, so the land around Jerusalem will become flat. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [All the land will become as flat as the Arabah plain]

See: Simile

Zechariah 14:10 (#3)

וְרָאֲמָה֙ וְיָשְׁבָ֣ה תַחְתֶּ֔יהָ

“But it will rise up and will dwell in its place”

The pronoun **it** refers to Jerusalem, not to the land that will become flat. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [But Jerusalem will rise up and will dwell in its place]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 14:10 (#4)

לְמִשַּׁ֣עַר בִּנְיָמִ֗ן עַד־מְקֹ֤ום שַׁ֙עַר֙ הָרִאשֹׁ֔ון עַד־שַׁ֖עַר הַפִּנֹּ֑ות וּמִגְדַּ֤ל חֲנַנְאֵל֙ עַ֣ד יִקְבֵ֔י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“from the Gate of Benjamin to the place of the First Gate, to the Gate of the Corners, and {from} the Tower of Hananel to the winepresses of the king”

The words **the Gate of Benjamin**, **the First Gate**, **the Gate of the Corners**, and **the Tower of Hananel** are the names of places in Jerusalem.

See: How to Translate Names

Zechariah 14:10 (#5)

לְמִשַּׁעַר בִּנְיָמִן עַד־מְקֹ֣ום שַׁעַ֣ר הָרִאשֹׁ֔ון עַד־שַׁ֖עַר הַפִּנֹּ֑ות וּמִגְדַּ֤ל חֲנַנְאֵל֙ עַ֣ד יִקְבֵ֖י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“from the Gate of Benjamin to the place of the First Gate, to the Gate of the Corners, and {from} the Tower of Hananel to the winepresses of the king”

Zechariah is referring to all of Jerusalem by naming two extremes, **the Gate of Benjamin** and **the winepresses of the king**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [throughout the whole city]

See: Merism

Zechariah 14:11 (#1)

וְיָשְׁבוּ בָ֑הּ

“And they will dwell in it”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Jerusalem, and the pronoun **it** refers to the city of Jerusalem. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And her people will dwell in Jerusalem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 14:11 (#2)

וְחֵ֖רֶם לֹ֣א יְהְיֶה־עֹֽוד

“and there will not again be destruction”

The implication is that enemies will never again devote Jerusalem to complete destruction in war. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and no enemy will ever again devote it to destruction]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:11 (#3)

וְחֵ֖רֶם לֹ֣א יְהְיֶה־עֹֽוד

“and there will not again be destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and no one will destroy it again]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 14:11 (#4)

וְיָשְׁבָ֣ה יְרוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם לָבֶ֖טַח

“and Jerusalem will dwell in security”

Jerusalem is spoken of as a living thing. By referring to the city in this way, the meaning is that its name represents the people who live in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Jerusalem will dwell in security]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:11 (#5)

וְיָשְׁבָ֣ה יְרוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם לָבֶ֖טַח

“and Jerusalem will dwell in security”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **security**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and Jerusalem will dwell securely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 14:12 (#1)

בְּשָׂרֹ֗ו וְהוּא֙ עֹמֵ֣ד עַל־רַגְלָ֔יו וְעֵינָיו֙ תִּמַּ֣קְנָה בְּחֹרֵיהֶ֔ן וּלְשֹׁונָ֖ם תִּמַּ֥ק בְּפִיהֶֽם

“his flesh & while he is standing on his feet, and his eyes will rot in their sockets, and his tongue will rot in their mouth”

The pronouns **he** and **his** refer to each individual among the peoples who waged war against Jerusalem, while the pronoun **their** refers to those same peoples together as a group. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [each person’s flesh will rot away while he is standing on his feet, and his eyes will rot in their sockets, and his tongue will rot in his mouth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 14:12 (#2)

וְהוּא֙ עֹמֵ֣ד עַל־רַגְלָ֔יו

“while he is standing on his feet”

Zechariah is using **while he is standing on his feet** as a common expression of the culture to mean “while he is still alive.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that

meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [while he is yet living]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:13 (#1)

מְהוּמַת־יְהוָה רַבָּה

“a great tumult of Yahweh”

Zechariah is using the possessive form **a great tumult of Yahweh** to describe a tumult that Yahweh himself will cause. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a great tumult that Yahweh sends]

See: Possession

Zechariah 14:13 (#2)

וְהֶחֱזִיקוּ אִישׁ יַד רֵעֵהוּ

“and each man will seize the hand of his neighbor”

Here the masculine term **man** could refer to: (1) soldiers of the enemy armies, Alternate translation: [and each soldier will seize the hand of his neighbor] or (2) have a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [and each person will seize the hand of his neighbor]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Zechariah 14:13 (#3)

וְהֶחֱזִיקוּ אִישׁ יַד רֵעֵהוּ

“and each man will seize the hand of his neighbor”

Zechariah is using **each man will seize the hand of his neighbor** as a common expression of the culture to mean that people will panic and attack one another in confusion. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everyone will grab hold of the person next to them in panic] or [everyone will turn against the person next to them in confusion]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:13 (#4)

וְעָלְתָה יָדָם עַל־יַד רֵעֵהוּ

“and his hand will go up against the hand of his neighbor”

Zechariah is using **his hand will go up against** as a common expression of the culture to mean “he will attack.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will attack his neighbor]

See: Idiom

Zechariah 14:14 (#1)

וְגַם־יְהוּדָה תִּלָּחֵם בִּירוּשָׁלִָם

“And also Judah will fight at Jerusalem”

The implication is that the people of Judah will take part in this battle. This could mean: (1) that they will fight at Jerusalem alongside its people against the nations. Alternate translation: [And also Judah will join Jerusalem in fighting against the nations] or (2) that they will fight against Jerusalem along with the nations. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And the people of Judah will also join the nations in fighting against Jerusalem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:14 (#2)

וְאֻסַּף חֵיל כָּל־הַגּוֹיִם סָבִיב

“And the wealth of all the nations around will be gathered”

The expression **will be gathered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they will collect the wealth of all the nations around]

See: Active or Passive

Zechariah 14:14 (#3)

לְרֹב מְאֹד

“in very great abundance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **abundance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in extremely large amounts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Zechariah 14:15 (#1)

מַגֵּפַת הַסּוּס הַפֶּרֶד הַגָּמָל וְהַחֲמֹור

“the plague of the horse, the mule, the camel, and the donkey”

Zechariah is using the possessive form **the plague of the horse, the mule, the camel, and the donkey** to describe the plague that will strike those animals. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the plague that will strike the horse, the mule, the camel, and the donkey]

See: Possession

Zechariah 14:15 (#2)

הַסּוּס הַפֶּרֶד הַגָּמָל וְהַחֲמֹור

“the horse, the mule, the camel, and the donkey”

Zechariah is not referring to a specific **horse**, **mule**, **camel**, or **donkey**. He means horses, mules, camels, and donkeys in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the horses, mules, camels, and donkeys]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 14:16 (#1)

לְהִשְׁתַּחֲוֹת לְמֶלֶךְ

“to bow down to the King”

Bowing down before someone was a symbolic action by which a person showed honor and submission to a ruler. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [to bow down in honor and submission to the King]

See: Symbolic Action

Zechariah 14:16 (#2)

אֶת־חַג הַסֻּכֹּות

“the Festival of Booths”

The **Festival of Booths** is a kind of yearly celebration during which the Israelites lived in temporary shelters for a week to remember how their ancestors lived after they came out of Egypt. If your readers would not be familiar with what the Festival of Booths is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the yearly festival of living in temporary huts]

See: Translate Unknowns

Zechariah 14:17 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר לֹא־יַעֲלֶה מֵאֵת מִשְׁפְּחֹות הָאָרֶץ אֶל־יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם לְהִשְׁתַּחֲוֹות לְמֶלֶךְ יְהוָה צְבָאֹות וְלֹא עֲלֵיהֶם יִהְיֶה הַגָּשֶׁם

“whoever does not go up from the clans of the earth to Jerusalem to bow down to the King, Yahweh of Armies—on them there will not be the rain”

Zechariah is presenting a possible condition, that some of the clans of the earth will not go up to Jerusalem to worship Yahweh. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [if any of the clans of the earth do not go up to Jerusalem to bow down to the King, Yahweh of Armies, then on them there will not be the rain]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Zechariah 14:17 (#2)

וְלֹא עֲלֵיהֶם יִהְיֶה הַגָּשֶׁם

“on them there will not be the rain”

The implication is that without rain the crops of those people will fail, and so this will be a punishment for them. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [on them there will not be the rain, and as a punishment their crops will not grow]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:18 (#1)

לֹא־תַעֲלֶה וְלֹא בָאָה

“does not go up and does not come”

The terms **does not go up** and **does not come** mean similar things. Zechariah is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [does not come at all]

See: Doublet

Zechariah 14:18 (#2)

וְלֹא עֲלֵיהֶם

“then not on them”

This could mean: (1) Yahweh will judge Egypt by plague instead of withholding rain, since rain is not how Egypt

grows crops. See the UST. (2) Yahweh will also withhold rain from southern Egypt that feeds the Nile River that the people of Egypt water their crops from rather than from direct rain. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [then the rain will not replenish the Nile either]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:19 (#1)

זֹאת תִּהְיֶה חַטַּאת מִצְרָיִם וְחַטַּאת כָּל־הַגּוֹיִם

“This will be the sin of Egypt and the sin of all the nations”

Here, **the sin** represents the punishment for sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [This will be the punishment of Egypt and the punishment of all the nations]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:20 (#1)

עַל־מְצִלּוֹת הַסּוּס קֹדֶשׁ לַיהוָה

“on the bells of the horse, “Holy to Yahweh”

The implication is that things which were very common will become holy. Someone will engrave the words “Holy to Yahweh” on the bells, just as those words were engraved on the turban of the high priest. To transfer something so holy to something so common would have been somewhat shocking to the original audience. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [on the common bells of the horse, someone will carve an inscription reading, “Holy to Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Zechariah 14:20 (#2)

וְהָיוּ הַסִּירוֹת בְּבֵית יְהוָה כַּמִּזְרָקִים לִפְנֵי הַמִּזְבֵּחַ

“And the pots in the house of Yahweh will be like the bowls to the face of the altar”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the bowls** that the priests use at the altar are sacred, so **the pots in the house of Yahweh** will be sacred. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And the pots in the house of Yahweh will be just as holy as the bowls that are before the altar]

See: Simile

Zechariah 14:20 (#3)

לִפְנֵי הַמִּזְבֵּחַ

“to the face of the altar”

Here, **the face of the altar** represents “the front of the altar.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before the altar]

See: Metonymy

Zechariah 14:21 (#1)

וְלָקְחוּ מֵהֶם וּבִשְּׁלוּ בָהֶם

“and will take from them and will boil in them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the pots in Jerusalem and in Judah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and will take a few of those pots and will boil their sacrifices in them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Zechariah 14:21 (#2)

כְּנַעֲנִי

“a Canaanite”

Zechariah is not referring to a specific **Canaanite**. He means Canaanites in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any Canaanites]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Zechariah 14:21 (#3)

וְלֹא־יִהְיֶה כְנַעֲנִי עוֹד בְּבֵית־יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

“And there will not be a Canaanite again in the house of Yahweh of Armies”

Here, **a Canaanite** represents someone who does not belong in the house of Yahweh. You may wish to add a footnote here with the meaning you do not choose. This could mean: (1) a trader or merchant, since the Canaanites were well known as traders, Alternate translation: [there will not be a trader again in the house of Yahweh of Armies] or (2) an unclean foreigner. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [there will not be a unclean foreigner again in the house of Yahweh of Armies]

See: Metonymy